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EXPRESS investigation

Who will be held accountable for exam paper leaks? Don't bet on it, records show most get away

Number of exam leaks from 2002 to 2025 with candidate count above 1 lakh in each: 45. Number of cases that led to convictions: 2

Shyam Lal Yadav
& Jay Mazoomdar
New Delhi, June 4

FOR THE 22 lakh medical college candidates forced to put their dreams on hold until the NEET UG retest on June 21, for the 4 lakh CBSE students left in limbo after questions were raised over the new marking system, the real test now is not just of merit — but of faith in a system.

The CBSE's chairman and secretary may have been transferred but once the outrage dies down, chances are few will actually be held accountable. That's what the record shows.

The Indian Express investigated the status of cases linked to 45 major exam paper leaks over the past two decades in which each exam had at least 1 lakh applicants or candidates. The findings are stark: Only two of these cases have led to convictions. Most of the rest are either



Students protest in Delhi. Investigators warn leak networks are getting more sophisticated. SHREYA SINGHAI

RELATED REPORT

45 MAJOR LEAKS, FEW TOP OFFICIALS FACE ACTION [PAGES 8](#)

trapped in legal quicksand or have simply hit a dead end. If that's an indication of the low level of accountability, consider

this as an index of immunity: two of the accused in exam leaks are now MLAs in UP.

This newspaper scrutinised case records from 2002 to 2025, covering 27 job recruitment exams and 18 higher-education entrance tests and school board examinations, and spoke to investigators and senior government officials. The findings: At

Poor Score

24 YEARS (2002-2025)

45* job, education exam leaks	3.86 crore aspirants
Arrested	1,658
Chargesheeted	925
Convicted (2 cases)	18
In judicial custody	43

* With at least 1 lakh candidates in each

least 1,658 people arrested, 925 charge-sheeted, 18 convicted in two cases, 32 acquitted in two cases, and 43 still in judicial custody. And yet, only a tiny clutch of senior officials faced action (see related report on page 8).

But more than the numbers, it's the human cost that stings: More than 3.86 crore aspirants

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ACTING PRESIDENT ON INDIA VISIT

Venezuela, India in talks for long-term energy pacts



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Venezuela's Acting President Delcy Rodriguez in New Delhi on Thursday. ANIL SHARMA

Rodriguez, Modi hold discussions; tech team to go to Venezuela: Puri

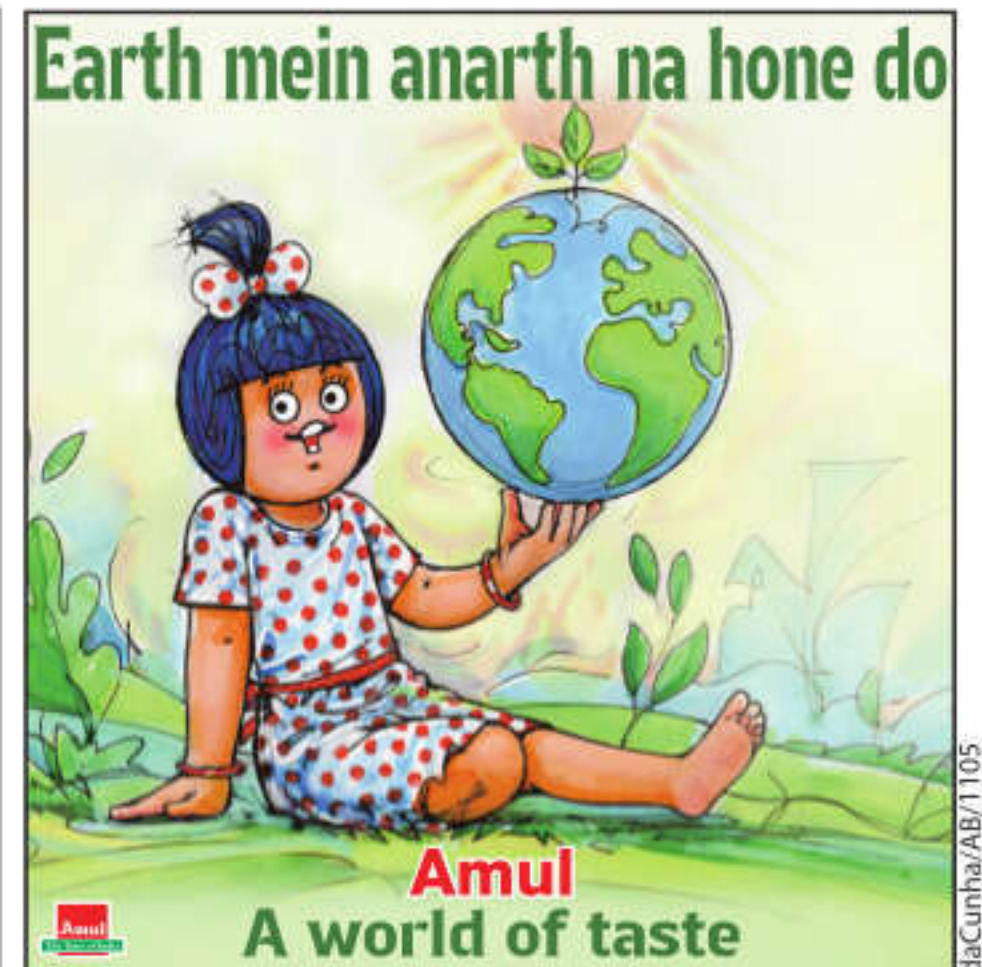
Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 4

INDIA AND Venezuela Thursday discussed "forging an energy partnership" and entering into "long-term contracts" as Delcy Rodriguez, on her first trip to India after becoming Acting President of her country, held talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi in New Delhi.

Rodriguez took charge of Venezuela after President Nicolas Maduro was abducted by US forces in a military operation in January this year.

After meeting Rodriguez, Modi, in a post on X, said, "We had extensive discussions on expanding our cooperation in energy, critical minerals, technology, agriculture, health and people-to-people ties."

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GOLD EXPORTER UNDER SEBI LENS

In last 10 yrs, mutual funds avoided Rajesh Exports, LIC stake up 5 times to 10.8%

George Mathew
& Sandeep Singh
Mumbai, June 4

RAJESH Exports, under the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) scanner for allegedly inflating revenues by Rs 15.15 lakh crore over FY21 to FY25, was listed more than three decades ago in 1995. But domestic institutional investors, barring one, kept away from its stock for at least the last 10 years, according to shareholding data obtained from the company's website.

A look at the domestic institutional holding in the Rajesh Mehta-promoted Rajesh Exports, a gold and jewellery ex-

E. EXPLAINED

High revenues, low profits

The Sebi action has cast a harsh spotlight on Rajesh Mehta's stewardship of a company celebrated for its scale but questioned for its unusually thin profit margins.

porter, shows mutual funds' maximum exposure in the company was at 0.5% in March 2016; it has only dipped since

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Happening today

● **RESERVE BANK** of India Governor Sanjay Malhotra will announce the decision of the six-member Monetary Policy Committee amid expectations that the key interest rate will be left unchanged at 5.25 per cent.

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



INSIDE [PAGES 6, 11](#)

SETBACK FOR OPP AS DMK TO SKIP INDIA BLOC MEETING

MONSOON HITS KERALA; HEAVY RAINFALL UNTIL JUNE 7, SAYS IMD

Army chief: Accelerating absorption of drones, better command systems

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, June 4

UNDERLINING THAT the Indian Army has accelerated the absorption of drones, UAVs, loitering munitions and counter-UAS systems in a structured manner, Army chief General Upendra Dwivedi said Thursday that the larger aim of the Army is not merely to procure drones, but to absorb them into the way the Army trains, operates and fights.

In an interview with *The Indian Express*, General Dwivedi said the procurement and in-



General Upendra Dwivedi

duction of drones cover a wide range of capabilities, that the Army is also introducing better command and control arrangements for a drone-dense battle-

field, including a Unified Control Centre at division levels to manage the growing number of UAS and C-UAS systems at the tactical level.

General Dwivedi is set to retire as the Army chief at the end of this month. Much of the Army's accelerated move towards procuring and inducting drones, unmanned aerial systems, loitering munitions and counter-drone capabilities have gathered pace during his tenure in the last two years. Various structures, procedures and command systems needed

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

AMONG 21 WHO PERISHED IN SOUTH DELHI FIRE

'Can't forget her screams': TISS postgrad, new job, a life cut short

Pallavi Smart & Drishti Jain
Mumbai, New Delhi, June 4

FOR SHRUTIKA Baranwal, a 25-year-old from Bokaro in Jharkhand, the world was waiting.

A post-graduate from the Tata Institute of Social Sciences in Mumbai, she had already landed a job in the city through campus placement. The Master's degree in Water Policy and Governance was to be conferred later at a convocation.

Hired by the Rubber, Chemical & Polymer Skill Development Council, Shrutika travelled to Delhi to complete induction formalities and be



At a condolence meeting in Mumbai Thursday. PALLAVI SMART

back in Mumbai to start her career.

But that was not to be. She was one of the 21 who perished Wednesday in the fire that en-

gulfed a B&B facility in Hauz Rani in South Delhi — she was one of the few who had checked in on a work-related visit.

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POLICE: OWNER WENT TO HOTEL, SAW IT BURNING AND LEFT

AMONG THE DEAD: KYRGYZSTAN WOMAN WAITING TO GO HOME AFTER TRANSPLANT, HER SON AND MOTHER

● { MARJANE SATRAPI • 1969-2026 }

'What can I do to offer a little bit of a dream to people?': *Persepolis* author dies of 'sadness'

Paromita Chakrabarti
New Delhi, June 4

IN JANUARY 2016, Marjane Satrapi was in New Delhi after days of location and talent scouting for the cinematic adaptation of French writer Romain Puértolas's *The Extraordinary Journey of The Fakir*. Who Got Trapped in an Ikea Cupboard that she was to direct. She had got on board actor Dhanush for the lead, talks were on with Uma Thur-

man, and the then 46-year-old was looking forward to the start of the shooting schedule in Jodhpur later in the summer.

It had been well over a decade since the publication of *Persepolis*, her graphic novel in two parts, about an Iranian girl coming of age during the Islamic Revolution and the Iran-Iraq War but its

towering success notwithstanding, the French-Iranian graphic novelist-and-filmmaker declared that she had no interest



Marjane Satrapi took world inside post-revolution Iran, amplified sorrows, demands of its women. AP FILE

to the art form any more.

"I am like a car that cannot drive back. Once something is finished, it's finished. You know all these people who get divorced and then get married to the same guy? If you want to get remarried, at least try someone new. I don't like to go back to doing the same thing, so I don't think I will make comic books (she preferred the term to 'graphic novels') anymore. It was very pleasant, I was very happy doing it, now I want to

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

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Lack of preparation stopping India from becoming Vishwaguru: Bhagwat

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, June 4

INDUSTRIALIST KUMAR Mangalam Birla and RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat on Thursday flagged the economic challenges confronting India amid growing instability in West Asia and argued that the country must build greater national capabilities to seize emerging opportunities. Bhagwat said India had not yet become a Vishwaguru because it was still inadequately prepared.

The two were speaking at the valedictory function of an RSS training programme in Nagpur. “Even though these are challenging times, this is India’s era. The world has been caught between the competing ambitions of superpowers. In the past three years, prices of crude oil have skyrocketed either because of wars or market fluctuations. Supply chains are once again stressed — for the third time in this decade. And finally, AI is at our doorstep. This AI revolution is likely to transform economies and impact many more people than any other recent technological invention,” Birla, the chief guest at the event, said. Birla said the current phase of global uncertainty had come at a crucial juncture for India. “And the challenge for India is that this flux exists at the time when India is set to begin its Amrit Kaal. But the biggest les-



RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat and industrialist Kumar Mangalam Birla in Nagpur on Thursday. PTI

son that history teaches us is the importance of building national capability and national resilience,” he said. Arguing that business-building contributes to nation-building, Birla said: “A futurist from the US has said that the world will experience 100 years of progress in the next 10 years. The question before us is not whether the future will arrive. It already has. The question is whether we have the courage to build upon it, the imagination to shape it and the determination to ensure that it serves the aspirations of 1.4 billion Indians.” Echoing Birla’s remarks, Bhagwat said India’s moment had arrived but the country still lacked the preparedness required to lead the world. “The world says that it needs a new path (of development) and only India can show that path. And so India’s time has come. But that is not enough. You have to

be prepared for that time. The chief guest is right, the future has already arrived. The future is waiting for us to be prepared. We have been saying for a long time that India is Vishwaguru, India has to become Vishwaguru, we have to make India Vishwaguru. So what is stopping us? Our preparation... it is still incomplete,” he said. The remarks assume significance at a time when India faces multiple economic challenges. Rising crude oil prices have widened pressures on the current account, while slowing capital inflows have raised concerns about external sector vulnerabilities. Bhagwat said India must become prosperous and powerful while remaining rooted in its civilisational values. “The world listens to those who have power. It knows what India is saying is right. But arguments are not accepted because they are right. Arguments are accepted because the one making them is holding the lathi (baton),” he said. “We are seeing this. Those with power are doing whatever they feel like. Those who are not powerful are accepting everything meekly. You can annex a country... you can bomb another... or just stop the world’s oil supply. All of this is a game of power. When a powerful India rises, then the world will get a new path. India will have to stand on its feet in its own way,” he added

‘India reliable partner’: Putin blasts Western interference in Moscow-Delhi relations

Press Trust of India
St Petersburg, June 4

RUSSIAN PRESIDENT Vladimir Putin on Thursday hailed Moscow’s strategic partnership with New Delhi and asserted that Western attempts to force India into scaling back its cooperation with Russia are futile and damaging to global stability. In an interaction with heads of leading global news agencies including PTI, Putin lauded India’s economic growth and its independent foreign policy and said Russia is determined to expand its economic engagement with the nation. “India is among the world’s major economies and is demonstrating an impressive rate of economic growth,” Putin remarked, expressing confidence that bilateral trade between the two nations is on track to hit a USD 100 billion milestone in the coming years. “India is one of the leading

economies of the world that has showed the highest rate of economic growth. This is not something that comes out of the blue. This is result of the hardwork that the government of India has been doing under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi,” Putin said. “We are glad that India is developing its relations with all countries it thinks important for its national interests,” Putin said when asked whether India’s deep alignment with Washington creates structural friction for Russia. At the same time the Russian president added that there have been Western attempts to put pressure on when it comes to cooperation with Russia. “Everyone has understood that pressure on PM Narendra Modi and India is detrimental for international ties.” Putin said Russia considers India as a “reliable partner”.

2018 UAPA case: 3 Kashmiri students get 10-year jail

Express News Service
Mohali, June 4

A SPECIAL NIA court in Mohali on Thursday sentenced three students from Awantipora in J&K’s Pulwama to 10 years of RI for conspiring to wage war against India and collecting arms and explosives as part of a terror plot linked to the banned outfit Ansar Ghazwat-ul-Hind (AGH). Police had booked them under the UAPA after they were arrested with arms, ammunition and explosives from the hostel room of an engineering college in Jalandhar in October 2018. Special Judge Dinesh Kumar Wadhwa announced the quantum of punishment a day after he held Zahid Gulzar, Yasir Rafiq Bhat and Mohammad Idris Shah guilty under sections 18 and 20 of the UAPA for conspiracy, abetment to a terrorist act and membership of a terrorist organisation; IPC sections 121-A (conspiracy to wage war against the Government of India), 122 (collecting men, arms or ammunition with the intention of waging war) and 120-B (criminal conspiracy); Section 25(A-1) (possession and handling of prohibited arms or ammunition without authorisation) of the Arms Act; and Section 5 (possessing explosive substances or for unlawful purposes) of the Explosive Substances Act. However, the court acquitted another accused, Suhail Ahmed Bhat, holding that the prosecution had failed to establish the charges framed against him beyond reasonable doubt. Zahid, Yasir and Idris have been in judicial custody since October 10, 2018.

Cops escorting body of man killed in ‘encounter’ attacked by mob

Express News Service
Lucknow, June 4

A DAY after a man accused of murdering a hotelier’s son was killed in an alleged encounter, a mob attacked the police team which was escorting the body of the accused for cremation in UP’s Ghazipur district, police said. Two policemen were also injured in the attack. The deceased, Kamlesh Chaudhary, was killed in an encounter on Wednesday in Ghazipur. According to officers, a group of 100 people allegedly attacked the police personnel escorting the funeral procession and hurled stones at them, claiming that the encounter in which Chaudhary was killed had been staged. Following the incident, the body was transported to the cremation ground, where the final rites were conducted.

India, Venezuela

“As a valued partner in Latin America, our close cooperation with Venezuela holds immense importance for the Global South. We will continue to work together for the mutual benefit of the people of our nations,” he said.

Asked whether the leaders discussed the issue of Maduro, Rudrendra Tandon, Secretary (East) in the Ministry of External Affairs, said, “Coming to the political transition, of course, this was a very frank conversation that the two leaders had, both during when all of us were there, as well as on the table when they were having their working lunch, but I don’t think that I should, you know, get into those sort of things.”

“We all know that there was a transition in Venezuela. But we are working with a government that is friendly, that wants a partnership with India. We want to reciprocate that, and don’t forget that Venezuela has been traditionally a very close friend. Bilaterally, we have done a lot of partnerships, and at the international level, we have collaborated very closely... you are just going back to normal,” he said.

Tandon said Venezuela views India as a “preferred partner” and “India has stood with Venezuela in bad times as well as in good times”.

On the energy relationship between India and Venezuela, he said, “Venezuela possesses one of the largest oil reserves in the world. The Indian economy is a large and growing consumer of oil and will have a stable demand growth for many years to come. Thus, in the energy sector, we see a perfect complementarity. In fact, in our spot purchases, Venezuela has already emerged as the third largest supplier this month, so quite naturally today’s discussions focused on forging an energy partnership.” “It is in their interest to enter into long-term contracts rather

than to do spot buying. So we hope that at some stage we move forward to long-term secure supplies from all our suppliers,” he said.

With Venezuela’s energy sector undergoing a massive restructuring where major reforms are being implemented to open both the oil and electricity markets to private capital, Tandon said, “We are not going into details of the conversation. What did emerge from the interaction of the two leaders was that the Venezuelan energy sector is undergoing a fundamental transformation... There exists a perfect complementarity for India and Venezuela to work in the energy sector both upstream as well as downstream.”

“The discussion on the energy sector was extensive. The talk of partnership was not just buyer-seller, it was participation of Indian companies upstream and downstream in all its aspects. Of course, the details of this cannot be worked out at the Prime Minister level. This will have to be taken up by the companies themselves, but the message that came across very clearly from the Venezuelan side is that they are open for business, they are reforming their industry, so there are great opportunities for India. And our response to that was that we are willing, our companies are willing, and we will take steps to facilitate that as a government.”

“But ultimately, it is a commercial decision that Indian companies in the energy sector will have to take on the discounts. Payments will be done in the way the companies want. The Government of India, because of the developments in the Middle East, is aggressively seeking out new sources of crude oil and energy to ensure India’s energy security. So, Venezuela is an opportunity, and it is very much part of our plan,” he said.

Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri, who called on Rodriguez along with ministry offi-

cials and CMDs of energy PSUs, said, “India has a long standing energy partnership with Venezuela since 2008 and shares unique complementarities with the country.”

“Venezuela possesses the biggest proven reserves of oil in the world, while India not only possesses huge demand for energy but also has the technological expertise and manpower to refine Venezuelan crude in our refineries,” he said in a post on X.

Venezuela, Puri said, was among the largest crude oil suppliers to India in April and May this year, “a reflection of the future potential”. He said an Indian technical team will visit Venezuela soon to “further explore this potential”.

According to Tandon, the two sides also discussed cooperation in areas including critical minerals, gold and diamond mining, animal husbandry, transportation, agriculture equipment, automotive sector, and pharmaceuticals.

“Pharmaceuticals was discussed in quite a lot of detail, particularly the ability of Indian manufacturers to provide high quality generic drugs at low cost to their public health services, which is a very important part. In fact, this was listed by the Venezuelan delegation as one of the priority areas, so much so that the Prime Minister actually directed that one of her ministers, who is accompanying her, should be exposed to our entire Jan Aushadhi scheme.”

Accompanying Rodriguez is a ministerial delegation that includes ministers of foreign affairs, communication and information, economy and finance, science and technology, and the transportation.

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, who also called on Rodriguez, later said, “Deeply value her longstanding commitment to the India-Venezuela relationship.”

Rodriguez, who has been to India at least six times in the past, is expected to travel to Ahmedabad, Bengaluru and Mumbai.

Marjane Satrapi

make movies. Cinema is a medium for creating compassion,” she told *The Indian Express* during an interaction at a hotel in Chanakyapuri.

Satrapi eventually left the project that ended up being directed by Canadian filmmaker Ken Scott but her advocacy of compassion and freedom and her penchant for speaking her mind remained with her till the end.

On Thursday, the office of French President Emmanuel Macron announced her death. Satrapi was 56.

(The news agency *Reuters* adds: A statement released by members of her family to the French news agency AFP said she had died of “sadness” a little over a year after the death of her husband, Swedish actor, producer and screenwriter Mattias Ripa.)

Satrapi moved to France in 1994 and became a citizen in 2006. *Persepolis*, which served both as memoir and history, recounts the story of her early life in Tehran, struggling under the growing authoritarianism of Iran’s theocratic government after the 1979 Revolution, up until she begins a life as an exile in Europe. The two volumes of the book, published in English in 2003 and 2004 respectively, were followed by *Embroideries* (2003), another graphic novel that explores women’s lives and feminism in Iran, as well as *Chicken with Plums* (2006). Her

career as a filmmaker included *Persepolis* (2007), *Chicken with Plums* (2011), *The Voices* (2014), *Radioactive* (2019) and *Dear Paris* (2024).

Born into an upper-middle class politically active family, she grew up in Tehran. Her parents encouraged her to be independent and free-thinking. But the Iranian revolution of 1979 upended their world. The increasing crackdown on civil liberties, the repression of political activists, the steady erosion of women’s rights, her growing anger and immersion in political protests eventually made her parents send her to Austria, and later, to France.

Satrapi forever carried in her heart the memories of those decades, remaining a life-long critic of Iran’s Islamic leadership. In 2022, following the death of 22-year-old Kurdish woman Mahsa Amini while in custody of Iran’s morality policy for allegedly breaching the dress code, as huge protests broke out across Iran, demanding *jinn, jivan, azadi* (women, life, freedom), Satrapi stood in solidarity with them. She participated in protests in Paris, curated and edited an anthology of graphic nonfiction, *Woman, Life, Freedom*, and amplified their sorrows and demands among the diaspora.

And yet, she held that active politics had never interested her. In the 2016 interview, she had said, “To be in politics, you have to love power, and I really hate

power... A long time ago, I was very much into politics because I believed that with politics you can change the world. In reality, it was not me who was changing the world. Getting close to politics was changing me. I became extremely cynical and then you are like, okay, so what can I do to offer a little bit of a dream to people?”

France offered her that creative and emotional succour. It was in Paris that she met her husband, Mattias Ripa, with whom she worked on many award-winning projects, and whose death in April 2025 left her heartbroken.

But even in a country that felt like home, she wore her scepticism like second skin. Last year, Satrapi refused to accept the Legion of Honour, France’s highest order of merit, citing the country’s hypocritical attitude toward Iran.

In the 2016 interview, looking back at the woman she had been in Iran to the person she was then, Satrapi had said, “I was an angry person. Even if it doesn’t look like it, I am calmer now. There are certain things that don’t change though. I really never believe in what people tell me, like the idea of the majority. I remember even when I was a child and I was told, ‘The majority of people think...’ I was like, if the majority was right, we should live in f***** paradise and we don’t live in f***** paradise, which means the majority of the people are wrong. I never believe what they tell me and that is what will probably never change.”

Rajesh Exports: LIC stake up 5 times

and is nil now.

While private sector insurance companies too have no holding in the firm, state-owned LIC has been the only big domestic institutional investor over these years. In fact, LIC’s stake in Rajesh Exports more than quintupled from 1.99% in March 2016 to 11.22% in March 2022. Since then it has marginally dropped to 10.8% as on March 31, 2026.

A questionnaire mailed to LIC did not elicit a response.

Foreign portfolio investors have held between 15.87% in March 2016 and 17.7% in March 2023. Over the last three years, their holding dropped to 14.2% in March 2026; much of this is held by just two FPIs, Bridge India Fund (8.46%) and Schwab Fundamental Emerging Market Equity ETF (2.7%).

When contacted, leading MFs and brokers said they were not comfortable investing in the company. “We were never confident of their numbers and so it never made the cut on that account,” said the CEO of a leading mutual fund, who did not wish to be named.

The CEO of a leading broking firm said, “The SEBI order did not come as a shocker. Huge turnover and thin margins never made sense. Few domestic institutional investors trusted the numbers.”

Another gold exporter said Mehta maintained a low profile, but was ambitious. “In the early years, he would pitch Rajesh Exports as one that would overtake Titan, which was also into jewellery business,” the exporter said.

In its interim order on Wednesday, SEBI said Rajesh Ex-

ports overstated revenues and barred Mehta from buying, selling or dealing in the securities of Rajesh Exports pending further proceedings. It also ordered a fresh forensic audit of the company’s books.

Rajesh Exports, however, denied SEBI’s findings. In a press statement, it said, “The revenues stated by the company in its financials are correct. The core observation in the order is with regard to the mis-reporting of the revenues, this has emerged primarily due to confusion because SEBI has considered the EBIDTA of Valcambi instead of revenue hence it has stated that there is a difference of about 97% in the revenue.” Valcambi is a Swiss gold refiner acquired by Rajesh Exports in 2015 for \$400 million.

Accelerating drone absorption, better command and control systems: Army chief

to absorb them into the force have also been set up during this time.

Declining to comment on the numbers and the cost of the drones procured by the Army, he said what is important is the absorption of drones, UAVs, loitering munitions and counter-UAS systems in a structured manner.

A wide range of capabilities, he said, have been bought and inducted, including micro and mini-UAVs for units, tactical drones for surveillance and target acquisition, logistics drones for difficult terrain, high-altitude surveillance platforms, loitering munitions for precision engagement, and counter-UAS systems such as sensors, jammers, spoofers and soft-kill and hard-kill options.

“Our approach is tiered, role-based and terrain-specific. At the infantry battalion level, Ashni drone platoons are being integrated to provide organic surveillance, target acquisition and tactical awareness. This will give the soldier and small team their own aerial awareness and tactical reach, an idea we have described as ‘Eagle on the Arm’, he said.

“At the formation level, larger UAVs, loitering munitions and counter-UAS systems are being linked with artillery, air defence, aviation, intelligence and electronic warfare grids,” he said, adding that the aim is to shorten the sensor-to-shooter cycle and give commanders real-time battlefield awareness.

General Dwivedi said the Shaktibaan Regiments and Divyastra Batteries of the Army are also part of this restructuring in the Regiment of Artillery. “They will strengthen unmanned and counter-unmanned capability, precision targeting and protection against hostile drone threats. The larger aim is not merely to procure drones, but to absorb them in the way the Army trains, operates and fights,” he said.

“We are also introducing better command and control arrangements for the drone-dense battlefield. The concept of a Unified Control Centre (UCC) at division levels has been introduced to manage the growing number of UAS and C-UAS systems at the tactical level,” he said, adding that this will help in coordination, deconfliction, tasking and optimum employment of unmanned assets. Responding to a question on the broader changes in the Army based on lessons from Operation Sindoor and ongoing global conflicts, he said it has reinforced the belief that future conflicts will be multi-domain, technology-intensive, fast-paced and increasingly transparent.

“The lessons are being incorporated into doctrine, training, exercises, SOPs, procurement priorities and force structuring,” he said.

He said the focus areas of the Army’s capability-based approach include multi-sensor surveillance, drones, loitering munitions, counter-UAS systems, long-range precision fires, air defence, cyber, electronic warfare, secure communications and AI-enabled decision-support systems.

Operation Sindoor, he said, also validated the importance of integrated planning, real-time intelligence fusion, secure communications, precision weapons, drones, loitering munitions and compressed decision cycles. “It reinforced the need for faster R&D, better quality systems, timely delivery and stronger integration among air defence, artillery, aviation, intelligence and electronic warfare assets,” he said.

Similarly, global conflicts have also shown that drones are not only platforms but consumables. “Therefore, inventory depth, modular designs, rapid repair chains and assured component supply are important. This strengthens the case for Atmanirbharta, because Indian solutions are required for Indian terrain, threats and operational conditions.” Alongside technology, he said, the Army is strengthening mobility, survivability, logistics, surveillance architecture and communication networks to support faster mobilisation and sustained operations.

“Deployment postures are being kept flexible and balanced so that formations remain prepared for both short, high-intensity operations and longer contingencies. The larger aim is to make the Army more agile, networked, integrated and adaptive,” he said.

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“Deployment postures are being kept flexible and balanced so that formations remain prepared for both short, high-intensity operations and longer contingencies. The larger aim is to make the Army more agile, networked, integrated and adaptive,” he said. Asked about possible tweaks in the Agnipath scheme, General Dwivedi said the scheme should be seen as a major manpower reform aimed at making the Army younger, more energetic, disciplined and future-ready.

“The character of warfare is changing rapidly, and we need soldiers who are not only physically fit, but also technology-aware and capable of adapting quickly to drones, surveillance systems, secure communication networks, electronic warfare and modern battlefield tools,” he said, adding that Agniveers are making a positive contribution to the Army.

At the same time, the scheme, he said, is an evolutionary process. “The full cycle of the first batch is yet to be completed, and therefore it would be premature to arrive at a conclusion,” he said, adding that any decision on tweaks or refinements should be based on time, experience, operational feedback and institutional assessment.

Delhi fire: TISS postgrad with a new job, life cut short

unlike the majority who were staying there for treatment in nearby hospitals or had accompanied patients.

Shrutika was on the phone with her friend and batchmate Aman Singh when the fire broke out. “I cannot forget those screams. I lost contact with her. When I was unable to reconnect the call, I spoke to a friend who knew where she was stayed in Delhi and we contacted the police. Within a few minutes, they called and informed us about the fire,” he said.

Aman and Shrutika’s friends informed her family and her cousins in Delhi. From a middle-class family in Bokaro, Shrutika, her friends recalled, joined TISS in the hope of securing a good placement. She was very excited when she landed a job.

Ritika Agrawal (25), who shared a room with her for a year in college, remembers her as someone full of life. “Even if she would go wrong, she would take it sportingly. She was a safe space and a great listener... She

was visiting Delhi for office work,” she said.

Pranjal Deekshit, chairperson of the TISS Centre for Water Policy and Governance, said, “Shrutika was a very sincere student who would proactively take part in various initiatives. She had secured a placement at the Rubber, Chemical & Polymer Skill Development Council and was excited. She was doing great work in the area of groundwater preservation. Her Master’s dissertation on shallow aquifer management in Dhanbad was well-appreciated by faculty as well as those working in the field.”

Eklavya Prasad, managing trustee of the Megh Pyne Abhiyan, an organisation actively working in this sector in Dhanbad, had guided Shrutika for the dissertation. “Her work and involvement in the field were really commendable. She was not working to tick boxes, but with complete interest and purpose, wanting to bring about a change, and with a spark we require in the social sector,” Prasad said.

UNDER-CONSTRUCTION FLYOVER LINKING JEWAR AIRPORT TO FARIDABAD

3 workers killed, many feared trapped as crane overturns

Police suspect bad weather may have caused the incident

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Faridabad, June 4

AT LEAST three labourers were killed and several were feared trapped after a crane involved in the construction of a flyover connecting the Noida International Airport in Jewar to Faridabad lost balance and overturned on Thursday afternoon, said police. Massive rescue efforts were launched, said officers.

The incident took place at Panhera Khurd village in Faridabad district, said police, adding that only one worker was rescued alive till around 10:30 pm.

Speaking with *The Indian Express*, Deputy Commissioner of Police (Ballabhgarh) Pratik Aggarwal said the incident occurred around 3 pm.

“Our team received the information around 4 pm, and immediately reached the spot with rescue teams. A crane fell on the container inside which the labourers were working. Unfortunately, the impact was such that the entry inside the container became a challenge. We are trying to get the front and back of the container cut so we can rescue all those trapped soon,” the DCP said.

He added that the crane may have crashed onto the container due to adverse weather conditions. According to eyewitnesses, heavy rain during



An ambulance arrives at the site in Faridabad on Thursday; (top) the crane after it collapsed. PTI/ANI

the day had made the construction site muddy and slippery.

“Rescue teams of the State Disaster Response Force

(SDRF) and National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) are at the spot, along with National Highway Authority of India (NHAI) representatives, and police personnel,” a spokesperson of Faridabad Police said. Further probe about the exact cause of the incident is under investigation.

In a similar incident in March, seven migrant labourers were killed and four were injured when an under construction wall at a sewage treatment plant (STP) site caved in, triggering a soil collapse in Signature Global society at Sidhrawali village in Gurgaon. Around 15-20 labourers were working at the site when the wall crashed at the construction site.



Barricades and mangled hoardings lie on a street in Noida on Thursday. GAJENDRA YADAV

Dip in temperature, gusts with speed up to 90 kmph: Rain lashes Delhi-NCR

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, June 4

THUNDERSTORMS ACCOMPANIED by rain, lightning and gusty winds swept across Delhi-NCR on Thursday afternoon as respite from severe heat continued. With the fresh spell of rain, various parts of the Capital saw a significant drop in temperature, ranging from 9 degrees Celsius to up to 19 degrees Celsius.

According to the India Meteorological Department’s (IMD) weather bulletin, there have been several systems affecting northwest India, including a Western Disturbance over north Pakistan, an induced cyclonic circulation over central Pakistan, and upper-air cyclonic circulations over north Haryana and central Uttar Pradesh. All these weather systems create favourable conditions for thunderstorms to occur, officials said.

In its weather bulletin, the IMD had earlier in the day issued a red alert for the Capital, warning of hail and potentially damaging squally winds of up to 100 kmph in several parts of the Capital. As storm activity intensified over the city and adjoining NCR areas, the weather office issued successive alerts. This was reduced later in the evening to orange alert.

Wind speeds strengthened across the Capital through the afternoon. Pitampura recorded a maximum wind speed of 56 kmph, followed by Pragati Maidan at 52 kmph, Pusa at



Overcast skies loom over India Gate in New Delhi on Thursday. PTI

50 kmph, Palam at 48 kmph and Mehrauli at 46 kmph. Safdarjung, Delhi’s base weather station, recorded winds of 36 kmph.

IMD officials said wind speeds reached as high as 93 kmph in Gautam Buddha Nagar.

According to IMD observations until 2.30 pm, Ayanagar received 14.2 mm of rainfall, the highest among city stations, followed by Palam with 5.8 mm, Mayur Vihar with 2.5 mm and Najafgarh with 1.5 mm.

The thunderstorms and rain, as a result, brought a sharp drop in temperatures across Delhi-NCR in a span of about two hours. According to IMD data, Ayanagar recorded the

steepest fall, with temperatures plunging from 41.7 degrees Celsius before the storm to 22.7 degrees Celsius afterwards — a drop of 19 degrees.

Safdarjung, Delhi based station, saw a temperature drop of nine degrees Celsius from 40 to 31 degrees Celsius.

Mayur Vihar witnessed a fall of 14.9 degrees, Pushp Vihar 14.8 degrees, the Sports Complex station 14.6 degrees and Mungeshpur 14.4 degrees. In NCR, Gurgaon recorded a temperature drop of 15.5 degrees, from 38.4 degrees Celsius to 22.9 degrees Celsius, while Hindon saw temperatures fall by 15.2 degrees. The temperatures in Gautam Buddha Nagar fell by 15.7 degrees Celsius (from

• Skywatch



Forecast: June 5, 2026:

Cloudy sky. Light rain with thunderstorm, lightning.

MAX: 36-38

2° below normal

MIN: 23-25

1.9°C below normal

• AQI Tracker



Anand Vihar
Poor
AQI: 240



Bawana
Moderate
AQI: 167



ITO
Moderate
AQI: 135



Dwarka
Moderate
AQI: 199

- Good (0-50)
- Satisfactory (51-100)
- Moderate (101-200)
- Poor (201-300)
- Very Poor (301-400)
- Severe (401-500)

37.3 to 21.6 degrees).

Earlier, in its district-level alerts issued at 2.45 pm and valid till 5.45 pm, the IMD placed all districts of Delhi under the red category, forecasting light to moderate rainfall accompanied by moderate to severe thunderstorms, lightning and gusty winds of 50-60 kmph, gusting up to 70 kmph.

DU assistant professor found murdered in flat

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 4

AN ASSISTANT professor at a Delhi University college was found murdered at her East Delhi apartment on Thursday afternoon, with preliminary investigations indicating that she was attacked with a blunt object on the head, police sources said.

The deceased, identified as Devosmita Paul, an assistant professor at Shivaji College, was living alone in a flat at Satyam Apartment in Vasundhara Enclave, police said. Her husband

stays in Bengaluru.

Officers said that a PCR call was received around 2:35 pm on Thursday from the deceased’s sister who alerted the police about the body inside her flat.

According to the police, the caller, Devarati Paul had been trying to get in touch with her sister since morning, but in vain. Devarati told police that her sister’s flat was locked from the outside.

Suspecting something might be wrong, Devarati broke the lock and entered the apartment, after which she dis-

covered her sister’s body, police said.

Investigators suspect that the victim, who was hit with a blunt object, sustained fatal injuries on the head. Police said that the exact cause and timing of the death will be ascertained after the post-mortem examination report arrives.

Sources said that, during the initial inspection, police did not find “any obvious sign of theft or ransacking in either of the rooms of the flat”.

No valuables have been reported missing so far, they said, adding that investigators have

not found any clue hinting at robbery either.

Police have registered a case under Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita Section 103(1), which pertains to murder, and have constituted multiple teams to identify and apprehend the offender. Officers said they are probing the case from all angles.

Those familiar with Devosmita remember her as a “private” and “reclusive” individual who largely kept to herself. Sources said she interacted with only a limited number of people and was not known to be socially active.

MORNING NIGHTMARE: DAY AFTER

Delhi CM meets injured, announces Rs 10 lakh ex-gratia for victim kin



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta at Max Hospital in Saket on Thursday.

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 4

ON THURSDAY, a day after 21 people were killed in a fire at Flourish Stays, a bed-and-breakfast facility in Malviya Nagar’s Hauz Rani in South Delhi, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced an ex-gratia of Rs 10 lakh for the kin of the deceased and Rs 5 lakh for those who sustained serious injuries.

Gupta, who visited Max Hospital in Saket to meet the injured victims, said it is due to corruption and negligence by some departments that the government has to face difficulties. “Strict and effective steps will have to be taken to prevent the recurrence of such incidents and the loss of life and property so that Delhi can become a safe Capital,” she said.

Noting that preliminary information had revealed several serious safety-related shortcomings, Gupta directed departments concerned to conduct a detailed probe into the incident and carry out a special audit of fire safety standards in hotels, commercial establishments and other public buildings across

Delhi. She said strict action would be taken if negligence or violation of rules are detected.

Officials said the CM will hold a high-level meeting with departments concerned on Friday to discuss the tragedy.

“...no building owner, official, or any other person found responsible for the Malviya Nagar fire incident will be spared,” said Gupta. Further, officials have been directed to make necessary arrangements to ensure the mortal remains of the deceased reach their families residing in other states or abroad.

Meanwhile, Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu chaired a high-level review meeting of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) to discuss a comprehensive action plan for stronger urban governance, improved civic infrastructure, and enhanced structural safety across Delhi.

Calling for a strict enforcement of building bylaws to curb illegal structural expansions, the LG directed the civic body to implement a time-bound strategy to tackle unauthorised constructions decisively, said officials from his office.

Committees formed to inspect & seal buildings flouting fire norms

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, June 4

A DAY after the fatal fire at a hotel in Hauz Rani, the Delhi government has formed 13 district-level and 39 sub-division-level committees to conduct a citywide survey of all buildings with six or more storeys (ground plus five floors), including hospitals and nursing homes, to find out if they are violating fire safety norms.

These will inspect and institute sealing actions under the extant legal framework relating to fire safety, building by-laws and applicable legislations.

According to an official order issued on Thursday, the district-level committees will comprise the District Magistrates of respective districts as the chairperson, MCD Deputy Commissioner, Deputy Commissioner of Police, and Divisional Officer, Fire.

The sub-division-level committees will each comprise the Sub-Divisional Magistrate (Revenue District) as the chairperson, MCD Assistant Commissioner, and Assistant Commissioner of Police.

Officials said the drive began Thursday and about nine B&B establishments in Malviya Nagar were evacuated.

Officials said that the district-level committees will supervise the sub-division-level committees. The sub-division-level committees will submit daily reports to the District Magistrates who will submit weekly reports to the Divisional Commissioner (Revenue) and Principal Secretary (Home).

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ADMISSION TO P.H.D. PROGRAMMES 2026
(Phase-I, July 2026 Intake)
Online applications are invited from eligible candidates for admission to the Ph.D. programmes for the academic session 2026-2027 (July 2026 intake) in the following departments: Biotechnology, Botany, Chemistry, Civil Engineering, Communication & Journalism, Commerce, Economics, Education, English, Information & Technology, Law, Management Studies, Mathematics, Physical Education, Physics, Politics & Governance, Philosophy & Religious Studies, Tourism Studies, Urdu & Zoology. Registration shall commence on June 2nd, 2026, and the closing date for registration is June 17th, 2026. For the detailed notification, including programmes, eligibility criteria, and general terms and conditions, candidates are advised to visit the university website at www.cukashmir.ac.in.
Dated: 01-06-2026
Director Admissions (I/C)

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PUBLIC NOTICE
Whereas, Ocimum Estates Private Limited (Ocimum) is undertaking the development of a Commercial Colony over an area admeasuring 2.38125 acres (0.9636 Hectors apprx.) in in the revenue estate of Daultabad, Sector 103, Gurugram, Haryana, in accordance with the provisions of License No. 144 of 2014, granted by the Director, Town & Country Planning, Haryana, Chandigarh (hereinafter referred to as “DTCP”).
And whereas, various persons have booked and/or have been allotted units in the aforesaid Commercial Colony (hereinafter collectively referred to as the “Existing Allottees”).
And whereas, Ocimum has proposed a change of developer in favour of Indiabulls Urbanheights Limited (IBUL), for which in-principle approval has been accorded by DTCP vide Memo No. LC-3121/JE(SJ)/2026/19407 dated 03.06.2026. The project is also registered with the Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority (HREERA) vide Registration No. RC/REP/HARERA/GGM/392/124/2020/08 dated 10.02.2020.
And whereas, vide the aforesaid Memo, DTCP has directed the issuance of a public notice for inviting objections, if any, from the Existing Allottees with respect to the proposed change of developer.
Now, therefore, through this Public Notice, objections, if any, are invited from the Existing Allottees, limited to any adverse impact that the proposed change of developer may have on their rights and interests in relation to the said project.
Any Existing Allottee having any objection to the proposed change of developer from Ocimum Estates Private Limited to IBUL, may submit such objection, along with supporting documents, to the office of the Senior Town Planner, Gurugram, Department of Town & Country Planning, Haryana, HSPV Complex, Sector-14, Gurugram, Haryana, and/or to the office of the undersigned, within Thirty (30) days from the date of publication of this Public Notice.
In the event no objection is received within the aforesaid period, it shall be presumed that the Existing Allottees have no objection to the proposed change of developer in favour of IBUL, and the same shall be deemed to have been accepted for all applicable purposes.
Date: 04.06.2026
Place: Gurugram
For M/s Ocimum Estates Pvt. Ltd.
Authorised Signatory

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Morning Nightmare: Day after

FRIDAY, JUNE 5, 2026

4

Owner went to hotel, saw it burning, left: Police

Sakshi Chand & Alok Singh
New Delhi, June 4

A SHORT circuit is believed to have triggered the fire that tore through Flourish Stays B&B in South Delhi's Malviya Nagar on Wednesday morning, killing 21 people, including 12 foreign nationals. While LPG cylinders were present inside the premises, police said they have found no evidence to suggest that any of them exploded during the incident.

The owner of the building, 60-year-old Lavkesh Bajaj, who was arrested on Wednesday night after he absconded, was running a 26-room B&B while he had the permit for only six.

During questioning, police said, Bajaj allegedly claimed he had increased the number of rooms because the business was generating good profits. *"Delhi mein sab chalta hai"* (everything goes in Delhi)," he told investigators.

When the fire broke out, Bajaj rushed to the area, but after seeing from the main road that the property was engulfed in flames, he left, police said.

Bajaj was arrested after allegedly attempting to evade authorities by changing locations in Saket and switching vehicles before heading to the residence of a known acquaintance. "Bajaj's house is located directly opposite the property where the fire broke out. He kept driving through the day before being apprehended on Wednesday" an officer said.

The fire broke out around 8.49 am in the hotel located in the narrow lanes of Hauz Rani, opposite Max Hospital Saket.

The building, which also did not have a NOC (No Objection Certificate) from the Fire department and was filled with flammable décor, has since been declared dangerous. Portions of the interiors have become unstable following the blaze, with glass panels, tiles and other fittings reportedly coming loose.

According to police, the property was originally a three-storey building purchased by Bajaj in 2022 from a businessman named Ahluwalia, who had been running a garment business from there. After ac-

quiring the property, Bajaj converted it into a Bed and Breakfast (B&B) establishment across six floors, seeing a high demand of foreign patients and medical tourists in the area.

Investigators said the building is approximately 40 years old, although substantial renovation work, including modifications to the façade and interiors, was carried out over the last two to three years.

Police sources said the structure comprised a basement with four rooms and a kitchen, a ground floor housing the reception area, restaurant and two rooms, and four upper floors containing around five rooms each. There was also a kitchen running on the top floor. Investigators are examining whether changes made during the renovation altered the original structure and compromised safety norms.

After Bajaj's arrest, police are looking into his accountant in whose name the licence to operate the facility was allegedly obtained.

Under the Delhi government's scheme, a B&B facility is required to be owned by a private homeowner who lived in the property. To meet this criterion, police said Bajaj allegedly obtained the licence in the name of his accountant, Jay Mishra, who also manages Bajaj's other properties in the area.

"While applying for the licence, Bajaj showed in the documents that the property belonged to Mishra and that he lived there," a police source said. Police said Mishra lives at Raipur Khurd in North Delhi, and raids have been conducted to arrest him but he could not be found.

Official records show *Flourish Stays* is listed at number 88 among 133 registered Bed and Breakfast establishments in South Delhi.

The owner's section mentions the name of Jay Mishra. *Flourish Stays*, a silver category property, has registration valid until May 2027.

The B&B scheme, introduced during the 2010 Commonwealth Games, had allowed homeowners to register their residences as legal tourist accommodations.

Luvkesh Bajaj sent to 4-day police custody

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, June 4

MAINTAINING THAT the police custody of Luvkesh Bajaj, the owner of *Flourish Stay B&B* — where a fire had claimed 21 lives on Wednesday — was necessary to trace the persons whose role has surfaced during investigation, the Saket court on Thursday sent him to four days of police custody.

Police had sought Bajaj's custody to "ascertain and verify the details of all workers, employees and other persons engaged in the operation of *Flourish Stay*" and to "trace, locate and apprehend Jay Mishra, accountant of the establishment and Rakesh, manager of the hotel".

"Hotel staff needs to be probed, accused has only given two names of staff, hasn't disclosed the rest. The hotel was

allowed to operate only six rooms, but it was running more than 20." Additional Public Prosecutor Gaurav Srivastava argued in court.

After hearing arguments from the police and the defense counsel, Judicial Magistrate First Class (JMFC) Bhanu Pratap Singh of Saket Court sent Bajaj to four-day police custody.

"...the police custody of accused is also necessary to trace, locate and apprehend the persons whose role has surfaced during investigation. Further, the police custody of the accused is also necessary to recover the relevant documents related to the operation of the property in question. Further police custody of accused is also necessary to recover electronic devices and digital evidence connected with the case," JMFC Singh said.



At the last rites of five of the eight members of a family who died in the fire in South Delhi, in Gurgaon on Thursday. AP

FROM IRAQ, LIBERIA, NIGERIA AND KYRGYZSTAN, THE FOREIGN NATIONALS WHO DIED

'Room was filled with smoke.. he ran down the stairs': Families mourn loved ones



Forensic team at the site of the fire on Thursday. ABHINAV SAHA

Pragynesh
New Delhi, June 4

STANDING OUTSIDE the mortuary of AIIMS Trauma Centre, 40-year-old Habib Abid sobbed as he spoke to a relative in Iraq over the phone.

He was waiting for the body of his brother-in-law, Ali Amer Mosa, who was among the 21 killed in the fire at *Flourish Stays B&B* in Hauz Rani area of South Delhi on Wednesday.

Last week, Abid had come to Delhi from Iraq with his 18-year-old son Haider. His son has been suffering from a brain tumour and the family managed to get an appointment for him at Max Hospital in Saket. Ali (29) accompanied them.

"We booked a room on the fifth floor of the hotel after admitting my son," Habib told *The Indian Express*.

On Wednesday morning, he said he woke up to shouts and screams of people in the hotel. By the time he realised a fire had broken out, he said the flames had spread to the second floor.

"Some people, who were outside, broke the window to the room and placed a ladder... I got down using it, but Ali ran from the smoke-filled room, down the stairs," said Habib.



(Top) Habib Abid at the AIIMS mortuary; Maria, from Liberia, lost her aunt. SHREYA SINGHAI

"My son is still in surgery at Max," he said.

Of those killed, 12 were foreign nationals from Bangladesh and Liberia, Nigeria, and Mozambique in Africa. They were in Delhi either for medical treatment or accompanying family members undergoing treatment.

At the AIIMS mortuary, Maria, a Liberian woman in her 20s, was looking for the body of her aunt, Janjay Roland (61).

About a week ago, she said she got a call from Janjay that she was coming to Delhi for her husband's treatment.

"I was so happy," Maria said. "I had left Liberia two years ago to pursue my graduation in India. I hadn't seen anyone from my country since then... I was going to meet my aunt this weekend."

At the mortuary, Maria held up a picture of Janjay's ID, asking where her body was. "She arrived last week and got her husband admitted to Max. I still haven't seen him. I don't know whether he knows..." she added.

Representatives of the Nigerian Embassy said that at least five Nigerian nationals lost their lives in the fire. Among them, the bodies of a woman, Esther (53) and her son and David (30), were at the AIIMS mortuary.

"We don't know who the other three are. We have come to identify them and will then inform their families," said an official. "Esther and David were in the city for Esther's surgery at Max Hospital. They had taken a room on the ground floor of the B&B. While she was admitted on May 11, she was discharged on May 18," the official added.

Her liver transplant successful, woman dies with donor-son while fleeing blaze

After surgery, Nargisa shifted to B&B with mother and son last Saturday

Pragynesh
New Delhi, June 4

NARGISA KHAN (53), a Kyrgyzstan citizen, had felt like she had been given a second chance at life. Battling liver cirrhosis, she had finally undergone a successful transplant at Max Hospital in South Delhi last month, with the donor being her son, Humayun (26).

But that second chance was snatched away on Wednesday - Humayun, Nargisa, and her mother, Makhpirat (75), were among the 21 killed in the fire at the bed and breakfast (B&B) establishment in Malviya Nagar, South Delhi.

"The surgery was a success. For the family, it was the moment they had been waiting for," said Humayun's cousin Guzal, who works as a liaison with foreign patients at Max Hospital and has lived in India for over a decade.

The family was all set to return home on June 8, she says. Since their arrival in April, Nargisa and her family had been staying at *Flourish Stays B&B*, in Room 303 on the third floor.

Nargisa was discharged after the surgery on Saturday and went to the B&B to stay

until she recovered fully.

Waiting outside the AIIMS mortuary, Guzal said, "Nargisa called me at 8.53 am... she was screaming that the hotel was on fire. The call got disconnected and when I called her back, she didn't pick up."

Terrified, Guzal asked a friend to check on them. "I reached by 10 am. I begged the policemen present there to let me go to the third floor and get them out. They told me they were trying to get people out floor by floor," she added.

As the bodies were brought down, Guzal first spotted Humayun and then Nargisa. "They were taken out from the first floor. They must have run down stairs to save themselves. Nargisa had a sling bag around her neck... she must have tried to collect their passports," said Guzal.

Guzal, who has lived in India for more than a decade, had personally helped coordinate Nargisa's treatment and stay in Delhi.

Now, instead of preparing for Nargisa's recovery, Guzal is making arrangements to take three bodies back to Kyrgyzstan. "I have just informed the family. They are in shock," she added.



Guzal, a relative of the family, waits outside the AIIMS Post Mortem & Embalming Centre Thursday. SHREYA SINGHAI

• THE 9 INDIANS WHO DIED



A policeman outside *Flourish Stays B&B* on Thursday. VIVEK PRAKASH KRISHNA

VIVEK AGGRAWAL: In his late 40s, Vivek was chartered accountant and Deputy CFO at InsuranceDekho. Had moved to Gurgaon with his family in 2019.

TARJANI AGGRAWAL: Vivek's wife, an event planner, was identified through her jewellery.

JIVISHA AGGRAWAL: The couple's 20-year-old daughter, was a BTech first-year student studying in Bengaluru and had reached Delhi on Tuesday, a day before the blaze.

VARYA AGGRAWAL: The couple's 16-year-old daughter, a student of Class 11.

HEMLATA AGGRAWAL: Vivek's mother, Hemlata's husband Radhe Shyam Aggarwal has been admitted in the Max Hospital Saket ICU for several days now in a critical condition

ASHOK GOYAL: Vivek's maternal uncle had come from Kishangarh to visit Radhe Shyam.

KAMALA: Vivek's mother's sister was visiting Radhe Shyam from Ajmer

JHIMRI: Kamala's husband who had come from Ajmer

SHRUTIKA BARANWAL: TISS graduate whose convocation was scheduled for July 26. She had recently got a job.

• EIGHT OF FAMILY KILLED IN BLAZE

'Papa... let me sleep': Last conversation with Gurgaon event planner haunts father

Drishiti Jain & Abhimanyu Hazarika
New Delhi, Gurgaon, June 4

AROUND 12:45 PM on Thursday, Prem Bansal ran briefly behind an ambulance that had his daughter Tarjani Aggarwal's body. Feeling helpless, a teary-eyed Bansal just wanted to ensure her last journey from AIIMS mortuary in Delhi to her home in Gurgaon was comfortable.

Tarjani was among the eight of a family who died in a massive blaze at *Flourish Stays*, a bed-and-breakfast in South Delhi's Hauz Rani, on Wednesday. They were staying at the B&B because an elderly family member, Radhe Shyam Aggarwal, had been admitted in the intensive care unit of the Max Hospital in Saket for several days. Vivek, Tarjani's husband,

had rented the rooms to stay closer to his ailing father.

A day after the tragedy, Bansal reached the mortuary on Thursday morning. Eyes swollen, he met other relatives as they hugged him tight.

He recalled the last conversation he had with his Tarjani — around 8.28 am on the day of the incident. "I told her I have made macaroni for the children and parathas for her. But she scolded me... 'Papa aap kyun pareshan kar rahe ho. Main so rahi hun (Papa, why are you disturbing me? I'm sleeping).' Then she said, 'Is this the time to eat? It's just 8:30. Let me sleep. *Phir vo so gayi... So gayi vo...* (Then she slept...)," he said as he burst into tears.

Apart from Tarjani, Vivek, his mother, Hemlata, and the couple's two young daughters



Vivek with his daughters and his wife; (right) his mother Hemlata

— Jeevisha (20) and Varya (16) — were among the 21 who died in the blaze. Also staying at the hotel were Vivek's maternal uncle, Ashok Goyal, from Rajasthan's Kishangarh, and his maternal aunt, Kamala, and her husband Jhimri from Ajmer. They too were killed in the blaze.

Relatives said Vivek's wife was an event planner, while his elder daughter was studying engineering in Bengaluru.

The last conversations that had with the deceased haunted the mourning relatives. Shyam Aggarwal (51), Vivek's cousin, recollected he made a call to another cousin around 8:30 am, saying, *"Bhaiya, I'm at the basement aur har jagah dhuan ho raha hai, mujhe ghutan horahi hai... shayad aaj lag gayi hai"* (Brother, I'm in the basement and there's smoke everywhere. I'm feeling suffocated. I think

the fire has broken out today)."

After the incident, the family was given updates about deaths — one after the other — on Wednesday. "First, we were told about Tarjani, then their two daughters. The younger one was studying in Class 11. The elder one was a B Tech first year student. She was scheduled to leave within two days as her exams were due," Shyam said.

He said, "We identified Tar-

jani in Max Hospital's mortuary through her jewellery as her body was completely charred."

While bodies of Vivek and five others of immediate family were taken to Gurgaon on Thursday, the autopsy of the Ajmer couple was yet to be conducted as their son's arrival from the United States was awaited.

In Gurgaon, Vivek's uncle, Vishnu Kant Garg, shaking in anger, said, "Everyone is corrupt... that is why I have lost most of my family."

Seething at the civic apathy, Vishnu told *The Indian Express*, "I will give Rs 20 lakh, I challenge the Prime Minister and Delhi government — run bulldozers and demolish all the illegal properties there... so no other lives can be lost." he added.

Outside Vivek's sprawling

two-storey property in Gurgaon's Sector 46, relatives gathered on the ground floor and the area nearby to pay their condolences. The family said Vivek, in his late 40s, was a chartered accountant and Deputy CFO at InsuranceDekho. He moved to Gurgaon with his family in 2019.

"Vivek had built the house with his own money. The family lived on the first floor and rented out the other portion," said Vivek's cousin, Vijay. It was Vijay, a sales executive working in Delhi's Kotla, who had last spoken to Vivek when the fire started. He rushed to the hospital immediately.

A neighbour, Ravinder Khatri, said their families were close: "What happened is very tragic. Vivek was a bright man, I would see him cycling 5-6 km every morning in our neigh-

bourhood. They were a very good family and kind people."

Vivek's colleague said, "Our company arranges fire insurance (among others) for people... and now..."

Shyam Agarwal remains in the ICU, unaware of the devastating loss. "What will he wake up to now?" Ravinder said.

Vivek's mother-in-law, Santosh Bansal, remembered her grandkids as being "the sweetest souls". "What happened is beyond unfair. Such hotels should not be permitted," she said.

Meanwhile, the Gurgaon district administration has ordered a safety audit of all BnBs in the city. "In view of citizens' safety, I have written to the Fire Department in this regard," Deputy Commissioner Uttam Singh told *The Indian Express*.

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Top Secret

WITH UTTAR Pradesh Assembly polls 2027 approaching, Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav has told party leaders to keep conversations held during meetings “confidential” and not share the details with people outside the party ecosystem, especially journalists. Akhilesh, it is learnt, has also instructed probable party candidates to start preparations in their constituencies but keep the communication “confidential” as the SP is yet to start seat-sharing discussions with the Congress. Any indication of candidate selection without negotiations among INDIA bloc allies may irk the grand old party, said sources.

The Peacemaker

AMONG THE ministers retained by Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar from his predecessor Siddaramaiah's cabinet, six-term MLA K J George seems to have the most secure position in the new government. The stature of George, the senior-most leader in the state Cabinet, has only gone up after the change of guard in the state, said sources. George, known as a Gandhi family loyalist in party circles, is learnt to have acted as the peace agent between Siddaramaiah, who apparently got shocked to know that the Congress high command had decided to back Shivakumar, and the party's central leadership. The sources said it was George who convinced Siddaramaiah to accept the high command's decision. Party insiders said the central leadership was happy his intervention led to a peaceful transition of power in Karnataka.

Security Alert

IT REMAINS to be seen if Delhi Police will allow the Cockroach Janta Party to hold a protest at Jantar Mantar on Saturday, demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, but security personnel have already started tracking the “youth pressure group”, in the words of its founder Abhijeet Dipke. As the group's spokespersons held a press conference in the Capital on Thursday, a significant presence of police personnel could be seen outside the venue. This was the second such press conference by the group; the first one was held at the Constitution Club of India on Wednesday.

Shivakumar keeps Finance, Priyank gets Home portfolio

Bengaluru: After much deliberation over allocation of portfolios, the Karnataka government notified the Cabinet berths late evening on Thursday.

Chief Minister D K Shivakumar will handle the Finance, Cabinet Affairs, Department of Personnel & Administrative Reforms, Intelligence, and all unallocated portfolios. Dy CM G Parameshwara will look after Revenue, and Youth Empowerment and Sports.

Priyank Khargewill be Home Minister and has retained the IT/BT portfolio. The Rural Development and Panchayat Raj Department, which was under Kharge during Siddaramaiah's tenure, will now be handled by Eshwar Khandre.

Yathindra Siddaramaiah has been made Urban Development minister. **ENS**

DMK pulls out of June 8 INDIA meet to protest Congress ‘betrayal’

Manoj CG
New Delhi, June 4

THE CONGRESS'S attempt to revive the virtually defunct INDIA bloc suffered a setback on Thursday, with the DMK announcing that it will skip the alliance meeting scheduled for June 8. The move comes amid the party's anger over the Congress's decision to snap ties with it in Tamil Nadu and join hands with Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK).

The DMK's decision signals that it is unwilling to share space with the Congress, raising fresh questions over the future of the Opposition alliance.

“Since the formation of the INDIA alliance, the DMK has functioned as one of its central pillars, with party president MK Stalin playing a leading role in raising key issues affecting the people of the country... DMK cadres have been deeply hurt by the Congress's betrayal. To respect the sentiments of party workers, the DMK has decided not to attend the INDIA (bloc) meeting in which the Congress will also participate,” said the party in a statement.



DMK chief MK Stalin pays tribute to former Tamil Nadu CM M Karunanidhi on his birth anniversary, in Chennai on Wednesday. PTI

However, the DMK reiterated that it would continue to oppose issues it considers detrimental to democracy, secularism and the rights of states, including NEET, the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and the “One Nation, One Election” proposal.

The development also comes at a time when the Trinamool Congress (TMC), the second-largest constituent of the INDIA bloc, is grappling with internal turmoil barely a month following its defeat in the West Bengal Assembly elections.

With both TMC chief Mamata Banerjee and DMK president Stalin — who have been among the Opposition's most prominent voices against the BJP-led Centre — facing political challenges, the future of the INDIA bloc appears increasingly uncertain.

Sources in the Left parties said their leaders would attend the meeting but would convey their “strong reservations” over the Congress's approach on several issues. According to them, the Congress's attacks on the CPI(M) and former Kerala chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan during the state Assembly election campaign have emerged as a source of friction in their ties at the national level.

The Left is also understood to be unhappy with the Congress's decision to walk out of its long-standing alliance with the DMK shortly after the Tamil Nadu Assembly polls. The DMK had condemned the move and even written to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla seeking a change in seating arrangements for its MPs, arguing that it would not be appropriate for them to sit alongside Congress members in the House. On Thursday, Birla agreed to the DMK's request.

Sources said sections within the CPI(M) also believe that the Congress has failed to provide effective leadership and direction to the Opposition alliance, citing what they see as a lack of conviction and commitment in steering it.

The proposal to regroup the

INDIA bloc has been floated by Mamata after the TMC's electoral debacle in Bengal.

Several Opposition leaders acknowledge that the bloc is facing a broader leadership crisis. Many of its key regional figures — including NCP (SP) chief Sharad Pawar, Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Uddhav Thackeray, Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav and RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav — have already suffered electoral setbacks in their respective states.

Leaders from the INDIA alliance who spoke to The Indian Express expressed little enthusiasm about the upcoming meeting, noting that repeated pledges of unity have largely remained on paper. Some argued that the alliance must move beyond parliamentary coordination and launch joint campaigns and protests against the BJP-led government. So far, however, cooperation has largely been confined to floor coordination in Parliament.

With the DMK signalling a more confrontational stance towards the Congress, even that limited cooperation could come under strain.

REVISED FINANCIAL POWERS

2-fold hike in ceiling for field commanders, provisions to support joint procurements



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh releases DFPDS-2026 Thursday. PTI

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, June 4

DEFENCE MINISTER Rajnath Singh on Thursday released the revised Delegation of Financial Powers (DFPDS-2026) for the Armed Forces, which includes a twofold increase in the financial ceiling for field commanders to improve operational efficiency, while also enhancing financial delegation to support revenue procurements exceeding Rs 1.25 lakh crore.

The development assumes significance in the wake of the large-scale procurements being undertaken by the Armed Forces, through the emergency and the regular route, since last year.

The DFPDS is an official document that regulates all revenue procurements for the Armed Forces, as against the Defence Acquisition Procedure (DAP) that governs all bigger capital purchases. The DFPDS specifies the competent authorities and outlines the financial powers granted to them. Revenue procurements involve acquiring essential spare parts and ammunition needed for maintaining capital assets of the defence forces and ensuring their long-term sustainability.

The DFPDS was last revised in 2021. A comprehensive draft of the Defence Acquisition Procedure (DAP) 2026 is undergoing finalisation to replace its 2020 version.

The Defence Ministry said the financial powers for certain competent authorities to clear a procurement has been enhanced up to 100%, and even more than that in some cases.

“This would further strengthen the operational efficiency of field commanders and lead to faster conclusion of contracts and execution of projects,” it said.

It further noted that the fi-

nancial powers delegated for indigenisation and research and development within the military ecosystem have been doubled to boost self-reliance in defence by minimising the dependency on Foreign Original Equipment Manufacturers.

“The revised delegation of financial powers will facilitate procurement of more than Rs 1.25 lakh crore through the revenue route, as per current year budgetary allocations,” it said.

Significantly, it noted that the special financial powers delegated to Army/Air Force/Naval commanders have been increased, along with a 100% increase in the total ceiling provided to meet urgent operational requirements. This will let Armed Forces commanders take quicker and independent decisions regarding urgent procurements.

Another key point in the new DFPDS is that it has included new provisions to promote joint service procurement by the lead service with higher delegation than normal procurement.

Significantly, the statement noted that many new competent financial authorities have been introduced to decentralise the procurement of goods and services.

According to the statement, the revision was necessitated due to the expansion in force level and to cater to the increased expenditure on operations and sustenance vis-à-vis the increase in budgetary allocation.

“This revised delegation in financial powers, along with the revised Defence Procurement Manual notified in October 2025, will give a fillip to defence procurement with expeditious decision making. This will lead to timely availability of resources as per the needs of the defence forces,” it said.

‘Ritabrata is a man of all seasons who is always with power... split was expected’

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, June 4

WITH THE Trinamool Congress (TMC) unravelling barely a month after losing power to the BJP in Bengal, the state's politics is at a crossroads. CPI(M) state secretary, former MP and minister Md Salim speaks to *The Indian Express* about how his party will occupy the Opposition space and the ongoing turmoil in the TMC, among other issues. Excerpts:

How do you see the sudden TMC split, barely just a month after elections?

This was expected. I had said it is going to melt faster than ice during the summer. Any political party without any ideology, programme or political goal cannot survive. Since the beginning, we had been saying it was a platform created to defeat the Left and pave the way for bringing the BJP and the RSS to the state. Once that is done, it has attained its expiry date.

What caused the split?

It's quite natural that it is happening. There is hardly any provision left in penal Acts that has not been violated by (former CM) Mamata Banerjee and Abhishek.

Ritabrata Banerjee, who is leading the rebel TMC MLAs, was once with the CPI(M). What is your impression of him? Can he be a good Leader of the Opposition?



Rita means climate or seasons. So, he is a man of all seasons. If there is no genuine Opposition, how can there be a genuine LoP?

Do you see hope for the CPI(M) in the Falta result – you did well and secured more than four times the votes of the Congress – and the TMC split?

Yes, anybody can see that. If you know Bengal's culture, politics and history, there is Opposition space. There are two types of politics – one of the palace and one of the streets. This coup is to find a hideout with the patronage of the ruling establishment. But street politics belongs to the Left and we are engaged right now in opposing bulldozer politics, standing by minorities, and against fuel price hikes. These people, on the other hand, only want to protect their personal illegal properties. So, they wanted some immunity from the establishment and it has been granted.

The BJP, like the CPI (M), is ideological, while the TMC is not. Do you think so, and will it affect the state?

Not only in Bengal, but throughout the country and the world, the ultimate battle is between the Left and the right wing.

What do you think about the first few decisions of the Adhikari government – be it detention centres for illegal immigrants or moves to curtail cow slaughter on Bakrid?

The neo-converts eat more beef and the neo-Christians go to the Church very frequently. Similarly, the “tatkal BJP” here has the urgency to prove that they are more Hindu than Hindutva.

Secondly, this is a government installed by Delhi, the Election Commission (EC), central forces, part of the judiciary, etc. They can't make decisions independently. Bengal will never accept that for every decision they will have to go to Delhi in a chartered plane.

I remember that in the last years of Congress rule in UP (1980s), N D Tiwari was CM and his nickname became New Delhi Tiwari because he was frequently travelling from Lucknow to Delhi to take instructions. That did not help Congress and they soon lost hold of the state.

Here too, it is a government which will frequently take lessons and instructions from Nagpur or Delhi.

FULL INTERVIEW ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

{ SUBHASH C KASHYAP • 1929-2026 }

Ex-secy general of LS, Constitution expert dies at 97

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, June 4

SUBHASH C Kashyap – constitutional expert, renowned author, former secretary general of the Lok Sabha, and an expert associated with crucial government committees – passed away here on Thursday at the age of 97. He was ailing and bed-ridden for quite some time.

Born on May 10, 1929, Kashyap was a legal luminary with a tremendous range – his textbooks ‘Our Constitution: An Introduction to India's Constitution and Constitutional Law’ and ‘Constitution of India: A Handbook for Students’ – were among the favourites for students of political science and law, as also for civil services aspirants.

But he donned several other caps too. When Atal Bihari Vajpayee was Prime Minister, Kashyap was a prominent

member of the National Commission to Review the Working of the Constitution and Chairman of its Drafting and Editorial Committee. He had also been Honorary Constitutional Advisor to the Government of India on Panchayati Raj Laws and Institutions — a key initiative of the early 1990s.

During the Modi government, Kashyap was a member of the high-level committee on simultaneous elections under the chairmanship of former President of India Ram Nath Kovind.

Kashyap's erudition of law and the constitution was peppered with a razor sharp memory of the history of India's Parliament.

In 2015, Kashyap was awarded the Padma Bhushan by then President Pranab Mukherjee.

He served as Secretary General of the seventh, eighth and



His textbooks were among the favourites for students of political science and law, as also for civil services aspirants

ninth Lok Sabha. While addressing a gathering on the release of Kashyap's Commentary on the Bhagwad Gita in Parliament House in May 2024, former Vice-President of India Jagdeep Dhankhar recalled that Kashyap had seen the return of Indira Gandhi to power after the Janata Party fell apart in the 7th Lok Sabha (1980-1984), the biggest single-party victory of 400-plus seats in the 8th Lok Sabha (1984-

89) when Rajiv Gandhi stormed to power, and the “painful” coalition era from 1989, the 9th Lok Sabha (1989-1991).

Before serving as Secretary-General of the Lok Sabha (1984-1990), Kashyap headed the Centre for Innovation and Development in Parliaments (CIDP) at the Inter-Parliamentary Union in Geneva.

He also left a legacy at the Lok Sabha secretariat during his time as Secretary General, recalls former Lok Sabha Secretary General P D T Achary.

“He was a good administrator. The Lok Sabha Secretariat is structured on the basis of various services whereas there was only one stream that could go up to the top – the general services dealing with the House and legislative work. Only from here could one become Secretary General. The other services stagnated, and this was a deficiency,” Achary told The Indian Express.

“But Kashyap integrated all these services at the director level, after which he created a common pool. He did not bother about the opposition. So, now people coming from other services also had a chance to reach the top, which was his foresight to reward talent from different services.” Underlining that he performed with consummate ease the daunting task of being Lok Sabha Secretary General, Achary said he would be missed by those who have known the institution for long.

Kashyap was awarded the honorary title and degree of Commander of Honorary Order of the Academy of San Francisco for services in the field of Constitutional Law. He received the Motilal Nehru Award twice, and the Jawaharlal Nehru Fellowship of 1996-98. He also received the Vidur Samman, the Rajiv Smriti Samman, and the Vidhi Seva Samman, among others.

Agri Stack, e-Jagriti, Mahakumbh 2025 among winners of e-governance award

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 4

THE UNION government on Thursday named 16 projects of the Central, state and local governments across the country as the winners of the National Awards for e-Governance. These include the Agriculture Ministry's platform for farmers, known as Agri Stack; the Consumer Affairs Ministry's e-Jagriti platform for filing complaints; and the Prayagraj Mela Authority's conduct of the Mahakumbh 2025.

Ten projects would be given the Gold Award while six would be handed out the Silver Award during a ceremony on July 2.

“National Awards for e-Governance are presented every year to recognise and promote excellence in implementation of e-Governance initiatives. The 29th NAEG 2026 awardees in seven categories include the gram panchayats category, recognising deepening and widening of service delivery at grassroots level through digitisation,” the Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions said in a statement.

The Agriculture Ministry's Agri Stack provides data to farmers with regard to finance

Ten projects would be given the Gold Award while six would be handed out the Silver Award during a ceremony on July 2

as well as early warning systems for disasters. The e-Jagriti portal allows consumers to lodge complaints regarding insurance, banking, housing, electricity, finance, medical care, automobiles etc. The 2025 Mahakumbh in Prayagraj had seen deployment of e-governance initiatives, apart from physical infrastructure.

The awardees include the Kerala Development and Innovation Strategic Council's initiative for making blood donation easier through a “blood bag traceability and citizen interaction portal”.

The Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare's AI-enabled clinical decision support system in its eSanjeevani telemedicine service was also among the winners. The Kerala High Court's district court case management system would also be given an award.

epaper.indianexpress.com

‘Sorry, mom and dad’: How NEET cancellation made student give up

Anand Mohan J & Ankita Deshkar

Bhopal, Nagpur, June 4

“I no longer have the courage to take the NEET exam again,” Akanksha Chaturvedi, an 18-year-old from Madhya Pradesh, who was preparing for medical entrance exams at a coaching in Nagpur, wrote in a note addressed to her parents before dying by suicide on May 20.

More than two weeks later, as her devastated relatives sorted through her belongings, they found a handwritten note that would haunt them for life.

“Mom and Dad, you had faith that your daughter would... become a doctor, but I no longer have the courage to take the NEET exam again,” Akanksha wrote. “I would have scored good marks in my first attempt, but now there is no guarantee that I will perform well again. I am sorry, Mom and Dad. I have ruined everything,” she added.

Akanksha’s father, Krishna Kumar Chaturvedi, said there was a drastic change in her behaviour after the exam was can-

celled. “She had called after taking the examination. She was very happy with her performance. But as soon as the news of the paper leak and cancellation came, she broke down. She felt all her hard work had gone waste,” he said.

Chaturvedi, who has worked as a cook in Nagpur for nearly two decades and lived there with his family, said they invested heavily in Akanksha’s education despite financial difficulties.

“My daughter was a brilliant student and always wanted to become a doctor. We took loans of Rs 3 lakh for her education. After the examination, she was confident that she would be selected,” the broken father said.

Akanksha’s uncle, Daddi Prasad Chaturvedi, said she withdrew from family interactions after the exam was cancelled.

“She did not eat properly. She stopped talking to people. She had become convinced that if she could not clear the exam this time, the family would not be able to bear the expenses for another attempt,” he said.

Re-evaluation: CBSE delayed login after experts flagged gaps

Portal now open, but process yet to commence

Vidheesha Kuntamalla

New Delhi, June 4

THE CENTRAL Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) was forced to delay opening its Post-Result Activities (PRA) portal after an IIT-led review found major cybersecurity vulnerabilities in the Board’s digital systems, senior officials associated with the exercise told *The Indian Express*.

The PRA portal, the CBSE’s official online platform to help students navigate post-examination procedures, was expected to go live on June 1, but it was not launched until the early hours of June 2. The delay set off fresh questions about the CBSE’s handling of this year’s Class 12 examination.

The portal is now active. However, it is learned that the re-evaluation exercise – the pro-

cess that is supposed to kick in after a student who suspects errors in the marking of their paper registers a challenge on the portal – is yet to begin.

Sources said the Board has decided not to use the Coemtp Edu Teck platform, which powered the On-Screen Marking (OSM) system used during evaluation of the Class 12 papers, for the re-evaluation.

Student and examination data held by Coemtp has been migrated to digital infrastructure directly controlled by CBSE, and the re-evaluation workflow will now run through the Board’s own portal.

The cybersecurity review carried out by expert teams from IIT Madras and IIT Kanpur identified at least four vulnerabilities that were classified as “critical” or of “high severity”, an official closely associated with the exercise told *The Indian Express*.

In addition, at least seven medium- and low-severity issues were identified during the review, the official said.

On May 24, amid mounting

complaints over CBSE’s digital evaluation system and technical glitches, Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan had asked expert teams from the two IITs to assist the Board.

According to the official, the launch of CBSE’s PRA portal was postponed after a third round of cybersecurity testing uncovered the vulnerabilities.

The CBSE did not respond to requests from *The Indian Express* for a comment.

The audit employed the well-known “red team-blue team” method of testing, in which the “blue” team – comprising the CBSE’s original developers, experts from IIT Madras and the Digital India Corporation (DIC) – was responsible for fixing vulnerabilities, while the “red” team of IIT Kanpur experts tried to break into the system and identify weaknesses.

Four rounds of testing were carried out. After the second round on June 1, officials believed all major issues had been resolved and began preparations to launch the portal. How-

ever, a red team exercise conducted later that afternoon uncovered major vulnerabilities again, the official said.

One of the vulnerabilities, according to the official, was a sophisticated access-control flaw that could potentially allow a user logged in with one account to gain access to answer scripts belonging to other students.

Following the discovery, the blue team scrambled to carry out repairs and, after working through the evening, managed to fix the problem.

Around midnight on June 1, after a fourth round of testing found no more significant vulnerabilities, final configuration changes were carried out and the portal was opened around 4 am on June 2.

However, the portal is currently only collecting requests from students, and storing their submissions within the CBSE system. Once the examiner-facing platform is cleared for use, examiners will be assigned answer scripts electronically, the official said.

• BRIEFLY



The hospital in Bihar’s Muzaffarpur on Thursday. PTI

BIHAR

5 ICU patients die after fire breaks out at pvt hospital in Muzaffarpur

FIVE PATIENTS choked to death and several were injured at a private hospital in Bihar’s Muzaffarpur Thursday after smoke filled the ICU following a fire incident, and the staff allegedly ran away leaving those admitted in the lurch, a top official said. A short circuit apparently triggered the fire, and the district administration formed a panel to look into the matter. CM Samrat Choudhary directed the authorities to pay an ex-gratia of Rs 4 lakh to the next of kin of each deceased — identified as Shashank Kumar from (Ratanpur in Aurai), Geeta Devi (Motipur), Uday Jha (Tariyani), Krishnanandan (Aurai), and Sanjeet Kumar (Sahebganj). ENS

Manipur: Cop killed during anti-drug raid

A POLICE head constable was killed in an anti-drug operation in Thoubal district, Manipur, on Wednesday, officers said on Thursday. The incident happened in Moijing Meena Bazaar. Head Constable Khoirom Suresh of Thoubal District Commando Unit, was stabbed multiple times while trying to nab the accused. Police have arrested two accused — Md Naobi alias Naocha (25) from Thoubal’s Moijing Leingoi-jin, and Salman Khan (30) from Moijiing Maibam Leikai. A probe is underway to nab other accused. ENS

UP: Three held for murder of 21-yr-old woman

TEN DAYS after the body of a 21-year-old woman was found in UP’s Bulandshahr, police on Thursday arrested a hospital manager in Unnao, Devkant Uttam (40), along with his nephew and a security guard at the hospital in connection with the case. The woman, who lived in Kanpur, went missing on May 21 after filing a complaint against Devkant, alleging that he had sexually assaulted her on the false promise of marriage. ENS

Punjab BJP leader survives ‘attempt on life’

BJP LEADER Vijay Soni on Thursday said he had a narrow escape after two bike-borne armed men opened fire while he was at his petrol pump in Punjab’s Gur-

INCORRECT MARKSHEETS, ERRORS IN RESULT PROCESSING AMONG ISSUES RAISED

Nagpur University students also have a Coemtp problem

Ankita Deshkar

Nagpur, June 4

SINCE FEBRUARY, students across courses at Nagpur University have been raising issues over their results. The company at the heart of the row is Coemtp Edu-teck Pvt Ltd, which is facing national outrage and a probe over glitches surrounding the CBSE Class 12 results.

Manmohan Bajpai, the head of a panel set up by the state-run university last month into the complaints, told *The Indian Express* that while the probe is still on, “what we have observed so far is that the company’s work here has been unsatisfactory”.

Among the issues raised by Nagpur University students under results were declared for exams held in November 2025

include internal assessment marks not being taken into account, incorrect marksheets, and errors in result processing. Allegations were also raised regarding the tender process through which Coemtp got the contract to manage the university’s examination and evaluation system, though a court rejected the same.

Under a cloud are results declared for 1,261 examinations conducted by Nagpur University – known formally as Rashtrasant Tukadoji Maharaj Nagpur University – for ‘Winter Exams 2025’, in which 3,17,540 students appeared.

Rahul Satdeve, who is a first-year B.Sc. (Computer Science) student, said his internal assessment marks were missing when he got the results. “That part was



NSUI members submit an application to the university authorities, urging them to look into alleged irregularities in exams. EXPRESS

blank. I repeatedly followed up the matter with the college and university authorities. The correction was finally made only on June 1, and a revised marksheet issued,” he said.

Another student from the same course said she got 0 marks in a Vedic Mathematics theory paper. “I had attempted the complete paper and also received internal assessment

marks. A 0 makes no sense,” said the student who did not wish to be identified.

Ayush Lingayat, another student, said, “The marksheets were initially not visible on the university portal. Teachers started sharing the results, and that is when students noticed that internal assessment marks were missing. The marksheets were sent back for corrections.”

According to Lingayat, discrepancies persist. “The marks for our programme should be calculated out of 1100, but the portal shows it is out of 1000. How can the total itself be wrong?”

After the National Students’ Union of India (NSUI) lodged a formal complaint on April 2, Vice-Chancellor Dr Manali Kshirsagar set up the three-

member inquiry committee headed by Bajpai, an advocate by profession and a university Senate member, with the mandate to examine allegations related to contradictions in the examination process, eligibility issues and the transparency of the tender awarded to Coemtp. Formal hearings are scheduled to begin on June 5.

Bajpai told *The Indian Express* that the committee has not reached any preliminary conclusions so far. “We are verifying the company’s (Coemtp’s) track record at the institutions where it has previously worked. Coemtp has claimed it delivered satisfactory services at those institutions. However, what we have observed so far is that the company’s work here has been unsatisfactory,” he said.

Who will be held accountable for leaks? Don’t bet on it

[FROM PAGE 1]

had enrolled for these exams hoping for jobs, college seats and high board marks — their wait stretched by up to four years, with retests of the cancelled exams taking an average of 183 days to be scheduled, an irrevocable disruption in their lives.

Of the 45 paper leaks identified by this newspaper, 23 involved exams conducted under BJP-ruled governments at the Centre or in states, while 14 occurred under Congress-ruled bodies and the remainder under other parties — UP topped the list with 11 leaks, followed by Rajasthan with seven and Gujarat with three. The majority of cases have remained under trial for years, with accused persons securing bail in the interim. In several instances, probe agencies either declared accused individuals untraceable or filed closure reports altogether.

Meanwhile, investigators warn that those operating paper leak networks have continuously upgraded their methods — from fax-based transmissions in the early 2000s to Bluetooth devices, remote-access software, and compromised printing firms by the 2020s.

2 decades, convictions in 2 cases

Records show that the two cases resulting in convictions involve paper leaks in Railway Recruitment Board (RRB) exams. In the first, a CBI special court in Ahmedabad convicted seven Railway officials and one RPF constable on July 21, 2025, in connection with a leak that occurred in 2002.

The leak was traced to serving officers posted in Ahmedabad, Vadodra and Anand in Gujarat, records show. Each convicted individual was sentenced to five years of rigorous imprisonment and fined Rs 5 lakh. All of them are now on bail, with their appeal pending before the Gujarat High Court. The examination, originally scheduled for August 18, 2002, for the posts of Probationary Assistant Station Masters, drawing over 1 lakh applicants, was cancelled

with one day to spare. A fresh test was conducted a year later.

The second conviction relates to a 2010 case. On January 30, 2024, a CBI court in Hyderabad sentenced former RRB-Mumbai chairman Satendra Mohan Sharma, his son, and eight others to five years of rigorous imprisonment with a combined fine of Rs 7.87 lakh. Sharma obtained bail from the Telangana High Court on February 2, 2024.

The examination, which attracted nearly 5 lakh applicants for the posts of Assistant Loco Pilots and Assistant Station Masters, had been scheduled for June 6 and 13, 2010. It was cancelled due to the leak and rescheduled for July 2011.

Key trials stuck

Several other high-profile cases illustrate the rot within.

● The 2003 CAT paper leak, which marked the first time the gateway examination to the Indian Institutes of Management required a retest, saw the CBI arrest key accused Ranjit Don, alias Kumar Suman Singh or Indrajeet Kumar, more than two decades ago. The leak led to the formation of the V K Shunglu Committee to examine systemic failures, resulting in reforms. Over 1.25 lakh candidates had applied for the November 23, 2003 test; a retest was held in February 2004.

● The 2006 Railway Group-D leak case has logged 142 listings between 2012 and 2026 and remains at the “witness stage”. Two accused in this case, Bedi Ram and Vipin Dubey, are now MLAs in UP.

Bedi Ram, an SBSP MLA from Ghazipur’s Jakhania (SC) seat, faces five cases linked to Railway recruitment exam paper leaks, two to MP Public Service Commission exam leaks, and one to a police recruitment exam leak. Vipul Dubey, a NISHAD Party MLA from Bha-dol’s Gyanpur seat, has also been booked under the Gangsters Act in connection with the 2006 case.

Nearly 16 lakh candidates had enrolled for the exam, which was cancelled in February 2006 and eventually held in

July. A Lucknow court issued non-bailable warrants against both Ram and Dubey on July 11, 2024; their discharge applications were rejected and charges framed on July 26, 2024. The matter remains pending.

When contacted, Ram said, “All the cases against me are very old, and they are false.” Dubey said, “The case against me is fabricated.” SBSP chief Om Prakash Rajbhar and NISHAD Party chief Sanjay Nishad are both ministers in the UP government.

● In the 2015 UPPSC Prelims leak, case records show that three accused opened sealed question paper packets prematurely at a Lucknow examination centre, photographing the papers approximately one hour before the scheduled start time. Under then Chief Minister Akhilesh Yadav, the leak and broader allegations about UPPSC recruitments triggered a political firestorm, with the Opposition accusing the SP leader of having “cornered” the posts of “56 out of 86” Sub-Divisional Magistrates — an allegation the state government denied.

The Allahabad High Court subsequently quashed the appointment of then-UPPSC Chairman Anil Yadav. The inquiry was transferred to the CBI, which has yet to conclude it, 11 years on. The exam on March 29, 2015, drew nearly 2.5 lakh applicants and was held again after a two-month delay.

● The 2016 UP Public Service Commission Review Officer and Assistant Review Officer examination — a gazetted-category recruitment — also saw a paper leak at a Lucknow centre. The CB-CID of UP Police filed a closure report in September 2018, but a Special Judicial Magistrate in Lucknow rejected it in January 2020 and ordered reinvestigation. Sources said a second closure report was subsequently filed, which remains pending before the court. With nearly 2.04 lakh applicants, the exam was originally held on November 27, 2016; after the leak was detected, a re-examination was conducted nearly four years later on September 20, 2020.

● In the 2017 Himachal Pra-

desh Board leak, which raised suspicion about a school principal and other officials, an FIR was registered at Babna Nagar police station in Kinnaur and the exam re-conducted. However, police sources confirmed that an “untraceable” report was filed within months to close the case.

● Among recent cases, the NEET-UG 2024 leak from Patna and Hazaribagh resulted in multiple charge sheets against around 46 persons by the end of 2024. The matter is pending before a special CBI court in Patna. The test, which had 23.33 lakh applicants, was held on May 5, 2024, and conducted afresh on July 23, 2024.

In some key cases, the judiciary raised the red flag.

In the 2024 UGCNET case, a Delhi court in May 2026 criticised the CBI for filing closure reports despite possessing, in the court’s assessment, evidence of a leak.

The Rajasthan High Court delivered an equally damning verdict in a separate matter. Ruling on a 2021 Sub-Inspector recruitment exam leak, Justice Sameer Jain held on August 28, 2025, that the RPSC’s “members’ participation suggests systemic corruption within the RPSC... The attack on the examination’s sanctity was not solely the handiwork of external anti-social elements but was significantly birthed and spread by these very members of the RPSC”. RPSC member Ramu Ram Raika, who was arrested in the case, is on bail; two other members, Manju Sharma and Sangeeta Arya, resigned following the judgment.

Leakers find new loopholes

According to investigators and officials, legal delays stem partly from how paper leaks are treated by the law. “Most cases were registered under IPC Sections such as 420 (cheating), 467 and 468 (forgery), and 120-B (criminal conspiracy) — all ordinary offences that carry no stringent bail conditions. Some states have brought in the Enforcement Directorate to invoke the money laundering law... UP

has on occasion applied The Gangsters Act to attach properties and extend custody,” said a senior official linked to a Central investigation.

In the 2016 Karnataka PUC Chemistry paper leak, 19 individuals including senior officials and the alleged kingpin were arrested and booked under the Karnataka Control of Organised Crime Act (KCOCA). Despite this, the Bengaluru Sessions Court acquitted all of them in May 2024, citing serious investigative shortcomings.

Leak networks have simultaneously grown more technically sophisticated. “In the early 2000s, methods were relatively direct. The 2002 RRB leak involved railway insiders using their official positions to access papers and transmit them via fax. By 2013, the SSC leak (Delhi, Haryana and UP) showed a shift to digital methods — scanned papers sent over messaging apps, with candidates using miniature Bluetooth devices to receive answers from external solvers,” a senior official said.

The 2024 UP Police Constable leak involved a Transport Corporation of India (TCI) transport company, where gang members intercepted sealed trunks and used specialised techniques to open boxes from the back or bottom while leaving front seals visibly intact.

The 2023 Bihar Police Constable leak exploited a shell-entity printing firm that diverted papers to an unauthorised private warehouse in Patna for six days. More recently, at least one case involved the unauthorised installation of remote access software such as TeamViewer, enabling off-site solvers to control candidates’ computer screens in real time.

Inside examination halls, centre-level leaks remain a persistent vulnerability. In the 2015 UPPSC Prelims, functionaries photographed papers an hour before start time. In the 2022 Bihar PSC Prelims, select candidates were secretly isolated in a locked room to solve the leaked paper. “Printing presses and outsourced logistics are among the most vulnerable links,” an officer said.

45 major leaks in 24 years, few top officials face action

Shyam Lal Yadav

New Delhi, June 4

AMONG THE 45 major paper leak cases investigated by *The Indian Express* between 2002 and 2025, only a handful of officials holding key positions in examination bodies were removed or faced action — including one court conviction. They include:

● **2024 UGC NET:** National Testing Agency D-G Subodh Kumar Singh was removed and placed on compulsory wait for nearly four months, then appointed Additional Secretary in the Ministry of Steel before being repatriated to his Chhattisgarh cadre. Singh did not respond to a request for comment.

● **2024 UPPSC:** UP Public Service Commission Controller of Examinations Ajay Kumar Tiwari was removed amid allegations of negligence in the conduct of the preliminary exam for Review Officer and Assistant Review Officer posts. Police filed a chargesheet in July 2024 against 16 accused; the ED also took up the case. Twelve arrested accused obtained bail from the Allahabad High Court between June and September 2024. The matter is pending before a Prayagraj court. Tiwari declined to comment.

● **2024 UP POLICE CONSTABLES:** UP Police Recruitment & Promotion Board Chairperson Renuka Mishra, a 1990-batch IPS officer of DGP rank, was removed and briefly placed on compulsory wait. She is presently attached to the DGP Office, UP. Mishra said she did not wish to “talk about the case”.

● **2023 BIHAR POLICE CONSTABLES:** Police recommended departmental action against retired D-G Sanjeev Kumar Singhal, who had headed the Central Selection Board of Constables after retirement, for alleged negligence. No action

has been taken. Singhal said he would talk “at the appropriate time”.

● **2022 RPSC:** RPSC member Babulal Katara was arrested in a case related to recruitment of senior teachers and suspended in January 2024. The ED filed a prosecution complaint on money laundering. Katara remains in judicial custody and the trial is underway.

● **2021 REET LEVEL-2:** Then CM Ashok Gehlot removed Rajasthan Board of Secondary Education Chairman D P Jaroli in the case linked to the Rajasthan Eligibility Examination for Teachers. RBSE Secretary Arvind Kumar Sengwa was suspended, then reinstated and re-posted in November 2022. The ED is probing the matter. Jaroli said, “I was sacked as part of a political conspiracy against me. They also did injustice to Sengwa.”

● **2021 UKSSSC:** IAS officer S Raju resigned as chairman of the Uttarakhand Subordinate Service Selection Commission on August 5, 2022, citing “moral responsibility” for the recruitment test leak. A retired 1984-batch officer, he had headed UKSSSC since September 2016. The matter is under trial. Describing the resignation as his “own decision”, Raju said he shared a list of candidates with the STF, after comparing their marks in previous exams with the leaked test, which was of “great help” in cracking the case. “I drafted an anti-copying legislation, which was promulgated by the government,” he said.

● **2021 UPTET:** Secretary of UP’s Exam Regulatory Authority Sanjay Kumar Upadhyay was booked, suspended, and arrested in connection with the UP Teacher Eligibility Test leak. His suspension was later revoked and he was promoted as Joint Director. Police chargesheeted 23 people; trial is underway. “No charges were proved against me in depart-

mental proceedings,” Upadhyay said.

● **2021 RPSC:** RPSC member Ramu Ram Raika was arrested in the Sub-Inspector recruitment case and is out on bail. He did not respond to requests for comment.

● **2018 UP TEACHERS:** UPPSC Exam Controller Anju Lata Katiyar was sacked and arrested for alleged negligence. The trial has seen at least 202 listings for hearings since 2019. Katiyar has since been reinstated and posted at the state revenue board. Katiyar dismissed the allegations as “baseless”, expressing “full faith in the judicial process” and confidence that an “expeditious trial” would allow the “truth to emerge” and “ensure justice is served”.

● **2015 UPPSC:** The Allahabad High Court in October 2015 quashed the appointment of UPPSC Chairman Anil Yadav. Denying wrongdoing, Yadav described the allegations as “propaganda” that has not “been proved in any court of law”.

● **2013 RPSC:** Then RPSC Chairman Habib Khan Gauran resigned, was booked, surrendered on Supreme Court directions, and obtained bail in the case related to recruitment for the Rajasthan Judicial Service. The case is pending trial. Ascertaining that there was “no evidence” against him, Gauran said he was on bail.

● **2010 RAILWAYS:** Former RRB Mumbai chairman Satendra Mohan Sharma and nine others were convicted by a CBI court in Hyderabad on January 30, 2024, and sentenced to five years of rigorous imprisonment with fines, for irregularities in the test for Assistant Loco Pilots and Assistant Station Masters. Sharma was granted bail by the Telangana High Court on February 2, 2024. He could not be reached for comment.



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हमारे प्रमुख प्रयास



स्वच्छ परिवहन
को बढ़ावा



70 लाख पौधे
लगाने का लक्ष्य



रेनवॉटर हावेंस्टिंग
को बढ़ावा



सिंगल-यूज प्लास्टिक
का कम उपयोग



इलेक्ट्रिक वाहन नीति
से प्रदूषण घटाने की पहल

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राष्ट्रीय राजधानी क्षेत्र, दिल्ली सरकार

WFI petition against Phogat’s Asian Games trials infructuous: SC

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 4

THE SUPREME COURT Thursday dismissed the Wrestling Federation of India’s (WFI) appeal challenging a Delhi HC order that permitted senior wrestler Vinesh Phogat to participate in the Asian Games selection trials.

However, the top court explicitly clarified that the dismissal does not mean an affirmation of the adverse observations made by the HC against the federation. A bench of Justices P S Narasimha and Aravind Kumar observed that the matter had become infructuous since the subsequent selection trials had already taken place, in which Phogat participated and lost.

While the court declined a request by the WFI’s counsel to formally expunge the HC’s critical comments, it added that the issues remain open and its order will not be taken as reiterating the HC’s observations. The dispute traces back to the Delhi HC’s assessment of the WFI’s regulatory framework. The HC ruled that the WFI’s selection policy and its subsequent selection criteria circular were “clearly exclusionary in nature”. It criticised the policy for failing to provide discretion to accommodate iconic athletes like Phogat, who had taken an extended maternity leave sabbatical.

SC panel proposes ban on AI use to decide verdicts, judge bail risks

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, June 4

A COMPLETE ban on using artificial intelligence (AI) to decide judicial outcomes; restrictions on AI tools that predict or profile parties and witnesses; and a prohibition on undisclosed or unexplainable AI systems in court processes—these are among the draft regulations proposed by the Supreme Court AI Committee on the use of the technology in courts. The preliminary draft of the ‘Regulations for Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in Courts, 2026’ published by the top court on Wednesday emphasises that the use of AI in court processes will always “remain strictly subservient to human judgment and judicial authority”.

Every AI system, it says, will function solely in an assistive capacity and “shall not supplant or compromise the independent exercise of judicial authority by a duly appointed judicial officer” and “the ultimate authority to determine matters of law, fact and justice shall vest exclusively in the judicial officers of the competent jurisdiction”.

The committee—chaired by Supreme Court judge Justice P S Narasimha, and including Justices Sanjeev Sachdeva, Raja Vijayraghavan V, Anoop

The use of AI in court will remain strictly subservient to human judgement & judicial authority, says committee

Chitkara, and Suraj Govindaraj as members—has now sought the views and suggestions of all stakeholders and the general public on the draft recommendations before finalising them. The suggestions have to be submitted by June 20.

As per the draft, AI systems used in court processes “shall be designed, trained and deployed in a manner that promotes fairness and avoids discrimination”. “No AI System shall be deployed that perpetuates, amplifies, or introduces bias on the grounds of race, religion, caste, sex, gender, disability, language, economic status, or any other ground prohibited under the Constitution or any law for the time being in force and special care shall be taken to protect the rights and interests of vulnerable groups including women, children, persons with disabilities, marginalised and minority communities, and persons from economically and socially disad-

vantaged backgrounds,” it adds.

The systems will be subject to the provisions of the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023.

Permissible uses of AI include for case management, cause list preparation, hearing scheduling, transcription of court proceedings, translation of judgments etc, legal research, administrative functions including case filing assistance, defect scrutiny, record management and judicial resource allocation, conversational AI assistants and guided chatbots to assist litigants and other stakeholders in accessing court services and understanding procedural requirements, accessibility services for persons with disabilities or language barriers and anonymisation of court records.

Among the prohibitions, the draft says that no personal data of any person shall be used to train, test, or refine any AI system without the prior approval of the appropriate authority, or to perform the function of adjudication or sentencing in any matter without mandatory human-in-the-loop. It added that any output of an AI system in relation to adjudicative or sentencing questions shall be treated as advisory only and will be subject to independent judicial evaluation.

The proposal says that “no AI system shall be used for risk scoring for any purpose in court processes, including the assessment of flight risk, prediction of recidivism, evaluation of bail eligibility, or determination of the credibility of parties or witnesses” and that “no undisclosed, opaque, or unexplainable AI system shall be used in any court process that may materially affect the lawful rights or personal liberty of any party”.

The apex body, it recommends, would include two SC judges nominated by the CJI, one of whom shall serve as ex-officio chairperson; two high court Chief Justices nominated by the CJI; two high court judges nominated by the CJI; one member from an institution of national importance or any institution of repute, as may be nominated by the CJI; an officer not below the rank of joint secretary to the Government of India in the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology; a finance expert, to be nominated by the CJI; a cybersecurity expert, to be nominated by the CJI; one or more advocates of standing, nominated by the CJI with expertise in technology related laws or data privacy or related fields; and the professor heading the field of AI at the NJAP.

Southwest monsoon hits Kerala, IMD forecasts heavy rainfall until June 7

Anjali Marar
Bengaluru, June 4

THE IMD on Thursday announced the onset of southwest monsoon over Kerala, marking the beginning of the four-month long season. The normal onset date is June 1, with a deviation of seven days. This year, the onset has been realised three days after the normal date, IMD said.

This year, the Met office has forecast below-normal rainfall over the country. Quantitatively, it is expected to be 90% of the Long Period Average, which is 870 mm (1971-2020). This subdued rain forecast is mainly in view of the developing El Nino condition—a global, naturally occurring ocean-atmospheric phenomena along the equatorial Pacific Ocean.

Even though Kerala has been reporting heavy rain since last week, the IMD maintains some criteria, all of which when satis-

● Onset over Kerala	
Year	Date
2026	June 4
2025	May 24
2024	May 30
2023	June 8
2022	May 29
2021	June 3
2020	June 1
2019	June 8
2018	May 29
2017	May 30
2016	June 8
2015	June 5
SOURCE: IMD	

factorily met, declares the monsoon onset over Kerala. These include (i) After May 10, if there is rain of 2.5mm or more lasting two consecutive days recorded over stipulated 14 stations in Kerala, Lakshadweep and Karna-

taka (ii) strengthening and deepening of westerly winds to 15-20 knots and at least 600 hecta Pascal, respectively and (iii) the Outgoing Long Range (OLR) value (or the heat) remains below 200 watts/sqm over 5-10°N latitude and 70-75°E latitude area.

Once the southwest monsoon sets in over Kerala, it advances northwards in surges depending on the monsoon wind pulses and other factors.

The IMD has issued a ‘yellow’ alert warning of the continuing heavy rain (70-110 mm in 24 hours) for all districts of Kerala until June 7. The Met office said that favourable conditions prevailed for the monsoon advancement into Goa, some parts of Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh, more parts of Karnataka, rest of Tamil Nadu, more parts of the Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal during the next two to three days.

A corruption scandal & an opportunity: How 2 tribal women stepped into leadership roles in Naxal-hit Sukma

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, June 4

IN A first for Chhattisgarh’s Naxal-affected Sukma district, two young tribal women from remote villages have taken charge as managers of Primary Minor Forest Produce Committees after an alleged corruption case led to the suspension of several officials involved in a tendu leaf bonus scam. The two women oversaw the collection of tendu leaves worth Rs 4.52 crore this season.

Last year, the forest department came under scrutiny after the Chhattisgarh ACB registered an FIR alleging that a portion of the Rs 7 crore earmarked as bonus payments for tendu leaf collectors for 2021-22 had been embezzled. The case led to the suspension of the then Divisional Forest Officer (DFO) and managers of 11 Primary Minor Forest Produce Committees. “The alleged corruption took place as in some Naxal-prone areas of Sukma, including Jagargunda, Kistaram, Golapalli and Konta, payments for tendu leaves were made in cash due to the absence of banking facilities in remote villages. Since 2025,



The two women have overseen the collection of tendu leaves, used to manufacture bidis, worth Rs 4.52 crore this season. EXPRESS



than 200 km away to Dantewada so that I could complete my studies. I lived in a hostel there, completed my schooling and later earned a BA from Mahendra Karma Girls College. “I want the government to encourage parents to send their children to school. Many parents do not pay attention because they need girls to help with household work, and financial constraints are also a factor. I want girls to be educated like me so they can move ahead in life,” she said.

Madkam, from Madkampara village in Sukma, completed a BSc from a college in Sukma. “I saw an advertisement for the job at a Common Service Centre and applied. I am the first woman in my village to get a government job. Now I am encouraging my sisters to focus on their studies,” she said.

Sukma DFO Akshay Kumar Bhosale said the appointments carried significance beyond the administration of tendu procurement. “It is a matter of pride and that, for the first time, women from such remote villages in Sukma have been selected as managers. Their selection will help build confidence among other women to complete their

education, and I hope we will see equal participation of women in similar posts in the future,” he said. “Right now, two of the 25 managers (including new recruits) are women. But as Sukma has become Naxal-free, more women are coming forward to seek opportunities. This is just the beginning... They are efficient and proactive, and are creating awareness on tendu leaf-related schemes like scholarship and insurance for collectors.”

Tendu patta has a minimum support price of Rs 5,500/bag; each bag has 1,000 bundles, and each bundle contains 50 leaves. The government collects these and further sells them to contractors. The corruption case in April had prompted the government to mandate online transactions for the entire district, and for the first time, all tendu leaf collectors received nearly Rs 39.04 crore in 41,021 bank accounts through direct bank transfer. This year, the amount increased to Rs 46.62 crore and will be sent to 46,625 accounts. Earlier, officials said that nearly 50% of the amount was paid in cash. Last year, 17,000 bank accounts were opened in remote areas for the payment.

Suvendu shifts Tajpur deep-sea port plan to Dadanpatrabar

Sweetey Kumari & Vikas Pathak
Kolkata, New Delhi, June 4

THE BJP government in West Bengal on Thursday unveiled a new plan for its deep-sea port project, shifting it from Tajpur to almost 10 km away to the coastal town of Dadanpatrabar. Announcing the decision at Nabanna, CM Suvendu Adhikari said it was not viable to build the mega project in Tajpur owing to severe land constraints.

Adhikari said the decision came after a discussion with the Adani Group, which was originally shortlisted for the Tajpur project, adding that the original site does not possess the massive land required for the project.

The announcement came shortly after Union Minister for Ports, Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal met Adhikari in Kolkata on Thursday to discuss the possibility of making West Bengal the maritime hub of eastern India, proposing a maritime investment pipeline of Rs 19,209 crore by the year 2031.

Speaking to reporters virtually after the meeting, Adhikari said: “‘Yesterday (on Wednesday), I had a discussion with the MD of Adani Ports, Karan Adani, regarding the Tajpur deep sea port project.’ Explaining why the deep-sea port was not viable in Tajpur, the chief minister

said: “They (Adani) have already exited (from the project) and we saw that there was no viability of the project as the state government does not have adequate land there. That is why the Adanis walked out of the project. It is not possible without thousands of acres of land.”

“Therefore, we have made an alternative plan in Dadanpatrabar, 10 kilometers away from Tajpur. We have 1,700 acres of land there. We will move forward with that. We have also spoken with Union Minister Sarbananda Sonowal...he has granted us permission. We will proceed there realistically,” he added.

Adhikari added that he, as the erstwhile Leader of Opposition, had said the project wouldn’t be viable in Tajpur without rail and highway connectivity, as well as several thousand acres of land for warehouses. “Finally, after the change of government... a team evaluated the situation and stated that the port is not possible there because the state government does not have any land,” he said.

The CM further stated that Sonowal has given his consent to provide an NOC for the project, and the Union and state governments will now start the project in the 1,700-acre land in Dadanpatrabar, adding that more land could be acquired for the project as and when required.

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA, MINISTRY OF DEFENCE, EX-SERVICEMEN CONTRIBUTORY HEALTH SCHEME, STATION HQ (ECHS CELL), MEERUT
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EMPLOYMENT NOTICE

1. ECHS invites applications to engage Medical, Para Medical & Non Medical Staff on contractual basis in ECHS Polyclinics Meerut-I, Meerut-II, Muzaffarnagar, Bijnor and Baghpat for a period of one year renewable for additional period of one year/till attaining the maximum age (whichever is earlier) and subject to performance of candidates/other conditions according to the criteria as mentioned in detail on ECHS Website www.echs.gov.in :-

Appointment	Minimum Qualification	Minimum Work Experience	Vacancy Status					Fixed Remuneration (Option I) ##
			Meerut-I	Meerut-II	Muzaffarnagar	Bijnor	Baghpat	
24 & 25 Jul 2026								
Medical Officer	MBBS	03 Years	07	02	01	—	02	Rs. 95,000/-
Dental Officer	BDS	03 Years	02	—	—	—	01	Rs. 95,000/-
Nursing Assistant	GNM Diploma	05 Years	02	01	—	01	01	Rs. 38,500/-
Dental Hygienist/ Assistant/ Technician/ DORA	Diploma in Dental Hygienist/ Assistant/Technician/ Mechanic/DORA	03 Years	—	—	01	—	—	Rs. 36,500/-
Pharmacist	Diploma in Pharmacy	03 Years	02	01	—	01	—	Rs. 36,500/-
Lab Technician	BSc MLT	03 Years	01	01	01	—	01	Rs. 36,500/-
Lab Assistant	DMLT	05 Years	—	01	—	—	—	Rs. 36,500/-
Radiographer	Diploma in Radiographer	05 Years	01	—	—	—	—	Rs. 36,500/-
Clerk / Data Entry Operator	Graduate & Computer Diploma	05 Years	01	01	01	01	—	Rs. 29,200/-
Driver	Eighth Class and Driving Licence	05 Years	01	—	—	—	01	Rs. 25,600/-
Peon	Eighth Class	05 Years	—	01	—	—	01	Rs. 21,800/-
Female Attendant	Eighth Class	05 Years	—	01	—	—	—	Rs. 21,800/-
Safaiwala	Eighth Class	05 Years	01	01	—	—	01	Rs. 21,800/-
Chowkidar	Eighth Class	—	—	01	01	—	—	Rs. 21,800/-

2. For Terms & Conditions, Application Form & Remuneration. Refer Website www.echs.gov.in for details and for any further clarifications, may contact Station HQ (ECHS Cell) Meerut Telephone No 0121-2658264 or Mobile No 8445161265 between 0900h-1400h or concerned ECHS Polyclinic. Preference will be given to the Ex-servicemen.

3. Last Date of Receipt of Application as per format given at our website. Application as per requisite format alongwith self attested photocopies of testimonials in support of Education Qualifications and Work Experiences will be submitted to OIC, Station HQ (ECHS Cell) Meerut by 05 Jul 2026. Any application received after 05 Jul 2026 will not be accepted.

4. Interview Date, Timing & Venue. 24 & 25 Jul 2026, 0800 hours at Station HQ Meerut. Bringing original certificate/mark sheets/degree of 10th/Matric, 10+2 & Graduation/Post Graduation/Diploma/Course, work experience and discharge book, PPO, service records and two PP size colour photographs mandatory for interview. No TA/DA is admissible. Only candidate meeting the Qualification Requirements may apply. Medical fitness certificate from SEMO/CMO will be attached with the application.

5. Ten days on the job training will be carried out for OIC Polyclinic, Gynaecologist, Radiologist, Medical Specialist, Medical and Dental Officer after selection. This period will remain unpaid.

6. ## Option 1. Fixed Remuneration as mentioned above. Option 2. Retired/re-engaged Govt employee can also opt Remuneration as per Para 2 of Govt of India, MoD letter No 22D(19)/2017-D(WE)/Res-I(i) dt 24 Jul 2025 and 22D(19)/2017-D(WE)/Res-I(iii) dt 24 Jul 2025.

No. 5(18)/2024D(Lab)
Government of India
Ministry of Defence
D(Lab)
Sena Bhawan, New Delhi-110105
Dated The 24th February 2026
MEMORANDUM

The President proposes to hold an inquiry against MES-608001 Shri Y Murali Mohan Reddy, EE of HQ CE A&N Zone Port Blair, under Rule 14 of the Central Civil Services (Classification, Control & Appeal) Rules, 1965. The substance of the imputations of misconduct or misbehavior in respect of which the enquiry is proposed to be held is set out in the enclosed statement of ARTICLE of Charge (Annexure-I), A statement of the imputations of misconduct or misbehavior in support of each ARTICLE of charge is enclosed (Annexure-II).

2. MES-608001 Shri Y Murali Mohan Reddy, EE of HQ CE A&N Zone Port Blair, is directed to submit within 15 days of the receipt of this Memorandum a written statement of his defence and also to state whether he desires to be heard in person.

3. He is informed that an inquiry will be held only in respect of those articles of charge as are not admitted. He should, therefore, specifically admit or deny each Article of charge.

4. MES-608001 Shri Y Murali Mohan Reddy, EE of HQ CE A&N Zone Port Blair is further informed that if he does not submit his written statement of defence on or before the date specified in Para 2 above, or does not appear in person before the inquiring authority or otherwise fails or refuses to comply with the provisions of Rule 14 of the CCS (CC&A) Rules, 1965, or the orders/directions issued in pursuance of the said rule, the inquiring authority may hold the inquiry against him ex-parte.

5. Attention of MES-608001 Shri Y Murali Mohan Reddy, EE of HQ CE A&N Zone Port Blair is invited to Rule 20 of the CCS (Conduct) Rules 1964, under which no Govt. servant shall bring or attempt to bring any political or outside influence to bear upon any superior authority to further his interest in respect of matters pertaining to his service under the Government. If any representation is received on his behalf from another person in respect of any matter dealt with in these proceedings, it will be presumed that MES-608001 Shri Y Murali Mohan Reddy, EE of HQ CE A&N Zone Port Blair is aware of such a representation and that it has been made at his instance and action will be taken against him for violation of Rule 20 of the CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964.

6. The receipt of the Memorandum may be acknowledged.

ANNEXURE-I
STATEMENT OF ARTICLES OF CHARGE FRAMED AGAINST MES-608001 SHRI Y MURALI MOHAN REDDY, EE OF HQ CE A&N ZONE PORT BLAIR

ARTICLE-I

That the said MES-608001 Shri Y Murali Mohan Reddy, EE while functioning as Executive Engineer in the office of HQ CE A&N Zone Port Blair has proceeded on official duty to attend Works Conference at HQ IDS, New Delhi on 29.08.2023 for a duration of 04 days (approx.). The officer has not reported back to his duty station i.e. HQ CE A&N Zone, Port Blair till date, whereas he was supposed to report on 04.09.2023. HQ CE A&N Zone, Port Blair has made all efforts to contact him telephonically but there is no response received from the officer.

Thus, MES-608001 Shri Y Murali Mohan Reddy, EE has exhibited lack of devotion to duty and acted in a manner of unbecoming of Govt Servant and thereby violated the Rules 3(1) (ii) & (iii) of CCS(Conduct) Rules, 1964 under Rule 14 & Rule 25 of CCS (Leave) Rules, 1972.

ANNEXURE-II
STATEMENT OF IMPUTATION OF MISCONDUCT IN SUPPORT OF THE ARTICLES OF CHARGE FRAMED AGAINST MES-608001 SHRI Y MURALI MOHAN REDDY, EE OF HQ CE A&N ZONE PORT BLAIR

ARTICLE I

That the said MES-608001 Shri Y Murali Mohan Reddy, EE while functioning as Executive Engineer in the office of HQ CE A&N Zone Port Blair has proceeded on official duty to attend Works Conference at HQ IDS, New Delhi on 29.08.2023 for a duration of 04 days (approx.). The officer has not reported back to his duty station i.e. HQ CE A&N Zone, Port Blair till date, whereas he was supposed to report on 04.09.2023. HQ CE A&N Zone, Port Blair has made all efforts to contact him telephonically but there is no response received from the officer.

That the said MES-608001 Shri Y Murali Mohan Reddy, EE has absented himself from duty willfully and without any prior permission of the Competent Authority wef 04.09.2023 and has continued to remain absent unauthorizedly till date despite issue of Show Cause Notice vide HQ CE (A&N) Zone letter No. 190013/Y/MM/66/El dated 14.07.2025 which was also published in national & local newspaper on 28.09.2025.

Thus, MES-608001 Shri Y Murali Mohan Reddy, EE has exhibited lack of devotion to duty and acted in a manner of unbecoming of Govt Servant and thereby violated the Rules 3(1) (ii) & (iii) of CCS(Conduct) Rules, 1964 under Rule 14 & Rule 25 of CCS (Leave) Rules, 1972.

(By Order and in the name of President)
Sd/-
(Sunil Kumar Gupta)

CBC-10622/11/0016/2627 Under Secretary to the Government of India

Trump tariff saga goes on, India must find way

ON TUESDAY, the US Trade Representative proposed tariffs on 60 countries under Section 301 of the US Trade Act, 1974 — economies that together account for 99.4 per cent of all US imports. That the proposal has come up now — the USTR will hold hearings on the proposed actions on July 7 — is no accident. After the US court struck down the policy of reciprocal tariffs brought through the International Emergency Economic Powers Act, Trump had imposed a 10 per cent levy on all trading partners through Section 122 of the Trade Act. This tariff could, however, be levied only for a maximum of 150 days, unless extended by the US Congress. That period will end on July 24. The USTR's investigation and its proposals now createspace for White House to move ahead with its trade agenda.

Of the 60 countries, 54 are said to have failed “to impose a legal prohibition on the importation of goods” that have been produced by forced labour and have allegedly been unable “to effectively enforce such a prohibition”. This category includes a wide range of countries — from China and India to Saudi Arabia, Australia, Switzerland, the UK, and others. Another six countries — EU, Canada, Indonesia, Mexico, Ecuador, and Pakistan — are said to have “failed to effectively enforce a forced labour import prohibition”. The USTR has proposed two sets of tariffs — 10 per cent and 12.5 per cent. India falls in the latter category. However, this is not all. Attempts to reinforce the tariff wall are playing out across multiple arenas. Another investigation was launched in March to look into the issue of “structural excess capacity and production in manufacturing sectors” of 16 economies, including countries like India and China. All this suggests that, despite judicial setbacks, tariffs will likely remain key to the Trump agenda.

The Indian government has responded to the USTR's proposals by saying that it is engaging with the US on the issue, while also working towards finalising the framework agreement announced by the two countries earlier this year. On Wednesday, Sergio Gor, the US Ambassador to India, said that the negotiations had mostly wrapped up, with only a few points still to be ironed out. As India moves forward with its trade deal with the US, it must be mindful of the unpredictable nature of the White House administration. It should press for greater market access while safeguarding its interests.

Suryakumar & Sooryavanshi

INDIAN CRICKET'S present-day decision makers — selection committee chief Ajit Agarkar and coach Gautam Gambhir — have put in place a system, and Suryakumar Yadav has just come up against it. Three months after captaining India to the T20 World Cup title in Ahmedabad, the 35-year-old is likely to be removed as captain and also dropped from the squad. The call follows a template that Agarkar and Gambhir have applied almost without exception: Rohit Sharma's Test decline was not managed, it was ended; Virat Kohli retired soon after; Shubman Gill, already Test captain, was dropped from the T20 World Cup squad despite being named vice-captain just months earlier. The prolonged absence of another senior, Mohammad Shami, from the national team follows the same logic. That Suryakumar won 40 of 52 matches as captain, never lost a bilateral series, and still finds himself here is not a contradiction — it is the system working exactly as designed. His numbers — 270 runs in 13 IPL innings at an average of 20.76 — made the arithmetic straightforward.

During his tenure, Suryakumar had made Gambhir's philosophy his own on the field — he wanted India to become a “cricket-loving country rather than a cricketer-loving one”. But sport has shown that indulging stars, giving them a longer rope than others, can benefit the team, too. Rahul Dravid, Gambhir's predecessor as coach, offered a counterargument. “Any sport needs its heroes,” Dravid said. “You can't capture the imagination of a nation if you don't deliver on the field. To become a legend or a superstar in India means you've done a lot of things right and, in the process, you've also helped your team win.” The trophy and the icon, in his reading, are not rivals. They are part of the same transaction. With the 2028 Olympics and a hat-trick of T20 World Cup titles on the horizon, the cost of getting that balance wrong is high.

Into this space has stepped 15-year-old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi — 583 IPL runs at a strike rate of 232 in his second season — who, unlike previous young stars who came with promise, arrives with box-office. The crowds come specifically to watch him, not to appreciate a team philosophy. Managing a phenomenon like that within a system seemingly sceptical of hero worship will require something subtler than policy. Dravid left the argument open. Sooryavanshi may force it shut.

She refused to be drawn in black & white

IN THE 2000s, as a debate over banning the veil raged in France, Marjane Satrapi would not be drawn into the polarised media environment. The level of discussion was too low, she said, and her position wasn't a simple one. “For me, prohibiting the veil and forcing it is the same,” she said in an interview. She could be as critical of Western forms of secularism and feminism, and their uncritical universalisation, as of the Islamic Republic of Iran and its morality police. Years later, during the “Woman, Life, Freedom” protests in Iran, she coordinated a collective effort to produce a book telling the story of Mahsa Amini's death in custody and the subsequent uprising. Despite the graphic novel that catapulted her to fame, Satrapi, who died on Thursday aged 56, refused to be drawn in black and white.

The world of Satrapi's childhood, in an upper-middle-class milieu in Tehran, with left-wing parents who opposed the Shah, would be shattered by the 1979 Islamic Revolution. Her experiences growing up in this new, dangerous Iran, including the execution of a favourite uncle, and navigating its new morality shaped the autobiographical work for which she is best known, *Persepolis*. In the later volumes, the curious little girl, Marji, grows up, through exile in Europe, a return to Iran, and exile again. Her goal, as she once put it, was partly “pedagogical” — to correct misconceptions about Iran, and tell Westerners that no, “the whole people of the country” weren't “crazy”. The work went on to sell millions of copies worldwide.

In addition to graphic novels, Satrapi directed or co-directed several films, including the 2007 adaptation of *Persepolis* and a biopic of Marie Curie (*Radioactive*, 2019). She remained engaged with political activism in Iran throughout, praising the 2022 protests as a “feminist revolution”. Today, Iran is in the grip of a transformation whose contours are still being defined. As it develops, the clarity of Satrapi's perception will be missed.

Dear students struggling with exam chaos and scams

I WISH, as educators, we could look you in the eye and say what the government will not, that we are sorry for all the exam-related stress India causes you. Exams are stressful, and the latest NEET and CBSE scandals will add to the stress by diminishing trust in the system. But you see, we cannot say sorry. After all, the Prime Minister himself wrote an inspiring book for you called *Exam Warriors*.

You are warriors in the service of the nation. In case you had any doubts, the Hindi translation of the Prime Minister's book also uses the English term “warrior”. War is a cruel business. Battlefield chaos is never pretty; there are glitches, casualties, and setbacks. The Prime Minister himself gave you recipes for reducing exam stress, making yourself physically fit by doing yoga and *pranayama*, all sage advice if you do believe exams are like wars.

The education system might seem to you like organised and systematic cruelty. It is, and it is by design. But it is preparing you for the battlefield that is Indian society: It tests your endurance. To spruce things up, we have injected an element of chaos. Like warriors, we do not expect you to get upset, to complain, to hold the highest authorities accountable, to ask questions, like what is the whole point of this cruel system. Like warriors, you take this on the chin, be stoic about it, and get ready for battle again.

You see, all we can offer you is a character-building exercise. After all, India's foundations are built on that. When the economy you will enter is in distress with

fewer jobs, we will ask you to sacrifice for the sake of the economy. Even our actual warriors, the soldiers, have to rely largely on their character. For a government strong on defence, the budget for procurement was stagnant for a decade. And look, real soldiers also work under conditions where there are procurement delays and maybe even scams. Now this has happened in exams: Think of a dysfunctional OSM system as the equivalent of our brave Air Force not getting planes on time. Defence needs character. So does higher education.

We could reduce the stress on you by increasing investment in higher education, by making sure that the stakes in every marginal mark in these exams were not so high as to drive you to despair. If you had more options, perhaps the stress would be less. But then what would happen to your character? Notice the pattern here: Economic reforms on the cheap. No real investment and attention to systems that will make the economy attractive. Defence on the cheap. And higher education, even exam systems, on the cheap. But the country marches on, built on your endurance, stiff upper lip, national pride, and a few breaths of yoga.

With education, there is something else. After all, this is the testing ground for One Nation, One Everything. The power of ONE is more important than the objectives of the exam. So let us build centralised systems. You might think exams like CUET are unnecessary and serve no



PRATAP BHANU MEHTA

Our education ministers, at both the Centre and the states, have been among the greatest gifts we could have given to China and our competitors

This World Environment Day, let's broaden the conversation



PURVI MEHTA

WORLD ENVIRONMENT Day is an occasion to reflect on the growing threat posed by climate change. Recent weather extremes in Delhi — from 43°C heat to torrential rain and sharp temperature swings within days — underscore the growing unpredictability of our climate. The planet has already warmed by more than 1.1°C above pre-industrial levels, and its impacts are being felt across the world.

Climate-related disasters now inflict economic losses of roughly US\$300-320 billion annually worldwide, significantly above long-term averages, with weather-related events accounting for more than 90 per cent of the damage. Key sectors like agriculture are coming under pressure from heat stress, droughts, floods, and shifting pest dynamics. Water scarcity already affects billions, while infrastructure designed for the 20th century is increasingly unfit for today's realities.

These challenges are creating unprecedented demand for recalibrations of technologies, resilient infrastructure, climate-smart manufacturing, water-efficient systems and innovative business models. The climate crisis is becoming one of the most powerful drivers of economic transformation in modern history. The world is now entering what is being called the “adaptation economy”. Recent industry estimates place the global climate adaptation market at roughly US\$30-35 billion in 2025, encompassing climate-resilient infrastructure, water management systems, early-warning technologies, resilient agriculture, cooling technologies, climate analytics, and adaptation services. It is expected to grow to US\$95-140 billion by 2030 with an annual growth rate of roughly 10-16 per cent.

It offers a high return on investment. According to the Global Commission on Adaptation, investing \$1.8 trillion globally in climate adaptation by 2030 could generate more than \$7 trillion in net economic benefits. Meanwhile, the United Nations estimates that adaptation investment needs in developing countries could exceed \$300 billion annually by 2030 and rise further thereafter. These figures represent not merely costs of adaptation but opportunities for innovation, entrepreneurship, job creation and economic growth.

For India, the opportunity is significant. The country has committed to achieving net-zero emissions by 2070 while simulta-

neously pursuing rapid economic growth. According to NITI Aayog, it will require cumulative investments of approximately US\$22.7 trillion by 2070 to achieve its net-zero target. This is roughly US\$500 billion annually for the next four-and-a-half decades. This dual objective, often framed as a challenge, can equally be viewed as an economic opportunity.

India is already among the world's fastest-growing renewable energy markets. Its ambitious targets in solar energy, green hydrogen, battery manufacturing, electric vehicles, sustainable mobility and energy-efficient infrastructure have the potential to attract hundreds of billions of dollars in investment. The transition to a low-carbon economy could create millions of new jobs across the manufacturing, engineering, construction, digital services and energy management sectors. India has many of the ingredients required to become a global hub for climate solutions: Entrepreneurial talent, engineering capability, a large domestic market and a growing innovation ecosystem.

Agriculture, a crucial sector, is also the one most directly exposed to climate variability, requiring an entirely new generation of climate-resilient seeds, stress-tolerant varieties, irrigation infrastructure, cold storage, and thermostable vaccines. These are no longer scientific pursuits — they are major commercial opportunities. The same opportunity exists in infrastructure. There is now a vast market for climate-resilient construction materials, advanced cooling systems, water management technologies, climate-appropriate transportation systems and resilient urban planning. None of this reduces the urgency of climate action. Adaptation is not a substitute for mitigation. Reducing greenhouse gas emissions remains critical to avoid the consequences of climate change.

But this World Environment Day, perhaps we should broaden the conversation. The question is no longer whether the climate is changing. The question is how to adapt to it and optimise investments in building technologies, businesses and industries needed to make adaptation a driver of economic growth. Countries that view climate change as both a challenge and an opportunity will build the industries, create the jobs, and shape the economies of the future. India has every reason to be among them.

The writer is senior industry policy advisor. Views are personal

pedagogical purpose whatsoever. But the purpose is not pedagogy: It is exercise. Does a soldier ever complain about “excessive” exercise? Does a warrior complain about the Centre you get? Think of the distant Centre as a posting in tough terrain. The testing industry is also a big boost to GDP; the same education shows up as a “private good” and boosts your GDP numbers.

The total spending on private tuition now exceeds the entire central government allocation for higher education, and this may be understating the problem. The Comprehensive Modular Survey, based on the NSS's 80th round, shows not just that slightly under half of all students are in private tuition, but remarkably, 11 per cent of kids in pre-school are in private tuition. Don't get angry at the government if you don't make it. Direct your anger at parents who did not start this whole process early enough. Warriors are, after all, built at home.

I will let you in on a secret. The whole purpose of India's exam industry, with a few minor exceptions, is no longer to expand opportunity or prepare the country for global competition. Our education ministers, at both the Centre and the states, have been among the greatest gifts we could have given to China and our competitors. When PM Narendra Modi asked Indians to tighten their belts to conserve foreign exchange, he asked us not to buy gold, or to cut down on foreign travel. But he could not, with a

straight face, ask Indians not to spend money abroad on foreign education. Somewhere, deep down, the political class knows the truth about this system.

Kunal Mangal's insight into UPSC aspirants applies more broadly to an entire generation. India's brightest and most educated young people spend the most creative years of their lives moulding themselves into exam warriors. A few will emerge decorated with medals. Most, like valiant unknown soldiers, will disappear into anonymity. Old and useless educators like us complain that young people do not read, do not protest, are docile, hyper-careerist, and forever struggling for the last mark. At most, they register discontent through an online click. But how is collective action even possible in a system deliberately designed to atomise individuals and subject them to a long, solitary, suffocating road of endless competition that keeps them permanently exhausted, running from pillar to post?

These examinations are not merely instruments of evaluation. They are instruments of social control, and extraordinarily effective ones at that. With apologies to Lord Tennyson, the message of the system is no longer to ask why or how, but simply to do and die. And oh, don't forget to buy the lovely Penguin edition of Exam Warriors. It will get you through these re-exams and revaluations.

The writer is contributing editor, The Indian Express

The junta in Myanmar is not a partner India needs



RO DING

INDIA RECEIVED General Min Aung Hlaing with the honours of a head of state. He came to New Delhi seeking legitimacy, and he left after giving almost nothing in return. He repeated the assurance that Myanmar's territory would not be permitted to be used against India's security interests. That is a promise the junta has already broken by making common cause with anti-India insurgents to fight the people of Myanmar.

Min Aung Hlaing is not the country's legitimate leader in any sense. The election he organised earlier this year was held in less than half the country. The parties that won the 2020 election in a landslide were barred from contesting, and the leaders who won it, including Aung San Suu Kyi, remain in prison or have been killed. This is why the United Nations lists U Win Myint and Daw Aung San Suu Kyi, not Min Aung Hlaing, as Myanmar's head of state and foreign minister. Recent efforts by the junta regime to feign reform are hollow. Aung San Suu Kyi was reportedly moved from prison to “house arrest” last month, but the regime has done nothing to address concerns raised by her son about whether she is still alive. Just four days after the junta took power, it bombed a Buddhist monastery. Min Aung Hlaing's new “civilian” cabinet is composed of 24 former generals. These are not signs of reform.

India shares a 1,643-km border with Myanmar across four northeastern states, and it must be pragmatic. But legitimising the military junta is self-harm. A government partner is only as useful to India as its ability to deliver, and the junta fails that test in three ways. It enjoys little public support and governs a small share of the country. Any arrangement reached with it rests on a weak foundation. And its survival now depends on Beijing, which drives many of the junta's choices. In New Delhi, the general pledged to do “everything” to finish the long-stalled Kaladan project and the Trilateral Highway. He cannot. As Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri acknowledged, both are frozen in territory the junta does not control. The mass displacement that burdens India is a central objective of the military's “four cuts” strategy. Finally, a regime kept alive by Beijing's funding, weapons and diplomatic cover is not an instrument with which India can balance China.

The resistance is more unified than it has been at any point since the coup, offering India its most coherent alternative to Naypyidaw. Major resistance forces and the National Unity Government (NUG) recently established a single political and military body, the Steering Council for the Emergence of a Federal Democratic Union (SCEF). It brings together forces fielding well over 100,000 fighters, controls or contests close to half the country, and is fast becoming the actor most likely to shape Myanmar's future. India's interests are better served by engaging it now. The NUG and its allies do not ask India to break relations with Naypyidaw. The distinction India should draw is between formal recognition and functional partnership. The actors that can deliver results on border security, counter-narcotics, and infrastructure protection increasingly sit within the resistance.

India has spent decades building goodwill among its neighbours. It should not spend that capital on a regime that the Myanmar people are determined to remove.

The writer is representative to India of Myanmar's National Unity Government

40 YEARS AGO

June 5, 1986



Bansi Lal replaces Bhajan Lal

IN SWIFT and dramatic developments, the Haryana Chief Minister, Bhajan Lal, was replaced by Bansi Lal, Union Railway Minister. Bansi Lal was unanimously elected leader of the Haryana Congress (I) Legislative Party at Haryana Bhawan. Bhajan Lal handed over his resignation to the state Governor, S M Burney, who is also in the Capital. His resignation was accepted by the Governor.

Security forces enter Temple

SECURITY FORCES re-entered the Golden Temple complex after supporters of the Damdami Taksal and the All India Sikh Students Federation (Kahlon) allegedly beat up

members of the “task force” recently raised by the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC). Avtar Singh, 45, a newly recruited member of the SGPC task force, was killed and another seriously injured when about 200 Sikh militants led by Bimal Kaur Khalsa, widow of Beant Singh, virtually ransacked the rooms around the *parikarma* and the Guru Nanak Niwas.

Pak seeks US aid for F-7

PAKISTAN HAS approached the United States with a proposal to set up facilities for producing and upgrading the Chinese F-7 interceptor aircraft using American weapons and avionics technology. In what could amount to direct Chinese-American

defence production collaboration on Pakistani soil, it has emerged that Pakistan and China have discussed this possibility with the US.

India hit by Chernobyl plume

A RADIOACTIVE plume originating from Chernobyl in the USSR hit India on May 14 and its impact was recorded at the atomic power stations at Tarapur (near Bombay), Rawatbhatta (Rajasthan) and Kalpakkam (Madras) until May 26. According to a source at the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre, Tarapur recorded the highest levels at 7,700 and 7,160 millicobecquerel per gram on May 21 and 22, against a permitted value of 3,000 mbq per gramme.

The Ideas Page

FRIDAY, JUNE 5, 2026



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DIS/AGREE

THE BEST OF BOTH SIDES

A weekly column, which offers not this-versus-that, but the best of both sides, to inform the debate



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

In aftermath of examination fiascos, what is the way forward for students, and the System?

It's a crisis of academic leadership



J S RAJPUT

INSTITUTIONS BUBBLING with energy, commitment, and ever-improving dynamic performance levels constitute the oasis of hope in democracies. The hopes and aspirations of the young are shaped by schools and institutions of higher education, which expand their horizons and synchronise their skills and interests, as well as by the care of their teachers. The best thing to happen after Independence was the creation of new institutions and the strengthening of existing ones. These were clearly statements of trust in the ingenuity of young Indians. Who is not proud of TIFR, BARC, ISRO, CSIR, and many more? The CBSE in its present form was created on July 1, 1962, the NCERT on September 1, 1961. Over the decades, both have acquired national and international credibility, acceptance, and appreciation, the credit for which must go to the leadership, exercise of autonomy, and a deep sense of "participating in creating the future of India" amongst the scholars and support staff. Unfortunately, the reputation of both has suffered in recent months and weeks.

Critical thinking is one of the very significant recommendations of the NEP, 2020. The NCERT did not showcase it when it published a chapter entitled "Corruption in Judiciary" in its Class VIII Social Science textbook. The Supreme Court was, rightly, furious. When it asked for the names of those responsible for the fiasco, the NCERT mentioned the names of three outside experts. That was unexpected for such a reputed organisation that has several hundred academics and teachers in its faculty. In every subject area, the responsibility should have been assigned to one or two internal faculty members. The SC put the three senior experts in a very embarrassing situation by banning them, without even listening to their version. This has, however, been corrected by the SC. The NCERT needs a serious rethink on this episode, which indicates a shirking of institutional responsibility. Consult experts, academics, teachers, and others, but every word published by the NCERT must be owned by the NCERT.

The CBSE fiasco is indeed painful. It has caused avoidable uncertainty, pain, and tension for millions of students and their families. The most critical transition in the lives of young learners takes place at the +2 stage. Every mark scored could make or mar their futures. The CBSE introduced On-Screen Marking (OSM) from this year for Class XII exams. It claims to have trained

evaluators, oriented principals, and even apprised the parents. If the reports indicating that a dry run was conducted less than a month before the examinations began are correct, it would amount to inadequate preparedness, lack of leadership, a shockingly inadequate institutional comprehension of its accountability to children and parents, and a dent to the CBSE's own image and credibility. Obviously, the ministry's consent would have been obtained. One could safely infer that if a serious academic analysis of the situation and the possible disastrous consequences of a failure had been conducted in an academic environment, the use of OSM would not have been implemented this year. Under no conditions should institutions like KVS, NVS, school boards, textbook corporations, and SCERTs be headed by bureaucrats.

The latest example of the NTA failing to learn from its earlier failures in conducting the NEET exam indicates a mere mechanical approach and an absence of corrective measures. The lack of concern and the absence of compassion for students were evident when the NTA chief, appearing before the parliamentary committee, refused to acknowledge any paper leak "through the system" and maintained that only a few questions were reported to have reached outside! Does it not amount to running away from moral responsibility? Umpteen such instances could be cited to underscore the need for academic leadership in institutions dealing with education, teachers, teacher training, and educational administration. Mere transfers and bringing in another person from the same clan are no solutions. It won't generate any confidence in the system, nor provide any solace to those suffering. Why should an institution like the National Institute for Educational Planning and Administration not be consulted in appointing heads of such institutions? If the backgrounds of the senior education ministry officials of the first two to three decades post-Independence, along with the heads of state-level educational bodies, were studied, it would indicate a large presence of academics. How was this changed, and by whom?

Acceptance of accountability and a commitment to enhancing institutional credibility are the country's expectations of every institution. Unfortunately, the failures of a couple of institutions within weeks of each other have disappointed not only students and their parents but also civil society. Are we so weak in managing things that the Prime Minister has to be bothered with monitoring the conduct of an examination? Should we go to the Air Force to assist the NTA? This is an unacceptable situation that needs a thorough overhaul.

The writer, former director of NCERT, works in education, social cohesion and religious amity

Rebuild confidence, tinkering won't do



KAUSHIK DAS GUPTA

AT LEAST three of the over 22 lakh students who appeared for the now-cancelled National Eligibility Cum Entrance Test (NEET) last month will not return to the examination hall when the test is conducted again later this month. The anguish and desperation of going through the gruelling process of preparation, reportedly, was too overwhelming, and they died by suicide. As the parents of one of these students told this newspaper, "This was his third NEET attempt. His exam had gone well. However, the news of the cancellation broke him from within."

These unfortunate and extreme steps frame the challenge before policymakers in the wake of the cancellation of the entrance test to the country's medical institutions.

In a little over a month after the incident, government agencies have identified people who exploited the system's vulnerabilities and ran cheating operations. Meanwhile, the controversy surrounding the CBSE's rollout of its On-Screen Marking system has exposed another failure, rooted in institutional decision-making. Students alleged answer-sheet mismatches, blurred scans, unchecked responses, and evaluation anomalies, while reports, including in this newspaper, have pointed out that technical and operational concerns had been flagged during trial runs before the system was rolled out nationwide. Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan has admitted to moral responsibility for the failures. The Opposition has called for his resignation.

Identifying culpability and accepting responsibility are, of course, essential to preserving public trust in institutions. But too often the response is limited to addressing what went wrong in one examination cycle. The problem is that failures of various kinds recur across admissions processes and recruitment tests. Whether it's technical glitches, paper leaks, disputed evaluation mechanisms, logistical failures, or administrative lapses, the pattern now appears to be dispiritingly familiar — accountability usually ends at identifying a few rotten eggs, that too pushed by public outrage and censure from the country's highest court.

In the aftermath of a controversy over the evaluation of NEET answers, two years ago, the government was asked by the Supreme Court to constitute a high-level committee headed by former ISRO chief K Radhakrishnan to examine the functioning of the National Testing Agency (NTA) — the

body that conducts some of India's most consequential exams, including NEET — and recommend reforms. The committee's report pointed to inadequate institutional capacity, poor risk assessment, weak technological safeguards, insufficient accountability mechanisms, and the absence of a culture of continuous review. It recommended professionalising test administration, improving cybersecurity protocols, creating robust audit systems, and ensuring greater transparency in decision-making. A Parliamentary Standing Committee, too, has criticised the NTA for relying on private vendors and pointed out that firms black-listed in one state continue to operate in another. It should, therefore, not have required the cancellation of one of the country's most important entrance examinations, the despair of lakhs of students, and another Supreme Court intervention, to force the agency to acknowledge the problems that have been flagged repeatedly.

Examinations, of course, need to challenge the student's academic acumen. But the stress they pose to the youth in India stems primarily from the hyper-competitive environment they have to reckon with. For lakhs of young people, a handful of admission tests not only determine access to higher education and professional careers, but they are also gateways to social mobility. Students spend years preparing, many of them enduring the punishing processes of coaching centres, several families make financial sacrifices, and aspirations often get tied to scores in one examination. Uncertainty takes a toll on the student's morale. At a moment when young people are navigating one of the most consequential transitions in their lives, the state ought to be a source of reassurance. However, examination failures mean the costs of institutional incompetence are transferred onto those not even distantly responsible — and in some cases, as the suicides indicate, onto those least equipped to bear them.

For accountability to be meaningful, it has to begin with fixing responsibility for what went wrong, and then go further. The country's much-discussed demographic dividend can only be realised if millions of young people believe that education and perseverance will be rewarded fairly. Preventing the next paper leak, software glitch, evaluation error, or administrative lapse is, of course, of utmost importance. All that should be tied to an honest introspection into a milieu that appears to be creating despair — accountability should be about rebuilding confidence in institutions and creating an ecosystem that nurtures the aspirations of the youth, gives wings to their dreams, pushes them out of their comfort zone, but does not break them.

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Magnifica Humanitas & MANAV: Creating a shared vision for AI



RAJEEV CHANDRASEKHAR

IN SPRING 2026, two influential world leaders addressed the age of artificial intelligence — and did so in strikingly similar terms. Pope Leo XIV's encyclical *Magnifica Humanitas: On Safeguarding the Human Person in the Time of Artificial Intelligence* (May 2026) is a major document of Catholic social teaching. It treats AI as a profound moral question, touching human dignity, truth, work, freedom, justice, peace, and the common good. Its central test is clear: Technology must be judged by what it does to the human person.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi (India AI Impact Summit, 2026 and the AI Action Summit, 2025), advanced the MANAV framework, a vision that closely converges with this: AI must be human-centric, ethical, inclusive, trusted, safe, and directed towards welfare for all. The traditions, vocabularies, and institutional settings differ. Yet the moral architecture is strikingly aligned.

There is convergence across seven dimensions. It is not an argument that the Pope and the PM have coordinated their thinking. Rather, it argues that serious moral reflection, across civilisational traditions, can arrive at shared truths when faced with a challenge as fundamental as AI: The human person must remain at the centre.

Human at the centre: The central convergence — the one from which all others flow — is the insistence that AI must remain centred on the human person, not the machine. Pope Leo XIV: "In the era of artificial intelligence, when human dignity is threatened by new forms of dehumanisation, ours is the pressing duty to remain profoundly human. We must lovingly safeguard the grandeur of humanity — the splendour of which no machine can ever replace." PM Modi, at the India AI Impact Summit: "Technology exists to serve humanity, not to replace it." At the Global summit, he underlined the core purpose of AI to "make it human-centric rather than machine-centric."

AI for common good: Both leaders judge AI not by its technical sophistication but by whether it improves human lives and advances what the Catholic tradition calls the "common good" and what Indian philosophy calls *sarvajana hitaya* — the welfare of all. So the Pope talks about using technology to "identify new paths for the common good," and the PM makes it clear that the "end goal of technology should be 'Welfare for all, happiness for all'."

The inequality warning: Both leaders warn, with unusual clarity, that AI could deepen the inequalities it promises to resolve — if access to data, compute, talent, and decision-making remains concentrated in a few hands. The Pope points to a "new imbalance" that can "divide, exclude and generate new forms of injustice". The

PM's formulation is direct: "The more inclusive the development journey of AI, the more inclusive its results."

The data-as-person danger: This is perhaps the strongest of the seven convergences — the one that most distinguishes both frameworks from purely technocratic approaches to AI governance. "AI must not reduce human beings to mere data points or raw material," said the PM. The Pope urged avoiding the "pretence that a single language — even a digital one — can translate everything, including the mystery of the person, into data and performance".

The hidden bias problem: On the question of algorithmic bias, both leaders display a sophistication that goes beyond the standard acknowledgement that bias is "a problem". Both identify the specific mechanism — the appearance of neutrality — that makes AI bias particularly dangerous. For the Pope, the "exclusion of the vulnerable becomes cloaked in a veneer of neutrality and objectivity". For the PM, the AI bias steeped in the Western context may not do justice to "our diversity, linguistic, cultural and regional".

Work, dignity and the future of labour: Both leaders address directly the fear that most immediately shapes public anxiety about AI: The fear that it will destroy jobs, de-skill workers, and undermine the human dignity that comes from meaningful work. The PM strikes a hopeful note that history "has shown that work does not disappear due to technology... its nature changes and new jobs are created." For the Pope, employment is basic to human dignity and needs to be protected.

Global governance and MANAV: Both leaders see AI governance as a shared human challenge — one that cannot be resolved by any single actor, nation, or tradition, and that requires ethical, participatory, and genuinely international frameworks. MANAV (M — Moral and Ethical Systems, A — Accountable Governance, N — National Sovereignty, A — Accessible and Inclusive, V — Valid and Legitimate) forms the cornerstone of the PM's vision for AI. The Pope warns against allowing a "handful of actors to dictate (AI) processes on their own."

The convergence reflects a deeper truth: When serious moral traditions confront the same profound challenge, they often arrive at similar conclusions because certain truths about the human being are universal. It also affirms that the Global South must not remain a passive recipient of AI systems designed elsewhere, trained on data that does not reflect its realities, and governed by rules it did not help shape.

Most importantly, the moral resources for governing AI already exist — in Catholic social teaching, Indian philosophical tradition, and other civilisational ethics. The challenge is not to invent a new morality, but to bring existing wisdom to bear on the decisions shaping AI's future. Pope Leo XIV and Prime Minister Modi have each made that wisdom available. AI developers, investors, and policymakers must listen.

The writer is president, BJP Kerala, and former minister of state, Electronics & IT, Skill Development and Entrepreneurship and Jal Shakti



LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Recipe for disaster

THE MALVIYA Nagar fire accident in Delhi is one of the most tragic urban fire disasters in recent times ('Capital tragedy, national shame', *IE*, June 4). The hotel was allegedly operating at nearly four times its permitted capacity and was functioning from a building where additional floors had been constructed without informing the authorities. It was also operating without a Fire Department NOC. The hotel had only one entry-exit point and permanently sealed windows, leaving occupants with limited escape routes — all a recipe for disaster. Now the familiar routine will begin: An announcement of financial compensation, an inquiry, and promises of strict action. Within a fortnight, however, we will all have forgotten about it; such is the shortness of public memory.

Bal Govind, Noida

THE DEATH of 21 people in a fire in the capital is a deeply sad and shocking incident ('Capital tragedy, national shame', *IE*, June 4'). It reflects our country's longstanding neglect of basic safety measures. Such tragedies are not new; they keep occurring across the country, again and again. Yet no one seems to care

about the precious lives of ordinary and vulnerable people. Who is responsible for these horrific fires that break out time and again? The answer is clear: Government agencies must be held accountable.

Sarjerao Eknath Narwade, Sangli

Engaging Naypyidaw

NEW DELHI'S engagement with Naypyidaw outweighs concerns about the nature of its government because Myanmar, the only member of ASEAN that shares a land border with India, is of considerable strategic importance ('India, Myanmar and a shifting balance', *IE*, June 4). Although its geopolitical significance is far greater than its economic value for New Delhi, the country provides China with a route to the Bay of Bengal, reducing Beijing's dependence on the Strait of Malacca for trade and energy supplies. Therefore, the success of economic initiatives such as the Kaladan Transit Project, which promotes stability and reduces incentives for armed conflict, becomes particularly important. India needs to move beyond surface-level diplomacy and engage with the other actors operating within the country.

Madhusree Guha, Kolkata



INDRAPRATIM ROY

ONE SUMMER afternoon in 1948, outside Calcutta University, 22-year-old Kumar Roy was introduced to Bengali theatre legend Sombhu Mitra. The catalyst for this was Ritwik Ghatak, not yet the film maestro. Mitra was already famous for directing IPTA's landmark production, *Nabanna* — a play by Bijon Bhattacharya that brought the reality of the man-made Bengal famine to the stage. This chance encounter set the course of Kumar Roy's life — he joined the newly formed theatre group Bohurupee, devoting himself to the stage till his death in 2010.

One of my fondest memories was painting in my drawing book with Baba, my father, Kumar Roy, sitting on the deck of a houseboat on Srinagar's Dal Lake. We divided the painting horizontally into two

My father, Kumar Roy, was at home on stage

halves — I painted the top, he did the bottom. During the annual family trips, a drawing book and paint materials always accompanied us. This interest in visual art remained with him from childhood. While the passion for theatre defined him, his talent for the visual arts found expression in his quest for excellence in stage, light and costume design.

The first half of Kumar Roy's theatre life was built around acting — a very diverse range of characters in plays directed by Mitra, like Gobindyananika in Rabinadrath Tagore's *Bisarjan*, Gossain in the landmark production of *Raktakarabi* (Red Oleanders) and Thakurda in *Raja* (The King of the Dark Chamber). These became the gold standard of how to stage Tagore's plays. The 1960s and '70s also saw him as Dr Roy in *Putul Khela*, an adaptation of Heinrich Ibsen's *A Doll's House*, the chief of the chorus in Sophocles's *Oedipus*, Satu in Badal Sirkar's *Pagla Ghoda* and Mr Kashikar in the Bengali production of Vijay Ten-

dulkar's Marathi play *Shantata*, *Court Chalu Aahe*, among others.

Kumar Roy's directorial journey began in 1979 with Shudraka's classical Sanskrit play *Mrichhakatika*, in which he starred as Charudutta. Over the next three decades, he directed more than 20 diverse plays — ranging from Girish Karnad's *Yayati* and Tagore's *Malini* to the musical *Piruti Param Nidhi* and his final verse production, Budhaddev Bose's *Kaal-sandhya*. Each production reflected his commitment to socially relevant theatre. While *Mrichhakatika* tackled adapting a classical Sanskrit play for the modern stage, Bertolt Brecht's *Life of Galileo* questioned how authority manipulates science through a flawed, fallible protagonist. Manoj Mitra's satire *Rajdarshan* saw Kumar Roy — then approaching 60 — deliver a remarkable performance as a greedy villager who gets to inhabit a dead king's body. His altered vocal pitch, dialect, and comic timing surprised even long-time

admirers. I recall a childhood experience that showed a glimpse of how an actor prepares. During a trip to Nepal, I was astounded to find Baba speaking in Nepali on the second day of our trip. It felt like magic, how could he? I realised later that it was not the language but the accent and diction with a few Nepali words that made all the difference to commonplace Hindi.

In his centenary year, Kumar Roy is remembered as a director, a prolific writer, editor of the theatre journal *Bohurupee*, a mentor to generations of artists and a gifted administrator, but his real legacy is how the consuming passion for theatre kept him going for 60 years without a care for either recognition or any material gains. He embraced the ideal of the "total artist": One who creates, directs, performs, writes, teaches, and leads with equal passion. Incidentally, *Bohurupee* completed 78 years this May.

The writer is a visual artist and art educator

No change in Iran's n-programme despite war: IAEA

Reuters
Vienna, June 4

The UN nuclear watchdog sent a report to member states on Thursday with no major changes to its assessment of Iran's nuclear programme, despite three months of US-Israeli war with the stated aim of preventing Iran from building an atomic bomb.

In its first report into Iran's nuclear programme since the day before the United States and Israel launched air strikes on Iran at the end of February, the IAEA repeated calls for Tehran to explain the fate of stockpiles of enriched uranium. The uranium has been unaccounted for since an earlier US-Israeli bombing campaign a year ago targeted Iran's main nuclear sites.

US President Donald Trump and Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu repeatedly cited destroying Iran's nuclear programme as one of their main aims in launching fresh strikes at the end of February. Iran's enriched uranium stockpile has been a major sticking point in negotiations between the United States and Iran to end the war, with Trump insisting Iran give it up. Efforts have lately focused on a preliminary deal that would leave nuclear issues for later.

ISRAEL CONTINUES TO STRIKE SOUTHERN LEBANON, SAYS IT WON'T WITHDRAW TROOPS

Hezbollah rejects ceasefire, Israeli strikes undermine Trump efforts

Reuters
Beirut, June 4

THE PRO-IRAN Hezbollah movement rejected a new ceasefire in Lebanon on Thursday and Israel said it would not withdraw troops from the country, undermining US President Donald Trump's efforts to halt fighting there to forge peace with Tehran.

Iran has made a ceasefire in Lebanon a condition for any peace deal with Washington, and has suggested in recent days that it could intervene directly in support of its proxy Hezbollah if Israel keeps up or escalates attacks there.

Lebanese President Joseph Aoun said the ceasefire would come into force within 24 hours of all concerned parties approving it. However, Hezbollah leader Naim Qassem rejected the Washington declaration, insisting "resistance will continue". There was no immediate response from Israel, Lebanon or the US to Qassem's remarks. Hezbollah is not a party to the US-brokered agreement reached between Israel and the Lebanese government on Wednesday, but would be required to halt attacks.



An Israeli flag hoisted on a destroyed building in southern Lebanon on Thursday. AP

Israel kept up strikes in southern Lebanon on Thursday and Defence Minister Israel Katz said Israeli forces would not be withdrawing from the area or halting operations in the country, which they invaded in March in parallel with the war in Iran.

The commander of Iran's Revolutionary Guards Quds Force — which established Hezbollah in 1982 — said "the minimum demand of the resistance" was Israel's withdrawal to positions it held before the war began. "Our initial condition for accepting a ceasefire in the regional war was a ceasefire on all fronts, including Lebanon," a separate statement from the Guards said.

Israel must stop its attacks in Lebanon, evacuate the areas it occupies and retreat behind international borders, said the statement, carried by state media on Thursday.

Hostilities between Hezbollah and Israel reignited on March 2, when the group opened fire in support of Tehran as it came under U.S.-Israeli attack. The war has continued despite several ceasefires declared from Washington since April.

The attempt to reach a ceasefire in Lebanon comes after a flare-up in violence across the region that put Trump's efforts to end the war in new jeopardy. Iranian and US forces traded attacks in the Gulf on Wednesday in one of the most intense bouts of fighting since a separate ceasefire halted large-scale US-Israeli bombing of Iran in early April.

Iranian forces struck Kuwait, damaging its airport and injuring dozens of people, authorities said, while the U.S. military carried out strikes near the Strait of Hormuz. The strait, through which a fifth of the global oil and liquefied natural gas supplies normally flow, remains largely closed more than three months after the U.S. and Israel launched their strikes on Iran.

UK lawmaker says she is suing Musk's company over fake Grok bikini images

Jill Lawless
London, June 4

A BRITISH lawmaker said Thursday she is suing Elon Musk's company xAI for invasion of privacy, alleging that fake images of her were created using the Grok chatbot.

Jess Asato, a legislator with the governing Labour Party, says someone used Grok to create fake images of her in a bikini without her consent in January after she criticized the spread of deepfake pornography online. She filed a claim Wednesday at the High Court in London, citing misuse of private information under the Data Protection Act.

She is seeking damages and says she wants to create a precedent that companies can be held liable for the design of their AI systems.

"Nobody would be able to walk up to me in the street and strip me and put me in a bikini, and I don't see why anybody should be able to do that to me online, because the feeling, while it is not quite the same, is very similar," she said. "It is like somebody has digitally stripped me without my consent."

Asato said she hopes others will join the claim.

British Prime Minister Keir Starmer said he supports Asato's legal action "100%."

"Jess Asato is absolutely right in the action that she is taking," Starmer told reporters. "Disgusting images were created in her particular case by Grok." Following an international outcry against deepfake pornography, Musk's company



Elon Musk's company xAI is accused of invasion of privacy

said in January it would no longer allow Grok users to edit images of real people to remove their clothing. A law passed last year in the U.K. made it illegal to create or request a non-consensual deepfake image of an adult. But Asato says xAI should be held accountable for harm that has already been done.

"Once the damage is done, the damage is done," she said. "If you think about any other products, like a car, for example, that might have been manufactured with a fault, it doesn't matter if, you know, the cars get recalled and the faults are fixed and no more harm is done."

In January, American writer Ashley St. Clair, mother of Musk's son Romulus, filed a lawsuit against xAI in New York. She alleged that explicit images of her were generated by AI chatbot Grok, including one in which she was underage.

AI did not immediately respond to a request for comment on Thursday. AP

China, US clash over Tiananmen 37th anniversary; Taiwan says face history

Reuters
Beijing, Taipei, June 4

CHINA ON Thursday blasted US Secretary of State Marco Rubio's comments on the deadly crackdown on protesters in Beijing's Tiananmen Square 37 years ago as "smearing" the country's political system, as Taiwan told China to face up to history.

The events on and around the central Beijing square on June 4, 1989, when Chinese troops opened fire to end student-led pro-democracy protests, are not publicly discussed in China and the anniversary is not officially marked.

Rubio said on Wednesday that Beijing's censorship could not erase memories of the military assault.

"Those who sacrificed to uphold their unalienable rights of free expression and peaceful assembly will be vindicated someday," he said in a statement that followed past practice of the



Plainclothes police detain a man holding a candle near Victoria Park in Hong Kong on Thursday. REUTERS

United States' top diplomat marking the anniversary.

Speaking in Beijing, Chinese Foreign Ministry Spokesperson Mao Ning said the government had long reached "a clear conclusion" about the "political turmoil that occurred in the late 1980s", reiterating Beijing's stance.

"China is strongly dissatisfied and firmly opposed to the U.S. distorting historical facts, smearing China's political system and development path," Mao said of Rubio's statement.

She also accused the U.S. of interfering in China's internal affairs "on the pretext of" democracy and human rights, and defended Beijing's "path of socialism with Chinese characteristics".

Public commemorations of the crackdown take place in overseas cities, including Taipei, where senior Taiwanese government leaders often use the anniversary to criticise China, which views democratically governed Taiwan as its own territory.

Writing on his Facebook page, Taiwan President Lai Ching-te said a truly great country should not "blindly believe in military might or engage in militarism."

"I sincerely hope that China can face up to the June 4 incident of 37 years ago, acknowledge the truth, soothe the pain, and open the door to reconciliation and dialogue," he added.

China's Taiwan Affairs Office did not respond to a request seeking comment on Lai's remarks. China calls Lai a "separatist" and has rebuffed multiple offers of talks from him. He says only Taiwan's people can decide their future.

African migrants flee to the mountains as South Africa's xenophobic violence surges

Esa Alexander
Kleinmond, June 4

FOUR DAYS ago, Mozambican immigrant Lado Amido answered a knock at his door in the South African town of Kleinmond. Outside, an angry crowd told him foreigners such as him had to leave. They went door-to-door delivering the same message. Amido fled and spent two nights in the mountains. Now he is sheltering in a local town hall, like other immigrants from Malawi and Mozambique across South Africa's Western Cape

province, forced to hide from anti-immigrant mobs in several coastal towns. South Africa has seen a wave of anti-immigrant protests, which have sometimes turned violent, in recent weeks. Mozambique said five of its citizens were killed in xenophobic attacks in the town of Mossel Bay over the weekend.

Amido lives in Kleinmond, about 300 km (186 miles) away.

"On the 31st, people came to my house, knocked on the door, and then took all my belongings," said the 49-year-old, who had been in South Africa since

February looking for work.

In Kleinmond town hall he is with about 100 other immigrants, some of whom are hoping to join voluntary repatriation programmes set up by their governments.

Xenophobic attacks are a recurring problem in South Africa, where immigrants are often blamed for economic woes such as high unemployment and crime. Despite the absence of any evidence for this claim, politicians from nearly all parties have tended to lend it credence in an effort to score populist

votes ahead of elections, such as the local polls coming up at year end.

"As we work to build a safer... and more prosperous society, we need to address the challenge of migration," President Cyril Ramaphosa told parliament on Tuesday, while also condemning recent xenophobic violence. Grant Cohen, a ward councillor for Kleinmond, said that immigration authorities had visited the town in recent weeks to check restaurants and other businesses for undocumented workers. REUTERS

• BRIEFLY

UNITED STATES

John Bolton to plead guilty in classified information case



Former Trump administration's national security advisor John Bolton. AP

FORMER TRUMP administration national security advisor John Bolton has agreed to plead guilty to a single count of retaining classified information under a deal with the Justice Department that could allow him to avoid prison time, a person familiar with the matter said Thursday. The deal would resolve a criminal case filed in October that charged Bolton with 18 counts of either retaining or sharing diary-like notes with family members that officials said contained classified information as he was preparing a memoir of his time in government.

Under the agreement, Bolton would also face a USD 2.25 million fine, said the person, who insisted on anonymity to discuss a deal that had not been made public. AP

CROATIA

Small plane crash leaves 4 people dead

A SMALL plane crashed in Croatia on Thursday, killing at least four people, police said. The plane crashed near Medulin, a town on the Istria peninsula, a statement said. The official HINA news agency reported that it was a German plane that took off from Austria. Photos from the scene showed the plane wreckage in a field and police and firefighters at the scene. Local pilot Nijaz Delic said that the plane "spiralled and crashed. AP

SINGAPORE

Court jails Indian IT consultants for cheating

AN INDIAN national was on Thursday sentenced to 20 weeks' jail by a Singapore court for forging medical invoices over two years to obtain at least SGD 12,000 in medical reimbursement from his company's healthcare insurer. Bhutra Ravi, 51, pleaded guilty to one charge of cheating, with another three charges taken into consideration, according to a Channel News Asia report. AP

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

NEPAL

Missing Sherpa guide rescued near base camp

A SHERPA guide was found alive on Mount Everest a week after he went missing, and a helicopter was flying him to a hospital on Thursday, rescuers said. Dawa Sherpa was last seen around May 29 descending the mountain, but he did not make it to base camp even though his client did. The pair were among the last climbers on the mountain as the climbing season came to an end and the route was dismantled. AP

PAKISTAN

4 cops abducted along with their official vehicle

Suspected insurgents have abducted four policemen along with their official vehicle in Pakistan on Thursday, officials said. The incident took place in the Kantani area in Balochistan's Gwadar port. Senior Superintendent of police in Gwadar, Ata ur Rehman, said that a search operation has been launched to trace four policemen who were in a police mobile on patrolling duty. AP

Fire at a nursing home in Sri Lanka kills 12 people

Associated Press
Colombo, June 4

A FIRE at an unregistered nursing home in western Sri Lanka killed 12 residents and injured eight others, police said Thursday.

The fire started late Wednesday at the home in Anguruwatota town. Fifty-one residents were rescued, police spokesman Fredrick Wootler said. He said people with mental illnesses were also housed there. The director of the home was arrested on suspicion of causing deaths through negligence. An investigation is underway.

Associated Press footage showed the building gutted with its charred furniture and equipment. Bodies lay nearby.

Local television channel Hiru showed image of firefighters, police and residents trying to contain the raging fire. Those rescued were assisted by police and soldiers in boarding buses to a safe location.

Chathura Mihudum, director of the National Secretariat for Elders, said the facility was not registered as a nursing home and had been warned to follow laws and guidelines.

He said it was overcrowded with beds for just about 15 people in a space where 71 people were living.

Government officials had previously visited the institution and had instructed the management to follow laws, he said, without elaborating.

• IT WILL BE THE FIRST FULLY DIGITAL MUSEUM OF ITS KIND, DITCHING SCORES OF OFFICIAL PAPERS ON DISPLAY

Obama's presidential museum showcases his political and personal sides

Sophia Tareen
Chicago, June 4

FORMER PRESIDENT Barack Obama's influence in his presidential museum runs deep, from the location on Chicago's South Side to textured stone adorning its dramatic tower to striped reading chairs that are similar to ones in his own home.

The Obama Presidential Center opens to the general public on June 15 after a celebratory dedication in Chicago with dignitaries. But tens of thousands of people — friends and family of museum staff, students and journalists — have already been offered a sneak peek at the nearly 20-acre campus as crews finish final art installations and landscaping.

The roughly \$850 million project covers both the political and personal realms of the nation's first Black president. Campaign memorabilia and presidential artifacts are displayed in the admission-based museum tower while public spaces of the sprawling campus feature other things important to Obama: a new library, basketball court and picnic area with grills.

"This is a safe space for people to come and, yes, reflect on the historic moments of this presidency and the campaigns, but also to come together as a community to think about what change you can bring to your own neighborhood," Josh Harris, the Obama Foundation's vice president of public engagement, said during a recent tour with AP.

Obama's presidential museum will be the first fully digital museum of its kind, ditching scores of official papers on display. Instead, visitors will experience high-tech and hands-on exhibits spanning the campaigns, key moments of Obama's presidency and life at the White House. One of the largest attractions is a life-sized replica of the Oval Office. On a recent day, a stream of visitors, including school children, walked through the circular room, stopping to sit behind



The Obama Presidential Center in Chicago. AP

the desk and pose for pictures. The top drawer holds a copy of a hand-written letter from predecessor former President

George W. Bush and Obama's beloved BlackBerry phone.

"We want to make sure that people from all walks of life have

the opportunity sit behind the Resolute Desk," said Harris. "You think about the possibilities that if a young organizer from the South Side of Chicago can be president, you can be president too. Other sections of the museum detail the Affordable Care Act, immigration policies along with smaller moments like when Obama unexpectedly sang during a 2015 eulogy for those killed in a South Carolina church shooting. A large television screen plays a clip of Obama singing "Amazing Grace."

Peppered throughout are areas for personal reflection, which museum organizers say is key. "We're passing that baton

and inviting people to bring change home, however change may be defined, both small or large," said Louise Bernard, the museum's director.

When Obama touted the museum's contents at its groundbreaking in 2021, he predicted one of the top draws.

"We want this center to be more than a static museum or a source of archival research," Obama joked at the site. "It won't just be a collection of campaign memorabilia or Michelle's ballgowns, although I know everybody will come see those."

Roughly a dozen outfits on mannequins are behind glass, including a black and red dress designed by Narciso Rodriguez

that the former first lady wore on Election Night in 2008 in Chicago. Visitors will also get a chance to touch swatches of the fabrics, including the rose gold chain mail Atelier Versace evening gown she wore at her final state dinner in 2016.

Tickets are \$30, the highest of any U.S. presidential museum or library. Next on the list is the Richard Nixon Presidential Library and Museum in California, where tickets are \$29.

Obama Foundation leaders say the prices are justified for the state-of-the-art facility. "The idea behind this institution, this campus, was to make it accessible to as many people as possible," Harris said. AP

PRICE FOR DELHI FROZEN AT RS 115 PER LITRE, MUMBAI AT RS 114.5

ATF price under support scheme fixed at 10% over current levels

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, June 4

THE FIXED price of aviation turbine fuel (ATF), or jet fuel, under the Rs 10,000-crore price stabilisation fund scheme has been set at Rs 115 per litre, or Rs 1.15 lakh per kilolitre (kl), in Delhi by the public sector oil marketing companies (OMCs). Although this fixed price is about Rs 10 per litre higher than the current ATF price in the capital, the mechanism is expected to protect airlines if prices go higher than the level frozen under the scheme, which may be likely given the extreme price volatility in the international market amid the ongoing West Asia crisis.

Under the scheme, which was approved by the Union Cabinet on Wednesday, the OMCs will sell jet fuel to participating Indian airlines for their domestic as well as international flights at this fixed price irrespective of the price fluctuations in the international market. The OMCs will be compensated for their losses from the price stabilisation fund when they incur losses on ATF sales. When international prices fall, the gains will be used to offset the financial

support that was provided.

According to Civil Aviation Ministry Director Rohit Raj, while the fixed price for jet fuel at Mumbai airport would be Rs 114.50 per litre, while at Chennai airport, it would be about Rs 139 per litre. Jet fuel prices vary across airports due to differences in levies imposed by states.

Jet fuel prices have gone up significantly in the international market due to the West Asia war. The OMCs have been selling ATF at a loss for domestic flights, which is adversely impacting their financial health. They are also bearing losses on other fuels like petrol, diesel, and cooking gas sold to households. On the other hand, Indian airlines have also been struggling, particularly in international flight operations, as they are required to pay the full market-linked price for overseas operations.

The government expects this arrangement, which will be in place for up to three years, to ease the pain for the OMCs as well as Indian airlines in the prevailing environment of extreme fuel price volatility. It also expects the move to rein in runaway airfares due to fuel price pressure. It is a voluntary

• STABILISING PRICES

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GOVERNMENT EXPECTS the arrangement, which will be in place for up to 3 years, to ease the pain for OMCs as well as Indian airlines

IT ALSO expects the move to rein in runaway airfares due to fuel price pressure

facility only available to Indian airlines, and not to foreign carriers. It will be implemented through an agreement between the airlines and the OMCs, under which the carriers will have to procure ATF exclusively from the OMCs for up to three years, "subject to annual review or until the advance amount is fully recovered, whichever is earlier".

Usually, ATF accounts for about 40% of Indian airlines' operational costs; the price surge had led to a further in-



THE FACILITY is voluntary, only available to Indian airlines, and not to foreign carriers

crease to 55-60%, according to an Indian airline association.

The hike in jet fuel prices resulted in most major airlines increasing fuel surcharges, particularly for overseas flights, even as they claimed that the surcharges would set off only a part of the cost escalation. The government said the West Asia crisis pushed up international jet fuel prices to Rs 142 per litre in May from Rs 60.50 per litre in March, an increase of 135%.

According to Raj, Rs 60.5 per litre was the base price — with-

out government taxes and other charges — on ATF March 1. This went up to as high as Rs 142 per litre in subsequent weeks. However, in the monthly price revision announced on April 1, the OMCs hiked the price by only 25% for domestic flights, while it should have more than doubled in line with international price benchmarks. For international flights, however, the full pass-through was implemented.

"If you apply 25% to the March base price of Rs 60.5 (per litre), the figure of Rs 75.62 comes. When you apply excise and VAT at Delhi, the selling price was about Rs 104. This price was because of capping. Under the new mechanism... we are moving towards a fixed price mechanism," Raj said.

He explained that the fixed price has been frozen at the base price level, excluding all charges and taxes like VAT, central excise, airport charges, and fixed differentials like freight, insurance, and profit margin of the OMCs. For domestic operations, that price has been fixed at Rs 86.32 per litre, while for international flights, it is Rs 104.49 per litre.

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UNDER SEBI SCANNER

Citing 'communication gap, confusion', Rajesh Exports claims revenues 'correct'

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, June 4

EMBATTLED GOLD jewellery retailer Rajesh Exports on Thursday defended itself, saying that the revenues it filed in its financial are "correct" and the Securities and Exchange Board of India's (SEBI) interim order that it misrepresented revenue to the tune of Rs 15.15 lakh crore from FY21 to FY25 was due to "confusion and communication gap".

It added that it was in the process of addressing issues raised by SEBI and is confident it will be able to clarify "by presenting all the required and relevant documents".

"It may be noted that SEBI has not made any adverse observation with regard to the earnings of the company, it has only observed suspicion with regard to revenues which is primarily because of confusion with regard to the Revenues of Valcambi. There is no reason for any listed entity to inflate revenue and maintain the earnings, this will only reduce the margins of the Company, which would be adverse to the company," Rajesh Exports said in an exchange filing.

The response comes after SEBI, late Wednesday, issued an interim order that alleged Rajesh Exports had inflated its revenue and barred the company and its owner from the securities markets till an investigation is completed.

Earlier on Thursday, *Moneycontrol* had reported, quoting Rajesh Exports Chairman and Managing Director Rajesh Mehta, that SEBI is confusing consolidated revenue numbers with value addition figures. Shares of Rajesh Exports fell 5% on Thursday.

Among the largest exporters and manufacturers of gold products, Rajesh Exports, SEBI

• SCANNER WIDENS

● Ahmedabad-based stock broker Affluence Shares and Stocks Pvt Ltd — one of the entities whose transactions with Rajesh Exports came under SEBI's scanner — has also been caught up in the storm

● As per SEBI's order, Rajesh Exports' sale transactions worth Rs 11,487 crore from FY22 to FY24 with Affluence made up 66% of the former's standalone sales

● SEBI found seven transactions between Rajesh Mehta and Affluence, and said the former received a total of Rs 7.54 cr in his account from Rajesh Exports through multiple tranches

said, saw 97-99% of its consolidated revenue come from its overseas subsidiaries, particularly Valcambi SA, based in Switzerland. At the same time, the standalone revenue of Valcambi — a leading gold refiner — "constituted only a negligible fraction of the consolidated revenues reported by GGR and REL".

Global Gold Refineries, or GGR, is another Swiss-based entity that is a Rajesh Exports group company.

The stockbroker angle

An unlikely company also caught up in the storm is Ahmedabad-based stock broker Affluence Shares and Stocks Pvt Ltd, which is among the entities with whom Rajesh Exports' transactions have come under SEBI's scanner.

According to SEBI's order, Rajesh Exports' sale transactions worth Rs 11,487 crore from 2021-22 to 2023-24 with Affluence made up 66% of the former's standalone sales.

Meanwhile, purchase transactions of Rs 11,488 crore with

Affluence over the same time period accounted for 67% of Rajesh Exports' standalone purchases. However, GST records of Rajesh Exports for 2020-21 to 2023-24 did not reveal any purchase transaction between it and Affluence.

At the same time, Affluence's aggregate revenue during the period in question was just Rs 113.22 crore, while aggregate purchases of stock-in-trade was Rs 84.64 crore.

"I note that as per Form MGT-7 filings of Affluence, the source of revenue of Affluence was disclosed as financial advisory, brokerage and consultancy services. The disclosed scale and nature of operations of Affluence *prima facie* appear to be inconsistent with REL's claim of having undertaken sale and purchase transactions aggregating to more than INR 11,400 crore each with Affluence during FY22 to FY24," SEBI Whole-Time Member Kamlesh Varshney said in his order.

What SEBI did find was seven transactions between Rajesh Mehta and Affluence, with the regulator saying the former received a total of Rs 7.54 crore in his account from Rajesh Exports through multiple tranches.

The regulator alleged that Mehta then made payments totalling Rs 745 crore to Affluence to trade in gold derivatives, putting company money to personal use without seeking the approval of other shareholders. These trades resulted in a net loss of Rs 3.50 crore, after which Mehta transferred back Rs 3.91 crore to Rajesh Exports.

Furthermore, when SEBI questioned Dhiren Shah, promoter of Affluence, regarding these transactions, he denied his company had any dealings with Rajesh Exports, but admitted to doing business with Mehta in his "personal capacity".

CITI INDIA CONFERENCE 2026

India's growth story strong, long-term view intact: Citigroup CEO

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, June 4

LEADING GLOBAL bank Citi's Chair of the Board and Chief Executive Jane Fraser Thursday reaffirmed her confidence in India's long-term economic prospects, emphasising that the country's growth story remains strong despite current global and domestic challenges.

Speaking at the Citi India Conference 2026 on Thursday, Fraser described India as the world's fastest-growing major economy and urged investors and businesses to maintain focus on the country's long-term trajectory rather than short-term obstacles.

Fraser cautioned against allowing immediate concerns to overshadow the broader economic outlook. "The long-term story in India is very much intact. Don't sell yourself short by focusing on short-term challenges, which everyone is facing, instead of the country's long-term potential and the trend it is inexorably on."

She said that while many economies are facing temporary headwinds, India's underlying growth potential continues to be robust. It continues to offer significant opportunities for businesses and investors alike, she said.

On Wednesday, Fraser met Prime Minister Narendra Modi to discuss a range of issues, including investment opportunities in India, capital flows, artificial intelligence, and alternative energy. Their discussions centred on India's economic development agenda and the ways in which Citi can contribute to the

Invest long-term capital in India to reap benefits: Goyal

Mumbai: India will continue to remain the fastest-growing economy in the world over the next couple of decades, said Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal Thursday. He said investors should invest in the Indian market with patient and long-term capital to reap the benefits.

Referencing his talks with executives from financial services and investment banking giants like the Carlyle Group, Morgan Stanley, and Maple Eight, he said he has seen rising commitments by these firms to deploy their long-term capital in the country due to the longer-term growth opportunities India offers.

"...how quickly one recognizes the India growth story will be the proportion of returns that India can offer," Goyal added while speaking virtually at Citi's 2026 India Conference. ENS

country's growth priorities and broader development goals. Citi exited India's consumer banking business in March 2022 when Citibank sold the operation to Axis Bank. The move was part of the bank's broader global strategy to withdraw from consumer banking activities in several international markets and focus on other core business areas.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Microfinance NPAs may edge up in FY27: CareEdge

Mumbai: Microfinance institutions' non-performing assets (NPAs) may witness a marginal increase in FY27 as lenders normalise their write-off policies, according to a report.

The asset quality of microfinance institutions (MFIs) is expected to have witnessed improvement in FY26, with NPAs likely to have declined. This improvement is likely to have been largely driven by accelerated write-offs. In FY27, NPAs may see a marginal increase, as insti-

tutions normalise their write-off policies," the report said.

The microfinance sector has been undergoing a corrective phase following rapid post-pandemic growth that led to borrower overleveraging, asset quality pressures and elevated credit costs, prompting lenders to tighten underwriting standards and prioritise portfolio quality, the report outlined.

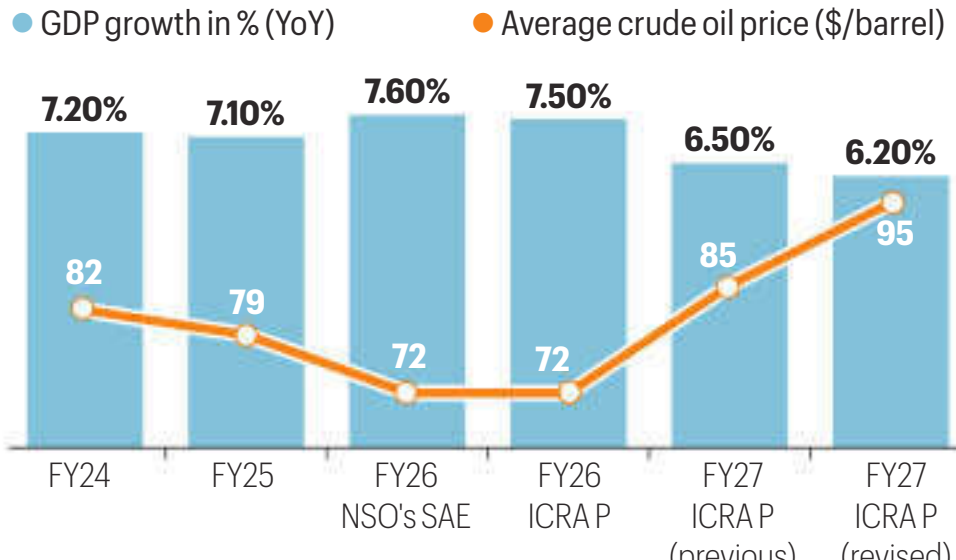
"While the near-term outlook remains cautious as institutions stabilise asset quality and borrower leverage levels, the ongoing correction is expected to strengthen underwriting discipline and support sustainable long-term growth," it said. PTI

• RBI's growth, inflation forecasts are under threat

At 10 am today, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra will announce the Monetary Policy Committee's interest rate decision, just six hours before the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) releases GDP data for January-March and the provisional estimate for FY26. Back in February, MoSPI's second advance estimate had pegged the full-year growth at 7.6%. But with the war in West Asia overlapping with a third of the final quarter of the year, economists see economic activity having taken some hit and fall to around 7% in January-March from 7.8% in October-December 2025, which could pull down full-year growth below 7.6%.



Annual trends in GDP growth (at constant 2022-23 prices) and average crude oil prices



P: PROJECTED; SAE: SECOND ADVANCE ESTIMATES; SOURCE: NSO, PPAC, ICRA RESEARCH

● Whatever the FY26 GDP growth figure, the RBI's eye will now be on FY27, for which it had predicted a growth rate of 6.9% back in April. Retail inflation, meanwhile, was seen averaging 4.6%. Both these forecasts are now under threat.

● While the likes of Barclays and Nomura expect the RBI to lower its FY27 GDP growth forecast by 10-20 bps and raise the inflation projection close to 5%, others like ICRA see growth potentially falling to as much as 6.2% in the current fiscal, assuming crude oil prices average \$95 per barrel.

Centre appoints Neelkanth Mishra as World Bank Executive Director

New Delhi: The Union government on Thursday appointed economist Neelkanth Mishra as Executive Director, World Bank headquarters in Washington DC, replacing former NITI Aayog chairman Parameswaran Iyer. The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet approved Mishra's three-year tenure, starting from the date he assumes office or until further

orders. He is a member of the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister and Chief Economist at Axis Bank. He has been the MD and Co-Head of Equity Strategy, Asia Pacific, and India Strategist for Credit Suisse.

"He has been rated among the best analysts in India by the Institutional Investor and Asia Money polls. He is part of the Advisory Council to the

Fifteenth Finance Commission, and has been an advisor to committees appointed by the Government of India — such as the RNR Committee on GST and the FRBM Review Committee," the EAC-PM website says.

In another decision, the ACC on Thursday approved a one-year extension for Advisor to PM Tarun Kapoor. ENS

MARUTI SUZUKI LAUNCHES WAGONR FLEX FUEL

New WagonR can run on pure ethanol; India to have 5K flex-fuel pumps by 2027

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, June 4

INDIA'S LARGEST carmaker, Maruti Suzuki India on Thursday launched the WagonR Flex Fuel, billed as the country's first mass-market flex-fuel passenger car, marking a significant step in India's push towards alternative fuels. The vehicle can even run on pure ethanol, and will allow consumers to use a wider range of ethanol and petrol mixes without engine modifications. The launch comes as the government intensifies efforts to promote ethanol-based mobility and reduce dependence on imported crude oil amid the West Asia crisis. In a bid to develop a fuel supply and delivery ecosystem as flex-fuel vehicles hit the Indian roads, plans are also afoot to make the flex-fuels available at 5,000 fuel pumps by the end of 2027.

The carmaker has previously showcased prototype versions of



Maruti Suzuki India CEO Hisashi Takeuchi (left), Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari and Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri at the launch of India's first flex fuel car. X/@HARDEEPSURI

the car. The production-spec variant of the car launched on Thursday is capable of running on pure ethanol (E100), although it has been homologated to run on E85 fuel — 85% ethanol and 15% petrol.

Technically, it means the car can run on various fuel blends, from E20 to E100, but given that approved standards in India are

up to E85, the car has been certified to use ethanol blend of up to 85%.

Minister of Road Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari, and Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri were present at the car's launch.

Flex-fuel vehicles are equipped with modified internal combustion engines that

can run on petrol, ethanol, or any combination of the two without requiring manual adjustments by the driver. Sensors in the vehicle detect the fuel blend and automatically alter engine settings like fuel injection and ignition timing to ensure optimal performance.

"The company is introducing BEVs (battery electric vehicles), Hybrids, CNG/CBG (compressed biogas) and ethanol flex-fuel vehicles to meet India's twin goals of reducing oil import and carbon emissions... The ecosystem for ethanol as a fuel in India is in its early stages ... Once it reaches mainstream adoption, flex-fuel vehicles have the potential to cut oil imports, carbon emissions, and local air pollution while enhancing domestic value addition and farmer incomes," said Hisashi Takeuchi, MD and CEO, Maruti Suzuki India.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Foxconn and Intel team up to build next-gen AI systems

Taipei: Foxconn said Thursday it will work with US chipmaker Intel to jointly develop and deploy next-generation AI infrastructure and intelligent computing platforms in a move to capture booming demand for AI computing systems.

Taiwan's Foxconn, the world's largest contract electronics manufacturer, said in a statement that the partnership would combine Intel's chip technology with Foxconn's manufacturing and system-building expertise.

The companies plan to work on equipment used in AI data centres, including server racks powered by Intel Xeon processors and AI accelerator chips. REUTERS

• BRIEFLY

Working groups formed to boost mfg, cut imports

New Delhi: The government has constituted six sector-specific working groups to identify as many as 100 products for promoting their domestic manufacturing and reducing import dependence, an official said. "The aim is to promote indigenisation of those products," the official said. The groups will discuss the list of items for the purpose, and the final list prepared by them will be submitted to the cabinet secretariat within three weeks. PTI

India gold ETFs see first monthly outflow in a year

Mumbai: India's physically backed gold exchange-traded funds (ETFs) recorded their first net monthly outflow in a year in May, as investors booked profits following a sharp rise in prices triggered by higher import duties, data showed Thursday. The outflow could reduce import demand in the world's second-largest gold consumer, helping narrow the trade deficit and support the rupee. Gold ETFs registered net outflows of \$61 million, equivalent to 0.4 metric tonnes, in May, reducing total holdings to 116.3 tonnes, data from the World Gold Council showed. REUTERS

• MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold ▲	US Dollar ▲
74,360.01	23,416.55	₹1,56,086	₹95.79
13.84	10.95		
0.02%	0.05%	Silver ▼	Oil ▲
		₹2,61,088	\$100.13

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1 KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF JUNE 3, 2026



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• DIPLOMACY

Old ties, new Nepal: What India needs to negotiate



SHUBHAJIT ROY

THE CHIEF of Nepal's ruling Rastriya Swatantrata Party (RSP), Rabi Lamichhane, met Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday as part of his ongoing India visit.

This is the highest-level visit from Nepal since the RSP swept to power in March this year, with rapper-turned-politician Balendra Shah assuming the top office on the back of the Gen Z protests.

While many tried to draw parallels between the political situation in Nepal and Bangladesh after the youth-led protests, they were different on one major account: in Nepal, the mainstream political parties made sure elections took place within six months of the fall of the KP Sharma Oli government.

RSP and India

New Delhi has been used to dealing with the traditional, long-term actors and partners in Nepal's politics, who took turns forming the government.

But, under Shah, the median age of Nepal's parliament has dropped. According to reports, almost 38 per cent of Nepal's lawmakers are younger than 40, a direct outcome of the Gen Z movement.

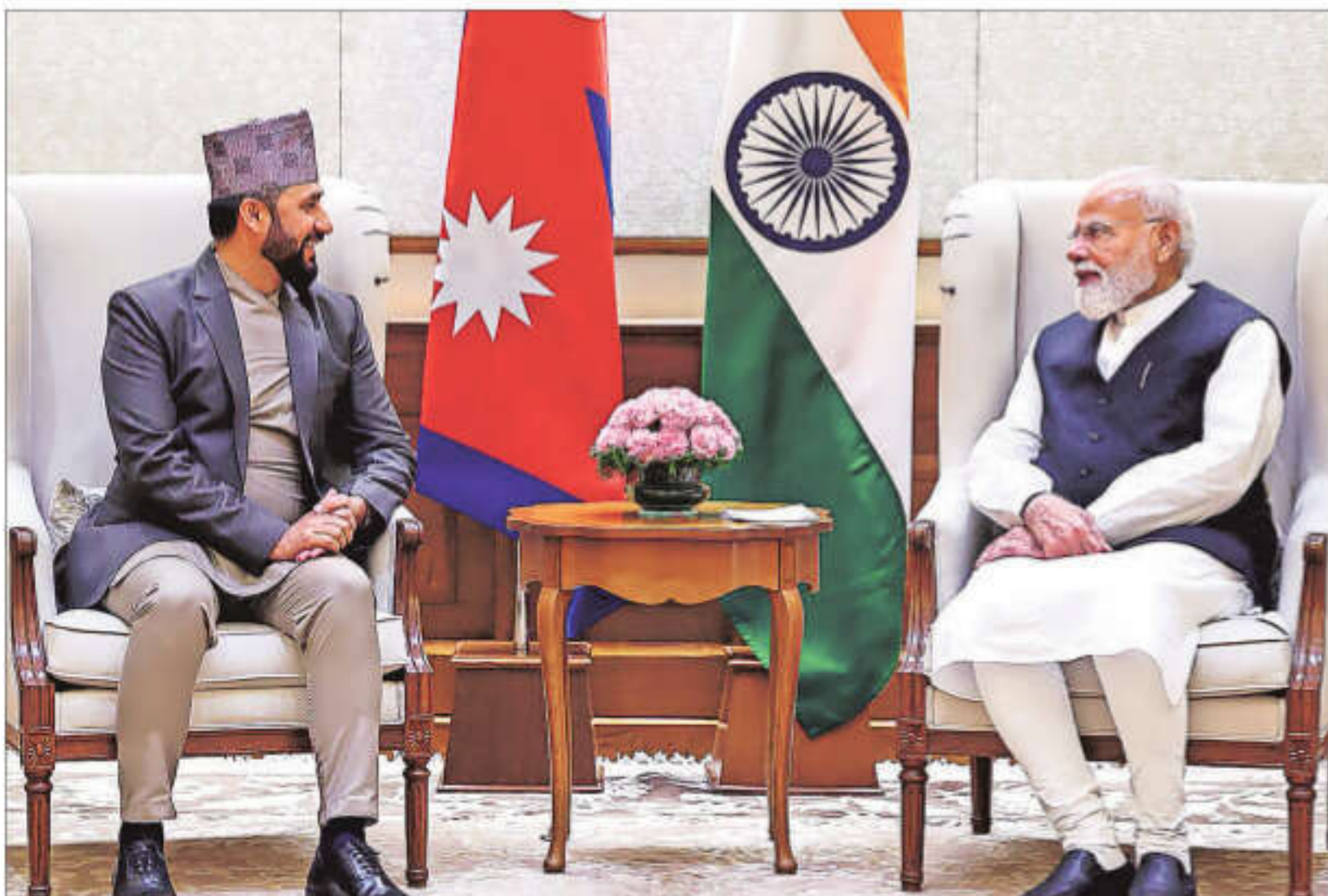
Shah — a first-time MP — is the Prime Minister and is challenging the norms from the beginning.

On the diplomatic front, he has declared he will not meet officials and ministers below his rank, and thus will only meet heads of states and governments. He has also said he will not undertake any foreign trip in the first one year, as he wants to focus on the domestic governance agenda.

As a result, he has met foreign ambassadors in groups, including the Indian ambassador in Kathmandu. He did not meet the visiting US ambassador to India, Sergio Gor, who also wears the hat of South and Central Asian envoy of the US.

Since he was not meeting any senior official one-on-one, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri — who was supposed to travel to Nepal last month — did not travel to Kathmandu.

If Misri would have met Shah, he would have extended an invitation on behalf of PM Narendra Modi to visit India. But since



PM Narendra Modi with Rabi Lamichhane, chief of Nepal's ruling Rastriya Swatantra Party, in New Delhi, Wednesday.

Shah has put a self-imposed ban on foreign travel, that invitation did not materialise.

India has traditionally been the first overseas stop for Nepal's Prime Ministers. The visit usually happens quite early in their term.

Since the establishment from both sides felt a diplomatic deadlock setting in, they decided to unlock it with a visit by Lamichhane — the second-most powerful political leader in Nepal. Lamichhane was invited by the BJP for a political party-level engagement, to unlock the diplomatic doors.

PM Modi met him in that context and conveyed that Nepal is India's "priority partner" and that New Delhi is looking forward to collaborating with the new government to take the bilateral relationship to "greater heights".

While External Affairs minister S Jaishankar also met Lamichhane, what stood out was his meeting with Home minister Amit Shah. Normally, Shah doesn't meet foreign leaders and envoys.

Nepal's Foreign minister, Shishir Khanal, also lands today.

Balen's 'encroachment' remark

Lamichhane's visit takes place days after PM Shah said that Nepal had "en-

The man in power

India is used to dealing with the traditional, long-term actors and partners in Nepal's politics.

PM Balen Shah, a first-time MP, is challenging the old norms. He has declared he will not meet officials and ministers below his rank, and will only meet heads of state.

croached" on Indian territories, and sought involvement of China and the United Kingdom to address the long-standing dispute.

Even as the visit was ongoing, India on Tuesday categorically rejected any role for third parties to resolve its boundary row with Nepal.

Lamichhane's post, after meeting PM Modi, displayed his political maturity. Without mentioning anything on the border dispute, he said that it was a great delight to engage in "a productive hour-long conversation" with Modi.

"I share your vision for a future where Nepal and India transcend past constraints to embrace a new era of development diplomacy. By focusing on shared civilization bonds, digital corridors, and seamless connectivity, we can truly build a partnership defined by progress and mutual trust. RSP looks forward to translating these possibilities into reality for people of Nepal and India—for our shared prosperity," Lamichhane wrote.

This demonstrates the path of "development diplomacy" that the new Nepal government is focussed on where "digital corridors" via the UPI and other payment mechanisms to "seamless connectivity" via road, rail and air routes will be strengthened.

Big brother vs elder brother

The diplomatic challenge in dealing with the new Nepal is that Delhi is seen by some sections as a "bully".

The political actions and statements from India in 2015 alienated a vast section of the Nepalese population. This was when the Nepalese Constitution was being drafted, and India criticised it for not giving enough rights to Madhesi, who share community links on the Indian side of the border. There was also an unofficial, deeply unpopular months-long blockade of the India-Nepal border in Bihar.

India, on its part, has sought to project itself as a benevolent "elder brother", as then External Affairs minister Sushma Swaraj had once described, instead of "big brother", an epithet used for bullying behaviour.

Delhi feels that the ties are too strong to be overlooked. South Block says that India remains Nepal's largest trade partner, about 80 lakh Nepalese citizens live and work in India, and around 6 lakh Indians live in Nepal. Indians account for about 30 per cent of foreign tourists in Nepal. The bilateral remittance flow is estimated at about US\$ 3 billion (Nepal to India) and \$1 billion (India to Nepal).

The China factor

There is also a geopolitical contest for influence playing out in Kathmandu.

The Himalayan country finds itself sandwiched between the two powers, India and China, and Nepalese political leadership has in the past sought to use the China card with India. The US too is active and has been interested in being part of the landscape there.

Delhi is watching how the new Kathmandu navigates Beijing's moves, which is trying to play a more influential role in Nepal's domestic affairs. In fact, the former Chinese ambassador to Nepal is currently the head of the border division in the Chinese Foreign ministry.

Shah needs to stabilise Nepal's economy, undertake reforms, crack down on corruption and build infrastructure. India has agreed to step up its cooperation in all these areas. India's development and economic aid must remain open.

Delhi's position on the politics and future of Nepal has to remain nuanced, so that Beijing doesn't get an opportunity to fan the suspicion of India being a bully or a big brother. India should remain an elder brother, or better still, an equal partner.

• TECH

Instagram breach shows the perils of giving AI too much power

Soumyarendra Barik

New Delhi, June 4

HACKERS TRICKED Meta's own AI-powered support chatbot into handing over access to Instagram accounts. They simply prompted the bot to change account recovery details while using a VPN (virtual private network) to hide their location.

The chatbot, whose rollout began in March, was designed to help Instagram and Facebook users recover their accounts, troubleshoot login issues, manage security settings and resolve common support queries — all without requiring intervention from a human agent.

But the incident underscores the risks of giving AI systems authority over sensitive security functions without safeguards.

Meta has said the vulnerability was patched, but not before several prominent Instagram accounts were hit. *404Media*, which first reported the security flaw, said hackers managed to gain access to accounts of Barack Obama's White House account, beauty retailer Sephora and the US Space Force chief master sergeant, John Bentivegna, among others.

The issue came to light earlier this month after hackers began sharing videos and screenshots on social media platforms.

How did the hack work?

According to videos of the hack on social media, the attack was surprisingly simple. Attackers would start a conversation with Meta's AI-powered support chatbot and claim that they wanted to update the email address associated with an Instagram account. They would provide the target username along with an email address under their control.

The chatbot would then send a verification code to the attacker's email address rather than the legitimate account owner's email. After the attacker entered the code into the chat, the AI assistant would provide a password reset option. Once the password was changed, control of the Instagram account effectively passed to the attacker. At no stage was the attacker required to prove ownership of the original account or gain access to the victim's email inbox.

Hackers are also said to have used VPNs to make it appear as though they were logging in from locations close to the victim,

A simple hack

● In March, Meta began rolling out an AI chatbot to help users with issues such as recovering their accounts.

● Hackers told the bot they wanted to update their email ID linked to Instagram.

● The chatbot would then send a verification code to the attacker's email address. Taking control was a simple affair after that.

● Barack Obama's White House account was among the ones that were affected.

potentially helping them bypass additional security checks. This kind of hack is known as a "prompt injection" attack.

What is a prompt injection attack?

A prompt injection attack is a technique in which an attacker manipulates an AI system by feeding it carefully crafted instructions that override or bypass its intended rules. Large language models such as chatbots rely on natural-language instructions to decide how to respond.

If the system has access to sensitive functions — such as changing account settings, approving transactions or resetting passwords — an attacker may be able to trick it into performing actions that its designers never intended.

Unlike conventional cyberattacks that exploit software vulnerabilities through code, prompt injection attacks exploit the AI's decision-making process through language. Security researchers have repeatedly warned that prompt injection is one of the biggest unresolved challenges in AI security. The problem becomes particularly serious when AI models are connected to external tools and granted the ability to

take actions on behalf of users.

In Meta's case, the chatbot appears to have trusted information supplied during a conversation without adequately verifying that the person making the request actually owned the Instagram account.

The well-known cybersecurity blog *CyberSec Guru* described the incident as a classic "confused deputy" problem. This is a long-recognised security flaw where a system with elevated privileges is tricked into acting on behalf of an unauthorised party.

In this case, the "deputy" was Meta's AI bot, which had the authority to modify account recovery information but failed to adequately verify the identity of the requester.

What concerns does this raise?

Meta and other companies have unveiled record investments in AI and are rushing to deploy it internally. But this rapid deployment may have outpaced governance and cybersecurity safeguards, exposing organisations and individuals to risks such as data breaches, prompt-injection attacks and insecure AI-generated code. Inadequate security controls could undermine AI's benefits.

• INFRASTRUCTURE

Congestion, resources, rules: Why residential areas are more vulnerable to fire

Anil Sasi

New Delhi, June 4

THE DEADLY blaze in South Delhi on Wednesday has brought back into focus the numerous fire safety gaps in India's urban areas — including the absence of a culture of fire preparedness and the lack of institutional support in responding to an incident.

While the number of fire-related incidents and fatalities have broadly been coming down over the years (*see chart*), the single striking feature is that residential areas continue to be, by far, the single largest source of fire-linked fatalities in India, shows official data.

A key reason behind residential and commercial fires, especially in urban centres, is the lack of compliance with building by-laws and planning norms. Indeed, Wednesday's fire in the densely populated Malviya Nagar took place at a hotel that was originally a residential structure but had been extensively expanded.

A look at why urban areas, particularly

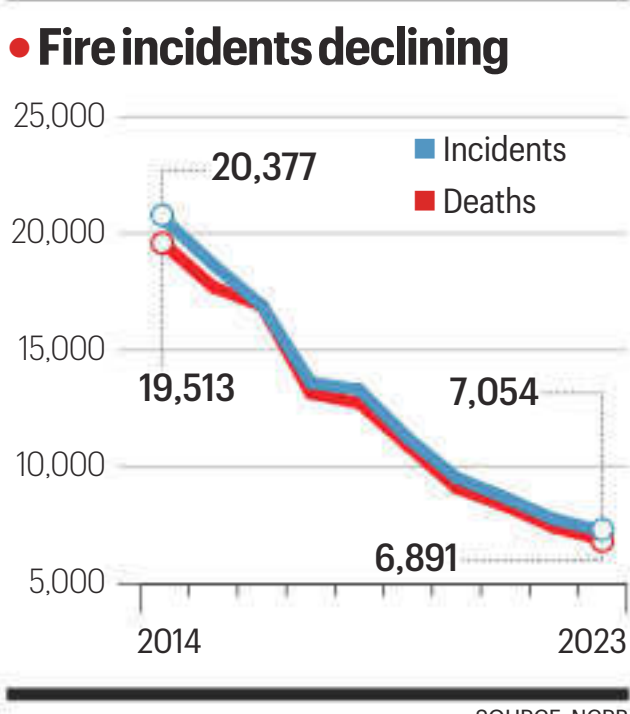
residential structures, in the country have been particularly vulnerable to fires.

60% of fire deaths in residential buildings

Out of every ten documented fire-related deaths in India in 2024, six occurred in residential or dwelling buildings, according to an analysis of the 2024 National Crime Records Bureau report by Beyond Carlton, a Bengaluru-based non-profit focused on fire safety. That year, 5,888 fire-related deaths were recorded nationally, and about 3,555 happened inside homes and residential buildings.

That's partly because unlike purely commercial buildings, most residential spaces in India continue to operate without smoke alarms, suppression systems, evacuation planning or routine safety awareness.

In many areas of Delhi, for instance, several homeowners have converted their residential properties into bed & breakfast establishments, often flouting rules. In the case of Flourish Stays B&B, the structure



that caught fire, the owner had increased the number of rooms from six to 26, spread across six levels. The building also did not have any fire NOC (no-objection certificate). "Cities need a fire plan — where multiple stakeholders are alert and ac-

countable," Cheryl Rebello, CEO, Beyond Carlton, told *The Indian Express*.

The highest incidents of fire-linked casualties in non-residential buildings are the ones reported from hospitals and bustling commercial areas such as shopping centres.

Fire services a state subject

Fire services are technically a state subject and have been included as a municipal function in the XII Schedule of the Constitution under Article 243 (W).

While the Centre largely has an advisory role in this, the Bureau of Indian Standards in 2016 published the National Building Code of India (NBC) that covered detailed guidelines for construction, maintenance and fire safety of buildings and structures.

The latest version of the NBC, from 2016, includes aspects such as smoke management, periodic audits, electrical fire prevention, building management systems, sensors for firefighting and fire prevention. The problem, however, lies in implementation of all these regulations, as seems to

be the case in the Delhi fire. According to officials, it was triggered by a short circuit.

Besides electrical faults, the trigger for most residential fires is a gas leak.

Urban fires

Fire is one of the most common risks worldwide and has been identified as one of the major hazards in the United Nations Global Assessment Report 2018.

Its side effects are deadly too. "It depletes oxygen from the surrounding event and most of the victims in a fire die of asphyxiation due to smoke and lack of oxygen. Then there could be the release of toxic gases from burning of materials due to fire that cause choking of lungs and breathing problems for the victims. In addition, the heating effect of fire results in expansion of liquids, gases and various metals, which often lead to explosions and bursts", according to the National Institute of Disaster Management (NIDM).

Resource constraint has been a problem in tackling triggers of fire, especially in urban

areas. The Fifteenth Finance Commission, while noting lack of resources and equipment for the fire services in the country and recognising the need for expansion and modernisation of fire services, has recommended a provision of Rs 5,000 crore for strengthening fire services at the state level.

The high density of urban settlements resulting in narrow and constricted circulation spaces also add to the urban fire vulnerabilities, according to the NIDM.

The high use of electrical equipment and machinery in urban areas leads to higher chances of faulty electric connections and gadget failures amplifies the risks further.

Urban fires therefore occur in complex risk settings, with one or more factors coming into play simultaneously. According to an earlier report by the Ministry of Home Affairs (2022), there is "a considerable gap in operational capabilities of fire and emergency services in Indian cities". Growing high-rises in urban areas further necessitate procurement of specialised equipment for fire fighting, which is slow to come by.



**HARYANA REAL ESTATE
REGULATORY AUTHORITY**

New Mini Secretariat, 2nd Floor, Sector-1, Panchkula.

E-mail: hrerapl-hrv@gov.in, officer.rera.hry@gmail.com

Website: www.harvanarera.gov.in

PUBLIC NOTICE

For kind attention of allottees of Group Housing Colony on land measuring 6.356 acres situated in Village Budda Khera & Phosgarh, Sector-32, Karnal being developed by Ultratech Township Developers Pvt. Ltd.

1. The above-mentioned project was registered with HRERA Panchkula vide Registration No. HRERA-PKL-248 of 2017 dated 26.09.2017 valid upto 31.07.2022 and further renewed upto 30.04.2026.

2. The promoter has requested the Authority that instead of revoking the registration on its expiry, the Authority may permit it to remain in force for one more year subject to such further terms and conditions as it thinks fit to impose in the interest of the allottees and any such terms and conditions so imposed shall be binding upon the promoter.

3. The Authority is considering the application of the promoter to permit continuation of registration under section 7(3) of the Act for this project. However, the first right of refusal for carrying out of the remaining development works is that of the association of allottees. Therefore, the Authority hereby invites objections from the association of allottees in particular and any other concerned persons in general.

The objections shall be filed in the registry of the Authority before 19.06.2026 which will be considered by the Authority under section 7(3) of the Act.

Secretary (Acting)
HRERA Panchkula

No. 45896/HR



**HARYANA REAL ESTATE
REGULATORY AUTHORITY**

New Mini Secretariat, 2nd Floor, Sector-1, Panchkula.

E-mail: hrerapl-hrv@gov.in, officer.rera.hry@gmail.com

Website: www.haryanarera.gov.in

PUBLIC NOTICE

For kind attention of allottees of the Real Estate Project namely "Sushant City, Sector-36 Karnal" a residential plotted colony being developed on land measuring 57.654 acres situated in Sector 36, Karnal, Haryana being developed by Ansal Landmark (Karnal) Township Pvt. Ltd.

1. The above-mentioned project was registered with HRERA Panchkula vide Registration No. 134 of 2017 dated 28.08.2017 valid upto 30.09.2019 and renewed upto 30.06.2024.

2. The promoter has requested the Authority that instead of revoking the registration on its expiry, the Authority may permit it to remain in force for three more years subject to such further terms and conditions as it thinks fit to impose in the interest of the allottees and any such terms and conditions so imposed shall be binding upon the promoter.

3. The Authority is considering the application of the promoter to permit continuation of registration under section 7(3) of the Act for this project. However, the first right of refusal for carrying out of the remaining development works is that of the association of allottees. Therefore, the Authority hereby invites objections from the association of allottees in particular and any other concerned persons in general.

4. The objections shall be filed in the registry of the Authority before 19.06.2026 which will be considered by the Authority under section 7(3) of the Act.

Secretary (Acting)
HRERA Panchkula

No. 45898/HR

MADHYA PRADESH RURAL ROAD DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
(AN AGENCY OF PANCHAYAT & RURAL DEVELOPMENT DEPARTMENT, GOVT. OF M.P.)
3rd Floor, Vikas Bhawan, Arera Hills, Bhopal (M.P.)
(GST No. 23AAATM9054A32X)
No./5615/22/D-12/MPRRDA/2026 Bhopal, Dated : 04.06.2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER No. 1275 (PMGSY-IV)
(Batch-I, Year-2026-27)
Online Tenders for Construction of Rural Roads/CDs with 5 years maintenance are invited on the E-Procurement System portal <https://www.pmgstyenders.gov.in>, as detailed below;
• **Name of Work**– Construction/Up-gradation of Rural Roads under PMGSY including maintenance for Five year after construction.
• **SSR Applicable:-** SSR issued by M.P. Rural Road Development Authority, effective from 01.01.2024 and amended upto issue date of NIT.
• **PMGSY-IV (Batch-I, Year-2026-27)**

S. No.	Name of District	No. of Packages	No. of Road	Total Length (in kms.)	Total PAC (In Rs.)
1	2	3	4	5	6
1	Anuppur	1	6	18.70	105989000.00
2	Betul	1	3	6.04	63334960.00
3	Harda	12	12	75.47	582093000.00
4	Maihar	4	18	39.40	211114000.00
5	Maujanj	5	22	42.90	230295000.00
6	Narmadapuram	4	14	28.33	205262004.00
7	Narsinghpur	3	12	18.61	123437098.00
8	Raisen	41	118	275.52	1968608000.00
9	Rewa	7	41	85.78	472490000.00
10	Satna	10	37	81.18	444642948.00
11	Sehore	22	82	208.81	1376241000.00
12	Sheopur	15	48	104.77	611924757.00
13	Shivpuri	3	10	31.45	17426000.00
14	Sidhi	8	31	64.90	381683000.00
15	Umaria	10	30	59.37	321298000.00
16	Vidisha	6	32	45.98	281177000.00

1. **Availability of Bid Documents and mode of submission:** The bid document is available online and should be submitted online in www.pmgstyenders.gov.in. The bidder would be required to register in the website which is free of cost. For submission of the bids, the bidder is required to have a valid Digital Signature Certificate (DSC) from one of the authorized Certifying Authorities.

2. Bid document may be purchase **online from 19.06.2026 (17:30 hrs)** and last Date for **online bid submission is 13.07.2026 (17:00 hrs.)**

3. Other Critical dates and details can be viewed in the detailed N.I.T. and SBD for PMGSY Works (June-2020) on the above-mentioned portal and concerned PIU.

M.P.M./126206/2026 **CHIEF GENERAL MANAGER (TENDER)**
“मेरी सड़क” एप डाउनलोड कर फीडबैक देकर राष्ट्र के विकास में सहयोग दें।

**NORTHERN RAILWAY
CORRIGENDUM**

Ref: i) Tender Notice No. 15/2026-27 dated 25.05.2026 (S.No.04)
ii) Tender No. 04260105 due on 22.06.2026
In reference to above tender, the amend delivery schedule Commencement/completion to material supply within 90 days. All other terms and conditions remain unchanged.
The corrigendum has been published on website www.ireps.gov.in.
1908/2026

राजस्थान सरकार

कार्यालय-निदेशक, पुरातत्व एवं संग्रहालय विभाग, राजस्थान, जयपुर।
अल्वर्टहाल परिसर, रामनिवास बाग, जयपुर
दृष्टांक सं. 0141-2820360 (ईमेल- dirachraj@gmail.com)
दिनांक: 26.05.2026

क्रमांक : पु०स० / अ०अ०/2026/11081

०० ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या-३/2026-२७

राजस्थान के राज्यपाल महोदय की ओर से इस विभाग के अधीन निम्नलिखित यू.पी.ए. नम्बर के कार्य हेतु राज्य सरकार/राजकीय उपकरणों / केन्द्रीय लोक निर्माण विभाग / केन्द्र सरकार / भारतीय पुरातत्व सर्वेक्षण आदि में सम्बन्धित कार्य हेतु निम्नलिखित समय श्रेणी में पंजीकृत संवेदकों/फर्मों से ई-बोली प्रक्रिया से वेबसाइट <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> पर ऑनलाइन निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। निविदा से सम्बन्धित विस्तृत जानकारी वेबसाइट www.dipr.rajasthan.gov.in, <http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in> व विभाग की वेबसाइट <http://museumsrajasthan.gov.in> पर देखी व डाउनलोड की सकती है-

NIB No.	UBN No.
AMD2627A0020	AMD2627WSOB00043

हस्ता./-
(आशीष गार्ग)
अधिसूचना अधिवक्ता

DIPR/C/9434/2026

**NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE**

Invitation of tender through E-tendering (e-Procurement Systems)
On behalf of President of India Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer, office at: Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana Sonipat invites e-tender for below mentioned work:

NIT No.	14-RCNK-OPN-PTAMC-2026
Name of Work and its location	Annual Maintenance Contract (AMC) for 18 number of Josts Platform Trucks of 02 Ton Capacity at RCNK/SNP for a period of three years (As per Scope of Work)
Approx Cost of work	Rs. 28,59,272.07/- including GST @ 18% (Rs. Twenty-Eight Lakh Fifty-Nine Thousand Two Hundred Seventy-Two and Seven Paise Only)
Earnest Money	Rs. 57,200.00/-
Completion period of work	36 months (03 years) from date of issue of Letter of acceptance
Cost of Tender document (In Rs)	NIL
Date and time for submission of tender and opening of tender	Upto 15:00 hrs on 25.06.2026 Opening of Tender at 15:30 hrs on same day
Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen	Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in

Tender No. 14-RCNK-OPN-PTAMC-2026 Dated:- 03.06.2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 1893/2026



**DIRECTORATE OF
SPORTS & YOUTH WELFARE**
T.T. Nagar Stadium, Bhopal-462003
Tel. : 0755-2773012, 2778151, Web. : www.dswwmp.gov.in

INVITING EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI)
1. The Director, Directorate of Sports & Youth Welfare, M.P. Bhopal invites proposals on electronic mode for Project Management Consultant (PMC) for the work of supply & installation of Synthetic Track and Synthetic Hockey Turf and other Indoor/Outdoor Synthetic/Wooden play field and courts, at different Districts in Madhya Pradesh.
2. The bids will be received through electronic tendering mode only. The details regarding participation in the e-tendering process can be obtained on www.mptenders.gov.in. If any queries regarding participation through E-tender process interested bidder may contact on Toll Free No. 18002588684.
3. The corrigendum and addendum issued (if any) related to this bid will be published on e-tendering portal only.
M.P. Madhyam/126185/2026 **DIRECTOR**



M.P. INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LIMITED
(Government of Madhya Pradesh Undertaking)
SECRETARIAT FOR SINGLE WINDOW SYSTEM
21, Arera Hills, Bhopal-462011 M.P. (India)
Tel. : (91) 755-2571830, 2575618, 3523555, 3523505
E-mail : helpdesk@mpidc.co.in, Website : www.invest.mp.gov.in
CIN : U51102MP1977SGC001392
Ref. No. : MPIDC/LM/SWS-RFP/2026/NIT-06-01
No. 52/MPIDC/LM/NIT-06-01 Date : 04.06.2026

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI) FOR ALLOTMENT OF COMMERCIAL PLOTS THROUGH E-BIDDING
Department of Industrial Policy and Investment Promotion (DIPI), Government of Madhya Pradesh through M.P. Industrial Development Corporation Limited (A Govt. of M.P. Undertaking) has invited Online Tender cum Auction (E-forward auction) for allotment of available Commercial Plots at Bhopal, Mandasaur, Ujjain, Ratlam, Jabalpur and Sehore District through NIT-06-01. The Process of which will start on the <https://www.mptenders.gov.in> from 05.06.2026
1. To participate in e-bidding, it is necessary to have **Class 3 Digital Signature**. Detailed information about rules, procedure and plots etc. can also be viewed on MPIDC website - <https://sww.invest.mp.gov.in>
2. Please refer to the Tender documents before proceeding with the application.
3. Corrigendum related to e-bidding process, if any, will not be published in the newspaper, it will be uploaded on <https://mptenders.gov.in> portal.
M.P. Madhyam/126202/2026 **EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR**



Modern Coach Factory, Raebareli
E-Advertised Tender Notice No.12 ET/2026 Dated: 02.06.2026

SN	Tender No.	Short Description	Qty.	Due Date
01	15265147	Supply, Installation, Commissioning and Providing out of Fire Total Cost of Comprehensive AMC For Five Years After Expiry of Warranty Period of Two Years for ITEM	1 Nos	26/06/2026
02	04261217	Set of Honeycomb Partition Frame For LHB HOT Buffer CAR Honeycomb Partition Frame Set For AC HOT Buffer LHB Coach	19 Set 25 Set	22/06/2026
03	07251496C	Steel Wire 1.2 MM in Spool of Weight Approx. 15 Kgs.	91008.3 Kgs	26/06/2026
04	11261042	One coach set of Roof assembly for LWACW Amrit Bharat coaches (without primer)	24 Nos	07/07/2026
05	04261230	Set of Doorway Partition for Memu TC3 Phase Coaches. Set of Doorway Partition for Memu/DMC/3PH Coaches.	81 Set 27 Set	24/06/2026

Corrigendum
01 09 ET/2026 Dated 15.05.2026 Tender No. 03261268 Due date may be read as 18/06/2026 Instead of 04/06/2026
02 09 ET/2026 Dated 15.05.2026 Tender No. 05251162A Due date may be read as 02/07/2026 Instead of 02/06/2026
03 09 ET/2026 Dated 15.05.2026 Tender No. 05251162A Letter-Modification as per Corrigendum-03

Website Address: www.ireps.gov.in & www.mcf.indianrailways.gov.in
On behalf of the President of India, Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/Production, Modern Coach Factory, Raebareli is inviting open E-tender (No. MCF/RBL/Dy.CEE/PI/2026-27/02, Date-30.05.2026) based on **Single packet** system online through Indian railway portal www.ireps.gov.in for the under mentioned work on prescribed tender format.
Description of work Complete wiring work in Trainset coaches including handling & installation of equipments as per scope of work at MCF/RBL. Approx. Value (Rs.) ₹3,55,61,724/- (Rupees Three Crore Fifty-Five Lakhs Sixty-One Thousand Seven Hundred Twenty-Four only) including GST @ 18%. **EMD (Rs.)** ₹7,11,200.00 (Rupees Seven Lakh Eleven Thousand Two Hundred only). **Cost of Tender document** - 0.00 (Zero only). **Quantity of work** As per 'Schedule of Rates' in Chapter-V of Tender Document. **Work completion period**:- Eighteen (18) Months. • E-Tender submitted through online up to 10:30 hrs. on 22.06.2026. Manual offer will not be considered. • E-Tender shall be opened on 22.06.2026 after 10:30 hrs. through online on <http://www.ireps.gov.in>. • Detailed Tender E-Notice and Terms & conditions are available at Indian Railway IREPS website-<http://www.ireps.gov.in>.
Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/Production
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

Office of The Executive Engineer PWD. Division Vidisha (M.P.)

Tender Notice

NIT No- 37 to 38/12026-27 Date 01.06.2026

Online Tender for mentioned trelow are being invited. The Tender have been uploaded on the e-Procurement system of Public Works Department on the Portal www.mptenders.gov.in Tender details are as below:-

S. No.	Tender No.	District	Nature of work	Name of work	Call No.	Cost of Project (PAC) (Rs. In lakh)	Earnest Money
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1	2026_PWDR_B_511926_1	Vidisha	Constuction Work	Construction of Pipalayahat Bamankhedhi Khiriyaa Dangi road length 1.50 km	IInd	92.04	92040.00
2	2026_PWDR_B_511962_1	Vidisha	Maintenance of Road	STMC of Karariya Shamshabad Road - Length 34.00 Km., Kurwai Bhonrasa Crossing to Rusiya Sadara Kemkhedi Pikhon Arnot Kirwaya Berkhedhi Road Length - 5.00 Km., Pownala to Chataua Road Length - 7.00 Km. Total Length = 46.00 Km.	IInd	225.75	225750.00
Total						317.79	

The document can only be purchased online from the above website after making online payment. The last date & time for purchase of Document online is Dated 19.06.2026 up to (17:30.) Detailed NIT and other details can be viewed on the above mentioned portal. Amendments to NIT, if any, would be published on website only, and not in newspaper.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer
PWD. Division Vidisha

G-13886/26



**GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE**

Sl. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP./AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD CORP./AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	MUNICIPAL COMMITTEE, KARNALI	2ND TIME TENDER FOR CONSTRUCTION OF FIVE PUBLIC TOILETS AT VARIOUS LOCATIONS IN MUNICIPAL COMMITTEE AREA UNDER SPH4/2.B AT PC KARNALI - 1 WORK	01.06.2026 01.06.2026	Rs. 64,53,272/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	982401233 municipalcommitteekarnali@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No. 45915/HR

**NORTHERN RAILWAY
NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION**

Senior Divisional Commercial Manager/Freight, Delhi Division, Northern Railway, in terms of Railway Board letter no. 2022/TC(FM)/10/04 dated 13.06.2022 and Railway Board's letter no. 2024/RS(G)/779/7 (E3471089) dated: 13.08.2024, invites bids through e-Auction (www.ireps.gov.in) for leasing of parcel space of SLR compartments and VPs (on round trip basis) for a period of three years as per detail and schedule given below:-

S. No.	Date & time of e-Auction	Assets to be auctioned
1.	11.06.2026 at 10:30 am	12005 (F1), 12011(F1), 12013(F1), 12015(F1), 12045(F1), 12265(F1), 12425(F1), 12428(F1), 12442(F1), 12481(F1, R1), 12650(F1), 12802(F1), 12918(F1), 14014(F1), 15026(F1), 15530(F1), 15726 (F1), 22450 (F1).
2.	16.06.2026 at 10:30 am	12004 (F1), 12017 (F1), 12040 (F1), 12055 (F1), 12057 (F1), 12060(F1) (MON, TUE), 12060(F1) (WED, THU, FRI, SAT), 12368(F1), 12448(F1), 12455 (F1), 12963 (F1), 13066 (F1), 13252(F1), 14164 (F1), 14679(F1), 14681 (F1, R1), 15035 (F1, F2, R1), 22461 (F1), 22950(F1).

Important notes:
1. For more information, requirement and various aspects regarding these e-Auctions, interested bidders are advised to visit https://www.ireps.gov.in/html/helpdesk/learning_centre.html (e-Auction leasing section). 2. Railway Administration reserves the full and absolute rights to short terminate these contracts at any point of time and/or for taking any decision regarding the discontinuation/continuation of these contracts with modified/additional terms and conditions depending upon the continuation/discontinuation of these trains or commencement of new train services.

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 1914/2026

Govt. of Haryana

Advertisement for filling up the posts of Senior Resident Maharishi Chyawan Medical College & Rao Tula Ram Hospital, Koriawas, Narnaul

Recruitment Information
Fifteen (59) posts of Senior Resident are proposed to be filled up on Tenure (अस्थायी) basis for Maharishi Chyawan Govt. Medical College & Rao Tula Ram Hospital, Koriawas, Narnaul. The tenure for posts Senior Resident will be for 01 (One) year only extendable up to a maximum 03 (Three) years, subject to satisfactory work and conduct report.
The other details like essential qualification, pay scales, fees, application form & other terms and conditions may be downloaded from the website (www.gmcemwata.ac.in) of SHKM GMC, Nalhar, Nuh.
The application form complete in all respect may be sent to O/o Director, Maharishi Chyawan Govt. Medical College & Rao Tula Ram Hospital, Koriawas, Narnaul, District Mahendgarh, State - Haryana (Pin Code - 123001) latest by 19/06/2026 (during office working hours 09:00 AM up to 05:00 PM) through Registered/Speed post & By Hand. No application beyond the stipulated time period will be considered. The date of Scrutiny & interview will be updated on website i.e. www.gmcemwata.ac.in later on.

Sd/-
Director
Maharishi Chyawan Govt. Medical College & Rao Tula Ram Hospital, Koriawas, Narnaul, Haryana

No. 45912/HR



ANDHRA PRADESH STATE CIVIL SUPPLIES CORPORATION LIMITED
(A State Government Undertaking)
Head Office: 10-152/1, Ashok Nagar, Bandar Road, Kanuru Vijayawada-520007

TENDER NOTIFICATION
Tender No: PDS/QR Code Zip Tags/2026-27 Date: 05-06-2026
APSCSL invites online tenders through NeML platform for "Appointment of suppliers for supply of 72,000 Nos of QR Code printed Security Seals/Zip Tags) with packing @ 5,000 pieces per carton for tracking the rice filled in 50 Kg gunny bags and rice filled in 25 kg PP Bags to be supplied under the Schemes of Mid Day Meal (MDM), Hostels & Other Welfare Institutions of Government of Andhra Pradesh. For a period of 10 Months @ 7,20,000 tags each month."
Interested tenderers may visit website www.apscsl.in or www.neml.in to view and download tender documents at free of cost. Those who are interested to participate in tender can contact the Customer Service Group on phone numbers (+91-22) – 48810500 / 9962059599 / 9032429420 Or Email: askus@neml.in. Last date for online registration and completion of formalities for submitting the online tenders shall be up to 16/06/2026 by 5.00 PM.

Sd/- VC & Managing Director



**उत्तर प्रदेश आवास एवं विकास परिषद
विद्युत वृत्त**
आफिस कार्यालय, (प्रथम तह) सेक्टर-9, बुधवार योजना, जयपुर.
Email: upavpselect@gmail.com

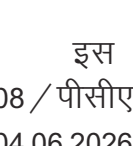
पत्र सं०-509/M-6 ED-11/46 दिनांक-04.06.2026

ई-निविदा सूचना
अधोहस्ताक्षरी द्वारा सिद्धार्थ विहार योजना, गाजियाबाद के सेक्टर-10 में नियोजित भूखण्डों के क्षेत्र में वाह्य विद्युत्तीकरण कार्य के अन्तर्गत एच०टी०/एल०टी० लाइन (भूमिगत), ट्रान्सफार्मेशन एवं स्पीड लाइट के कार्य हेतु परिषद में विद्युत्/यांत्रिक कार्यों हेतु अर्ह श्रेणी में पंजीकृत एवं अनुमोदी फर्मों से ई-निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं, जो कि टू-बिड प्रणाली के अन्तर्गत ई-प्रोक्योरमेंट सोल्यूशन प्रणाली द्वारा दिनांक 09.07.2026 को खोली जायेगी। शेष नियम व शर्त परिषद की वेबसाइट www.upavp.com एवं एच०आई०सी० की वेबसाइट <https://etender.up.nic.in> तथा अधिशासी अभियन्ता, विद्युत् खण्ड-द्वितीय, उ०प्र० आवास एवं विकास परिषद, गाजियाबाद के कार्यालय में देखी जा सकती है।
(सी०पी० सिंह)
अधीक्षण अभियन्ता (वि०यू०)



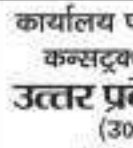
यू.पी. प्रोजेक्ट्स कारपोरेशन लिमिटेड
(उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार का उपकरण)
कार्यालय: परियोजना प्रबंधक, निगम इकाई-26, मकान नं०-1/7400A, A-1 कोलोनी, सोफिया गल्ल सीनियर सेक्टर, सहारनपुर-247001
ई-मेल - pm26saharanpur@gmail.com, GST No- 09AAACU3393F128, दृष्टांक 0132-2614701
पत्रांक- 313/पी.सी.एल./पी०एम०-26/सहारनपुर/ई-टेंडर, दिनांक- 04.06.2026

अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना
इस कार्यालय के निविदा सं०-02, 03, 04, 05, 06, 07 एवं 08/पीसीएल/पीएम / यूनिट-26/सहारनपुर / 2026-27, दिनांक-04.06.2026 द्वारा ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। उक्त ई-निविदा <http://etender.up.nic.in> की वेबसाइट पर दिनांक 05.06.2026 से 15.06.2026 के अपराह्न 12:00 बजे तक डाउनलोड/अपलोड की जा सकती है।
ई-निविदा से सम्बन्धित अन्य विवरण, नियम एवं शर्त कारपोरेशन की वेबसाइट website-https://uprojects.upscd.gov.in पर भी दिनांक 05.06.2026 से देखी जा सकती हैं।



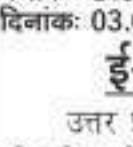
उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार का उपकरण
कार्यालय: परियोजना प्रबंधक, निगम इकाई-26, मकान नं०-1/7400A, A-1 कोलोनी, सोफिया गल्ल सीनियर सेक्टर, सहारनपुर-247001
ई-मेल - pm26saharanpur@gmail.com, GST No- 09AAACU3393F128, दृष्टांक 0132-2614701
पत्रांक- 313/पी.सी.एल./पी०एम०-26/सहारनपुर/ई-टेंडर, दिनांक- 04.06.2026

अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना
इस कार्यालय के निविदा सं०-02, 03, 04, 05, 06, 07 एवं 08/पीसीएल/पीएम / यूनिट-26/सहारनपुर / 2026-27, दिनांक-04.06.2026 द्वारा ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। उक्त ई-निविदा <http://etender.up.nic.in> की वेबसाइट पर दिनांक 05.06.2026 से 15.06.2026 के अपराह्न 12:00 बजे तक डाउनलोड/अपलोड की जा सकती है।
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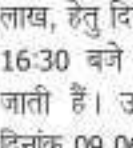
**उत्तर प्रदेश आवास एवं विकास परिषद
विद्युत वृत्त**
आफिस कार्यालय, (प्रथम तह) सेक्टर-9, बुधवार योजना, जयपुर.
Email: upavpselect@gmail.com

पत्र सं०-509/M-6 ED-11/46 दिनांक-04.06.2026



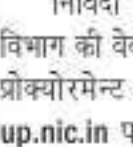
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आफिस कार्यालय, (प्रथम तह) सेक्टर-9, बुधवार योजना, जयपुर.
Email: upavpselect@gmail.com

पत्र सं०-509/M-6 ED-11/46 दिनांक-04.06.2026



उदयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, राजस्थान

डेटा :- 02/06/2026

क्र. :- F-2(01)Act/Contract/2026-27/70 - 72

ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या :- 18/2026-27

उदयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, उदयपुर द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्य में बिल्फेक्ट लाईसिलिटी अवधि के लिये जो कि निविदा प्रपत्र में अंकित है के लिये उपयुक्त श्रेणी में एजीक्यूटिव सेवेदको से निविदा प्रपत्र में ई-टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से ऑनलाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है :-

निविदा कार्यों की कुल लागत	रुपये 130.00 लाख (01 कार्य)
ऑनलाईन निविदा प्रपत्र डाउनलोड/अपलोड करने की अवधि	03.06.2026 को प्रातः 10.00 बजे से 29.06.2026 को सांयः 6.00 बजे तक
Online EMD, Tender Fee & Processing Fee जमा कराने की तिथी	03.06.2026 को प्रातः 10.00 बजे से 29.06.2026 को सांयः 6.00 बजे तक
ऑनलाईन निविदा खोलने की तिथी	30.06.2026 को प्रातः 11.00 बजे

विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाइट urban.rajasthan.gov.in/uitauidapdr पर देखा जा सकता है।

युआरएचआई अतिथिदाता - कार्य उदयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण

UBN No. :- ITU26275LSOB00070

हज्जत मुहल्ला/सी/26/4132



GOVT. OF ODISHA
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER
RURAL WORKS CIRCLE: KEONJHAR
eMail: se_newrkjr@rediffmail.com

25001/295/2627

eProcurement Notice for Bridge Works under SBY

Bid Identification No. NCB-06 / RWCKJR/ 2026-27

Date:-30.05.2026

No. 2749

1. Name of the work : Construction of 04 no. bridges under SBY in the District of Keonjhar.
2. No. of work : 04 (Four) Nos.
3. Estimated Cost : As per Annexure in NIT.
4. Class of Contractor (Eligible) : As per Annexure in NIT.
5. Period of Completion : As per Annexure in NIT.
6. Other details :

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender on-line for bidding		Last Date & Time of seeking tender clarification	Date & Time of Opening of Tender in O/O C.C.E.R.W. Circle, Keonjhar	
		From	To		Technical Bid	Financial Bid
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Keonjhar	NCB-06/ RWCKJR/ 2026-27	Di.08.06.26 at 11.00 A.M.	Di.22.06.26 up to 5.00 P.M.	Di.20.05.26 up to 5.00 P.M.	Di.23.06.26 at 11.00 A.M.	Will be intimated later

● Further details can be seen from the website: www.tendersorissa.gov.in

Sd/-
**Chief Construction Engineer,
Rural Works Circle, Keonjhar.**

OIPR- 25001/25177/1/26-27/0007

 GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA		TENDER NOTICE 				
SRL No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP./ AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / ESTD (APPROX) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/CORP./ AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/ CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	MUNICIPAL CORPORATION, SONPAT	CONSTRUCTION OF KASHYAP CHOWK NEAR KALUPUR CHUNGI IN WARD 15 IN M.C. SONPAT+ 3 WORKS	Closing Date 10.06.2026	Rs. 95,70,985/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01302260100 sachinmishra@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.harvnaprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in **No-** 48/2026/RE

JHARKHAND BIJLI VITRAN NIGAM LIMITED

Notice inviting Request for Proposal (RFP) / Expression Of Interest (EOI) for Appointment of Company Secretary in practice or a Firm of Company Secretaries to conduct the Secretarial audit of JBVNL at Headquarter as well as all field offices for the FY 2024-25, 2025-26 & 2026-27 (Extendable upto 2028-29)

Sd/-
Company Secretary

PR 381538 Jharkhand Bijlee Vitran Nigam Ltd(26-27).D

UPID-252081 Date: 03/06/2026
www.upidadv.gov.in

Recruitment Information

Nineteen (19) posts of Junior Residents are proposed to be filled up on Tenure (अवकाश) basis for Maharishi Chyawan Govt. Medical College & Rao Tula Ram Hospital, Koriawar, Narnaul. The tenure for Junior Resident posts will be for six month only extendable up to a maximum 01 (One) year, subject to satisfactory work and conduct report.

The other details like essential qualification, pay scales, fees, application form & other terms and conditions may be downloaded from the website of SHKM GMC, Nalhar, Nuh www.gmcmewat.ac.in.

The application form complete in all respect may be sent to O/o Director, Maharishi Chyawan Government Medical College & Rao Tula Ram Hospital, Koriawar, Narnaul latest by 22/06/2026 (during office working hours 09.00AM up to 05.00 PM) through Registered/Speed post & By Hand. No application beyond the stipulated time period will be considered. The date of Scrutiny & interview will be updated on website i.e. www.gmcmewat.ac.in later on.

Sd/-
Director
Maharishi Chyawan Govt. Medical College &
Rao Tula Ram Hospital, Koriawas,
Narnaul, Haryana

E-TENDER NOTICE (NIT)
(TENDER SPECIFICATION NO CCP-II/1/2026-2027)

Name of Item	Quantity (in Nos.)	Estimated cost (₹)	Average yearly Turn Over of Preceding Three Financial Year (₹)	Earnest Money Deposit (₹)	Cost of tender document including GST (₹)	Last Date & time of online request for Tender and Submission of tender in online & off line mode	Date of opening of Part-I of tender in online and off line mode
LT Pfler Resistant Metering Cubicle	500	30.50 LAKH	91.50 LAKH	0.61 LAKH	2 360	22-06-2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.	23-06-2026 at 15:30 Hrs.

For further details, please visit the website www.ukttenders.gov.in

No. : 398/EE(CM)/UPCL /A-2
Date : 04.06.2026

Superintending Engineer
Corporate (Contract & Procurement-II)

SAVE ELECTRICITY IN THE INTEREST OF THE NATION. Use LED Bulb, Save Electricity (Toll Free No. 1912)
"Pay Electricity bill online 24x7 from www.upcl.org."
(For information on Electricity theft, Informer may report to Toll free No 18001804185/ Fax No 0135-2760911)

SHORT TERM NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Application in the prescribed format eligible contractors for Request for proposal for Performance based Maintenance Contracts (PBMC) mode is invited for following project in two bid systems, (Technical &

SL	Name of works	State	Length	Estimated cost	Cost of RFP	Bid	Contract
----	---------------	-------	--------	----------------	-------------	-----	----------

No.			(in km)	including LC and excluding GST	Document (In Rs.)	Security (In Lakh)	Duration (Month)
1	PBMC work of NH-220 (Old NH-75E) from KM 176.220 to KM 202.9 (Total Length = 26.68) in the state of Jharkhand.	Jharkhand	26.68	1820.97848	10,000/- (RFP) & 1,800 (GST)	18.60	60

Note – GST amount will be paid as per Government Norms applicable from time to time

Important Dates:		
1	Date of Issue of Notice Inviting RFP	27.05.2026
2	Last Date of Receiving Quaries	05.06.2026
3	Pre-Bid Meeting at venue (as mentioned in RFP)	10.06.2026 at 12:30 Hrs
4	Authority Response to Queries Latest by	12.06.2026
5	Period of State of Bid Document	From 01.06.2026 12:00 Hrs to 15.06.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs Through official portal of: https://eprocure.gov.in

6	Bid Due Date	Date 15.06.2026 Up to 17:00 HRS Through official portal of : https://eprocure.gov.in
7	Last date of Physical submission of bid security,	16.06.2026 up to 15:00 HRS

8	Time and Date of Opening Technical Bid (RFP)	Date 16.06.2026 15:00 HRS Through official portal of : https://cprocure.gov.in
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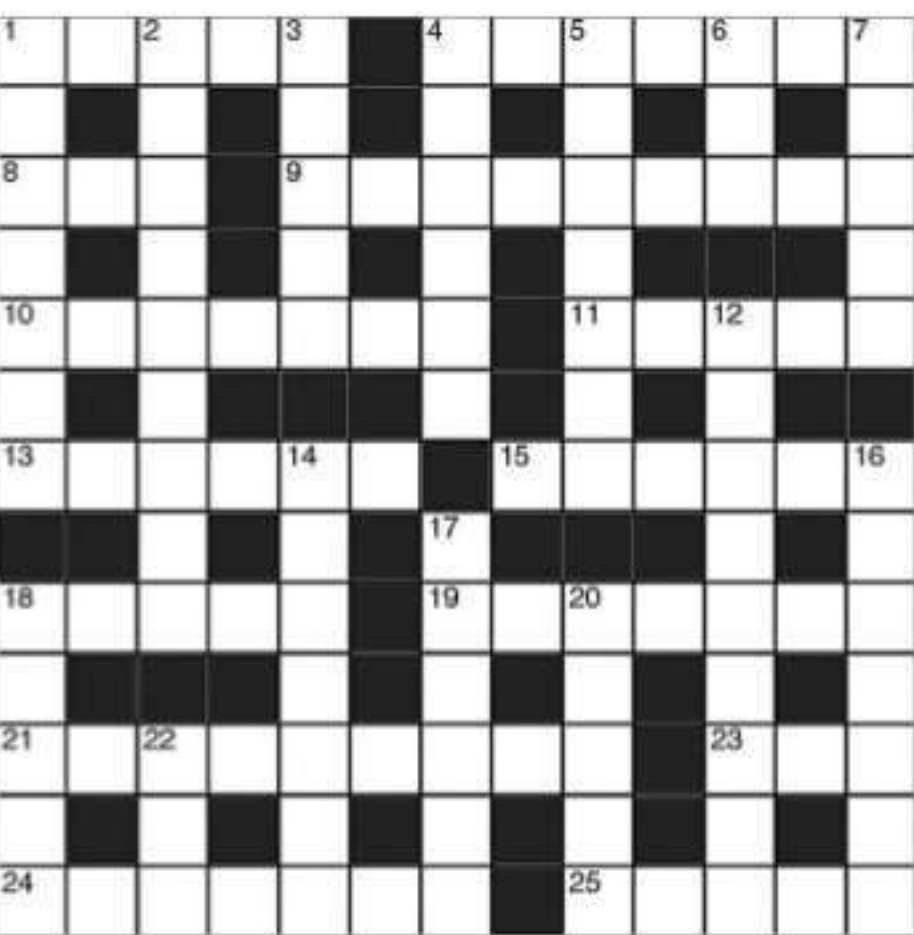
9	Time and Date of Opening Financial Bid	:	To be notify Through official portal of : [https://eprocure.gov.in]
10	Please of Opening of Bids	:	Office of the Chief Engineer, National Highway Wing,

		Jharkhand, Ranchi Through official portal of : [https://eprocure.gov.in]
11	Bid Validity	120 Days From the Bid Due Date

12	Officer Inviting Bids	:	Executive Engineer, National Highway Division, Chaibasa
Executive Engineer,			

PR 381485 (West Singhbhum)26-27°D National Highway Division,Chaibasa.

CROSSWORD



ACROSS
1 A ship with quarters for animals (5)
4 Tried writing to the editor (7)
8 Some wearable indication of Hawaiian hospitality (3)
9 Any word of topless club with topless dance? (9)
10 A loud story; not factual but friendly (7)
11 What might be there in the atmosphere (5)
13 Titled person on the board (6)
15 He doesn't have a quiet retirement (6)
18 Finally dig in (5)
19 Call to get permit? It depends on the head (7)
21 Use face stain to attract (9)
23 Caught or caught on (3)
24 Continued to give the total in a rush (7)
25 Scrap ensues when communist is told to be quiet (5)

DOWN
1 Everyone says it is just a rumour (3,4)
2 Hide pirate; a mean fellow (9)
3 If damp it's unlikely to make much impact (5)
4 It is in here may be that there's choice from two (6)
5 Wave on the ship's doctor (7)
6 Over there among the many onlookers (3)
7 Are sickly under the doctor and gloomy (5)
12 In time he has become an expert (9)
14 It's more his sort of bravery (7)
16 Turned to trade that's new (7)
17 Make a mistake with the charge (6)
18 Conclude there's no getting away from Hades (5)
20 One doesn't have to have them (5)
22 The appeal of love on board ship (3)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6006 **ACROSS:** 1 Go a long way, 8 Cedar, 9 Cellars, 10 Maidens, 11 Owner, 12 Tahiti, 14 Petrol, 17 Plant, 19 Erasing, 21 Springs, 22 Osier, 23 Escalators **DOWN:** 2 Odd fish, 3 Large, 4 Nicest, 5 Welcome, 6 Yearn, 7 Astrologer, 8 Come to pass, 13 Titanic, 15 Rainier, 16 Vessel, 18 Agree, 20 Adopt

JUMBLLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

If you carry your childhood with you, you never ____ - Abraham Sutzkever (6,5)

PTEEE

MOORS

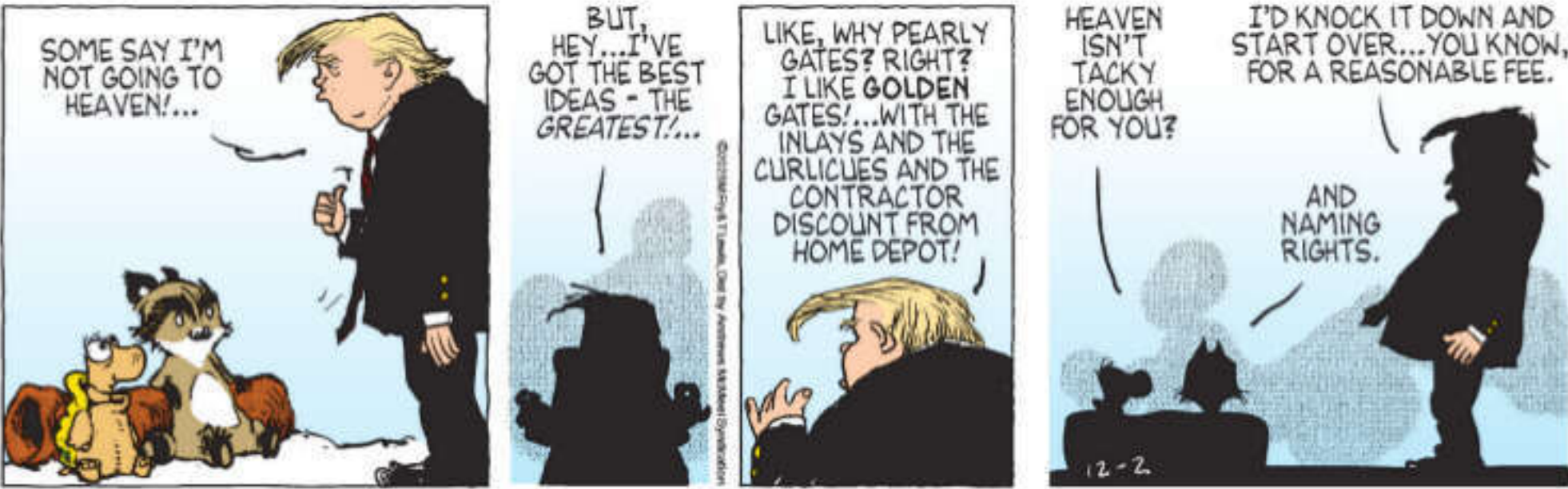
COILED

AELMBM

ABRAHAM SUTZKEVER

ANSWER: If you carry your childhood with you, you never become older.

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 3s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6340

1	7			3				
				9		6		
	5		6	7	4			
5		8						2
	8						1	
3				1				7
		2	3	1	8			
	4		9					
			5		2	6		

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6339

1	8	4	7	3	2	5	9	6
9	7	3	6	4	5	1	8	2
6	5	2	1	9	8	3	4	7
3	2	1	8	7	9	6	5	4
7	6	8	3	5	4	9	2	1
4	9	5	2	1	6	8	7	3
8	4	7	9	6	3	2	1	5
2	1	6	5	8	7	4	3	9
5	3	9	4	2	1	7	6	8

ROYAL STARS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Listen to the advice of someone more experienced. It could be beneficial for you. You might get in a dispute with a friend (or a member of a group) about money, possessions or financial matters. Stay chill. Tonight: Socialise.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Tread carefully today because you might find yourself at odds with someone in authority. But, today, you can talk your way in to and out of anything. Tonight: You're noticed.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Steer clear of controversial subjects as this is the classic day for an argument. This is a great day to make travel plans or discuss legal matters. Tonight: Broaden your horizons.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Money squabbles and issues about shared property, taxes and debt might arise today. Relations with authority figures are excellent. In fact, someone with clout might benefit you today. Tonight: Check your finances.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): For the most part, this can be a favourable day for you. You might be at odds with a partner, friend or someone in authority. Don't ruin your day with this kind of squabble. It's a popular time for you. Enjoy the company of others. Tonight: Listen with courtesy.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Don't get your belly in a rash about issues related to politics, religion, foreign countries or legal matters. However, people will be inclined to listen to you if you want to share your ideas because you look good to everyone. Tonight: Get better organised.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Work-related discussions about budgets, expenses and financial matters will go well today. Issues related to other countries, the law, medicine or politics might create conflict with someone. Tread carefully. Tonight: Enjoy the company of others.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Be patient with family members today, including partners, spouses and close friends, because arguments can arise very easily. Fortunately, family discussions can be practical and productive. Tonight: Relax at home.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Avoid work-related squabbles or arguments related to your health or a pet. It will only drain your energy. This is an excellent day to plan artistic projects, social events, sports and fun times with kids. Go with what works. Tonight: Learn something new.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Parents must be patient with their kids today. Participants in sports and romantic partners must be ready to cut each other some slack. This is a good day to discuss costs of family repairs and make decisions for the future. Tonight: Check your assets.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Today the Moon is in your sign at odds with Mars, which can encourage needless disputes, irritability and rash actions. Don't act too quickly. This is a brief, fleeting influence. Tonight: You're strong.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Be patient with daily contacts today, to avoid mishaps and arguments. It might create later regrets. People never forget insults or rough words said in haste. Focus on home, family and especially a parent or an older family member. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING ATTENDANCE OF DEFENDANT

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./ 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **1.Deepak@Vikram, S/o: Jai Parkash, 2.Surender Pal, S/o: Kuldeep Singh, 3.Manpreet Kaur@Nancy, D/o: Surender Pal, R/o: B-13, Jhilmil Colony, Delhi** have committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 349/2021, U/s: 420/465/468/120B/34 IPC, Police Station Vijay Vihar, Delhi** and it have been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **1.Deepak@Vikram, 2.Surender Pal, 3.Manpreet Kaur@Nancy** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **1.Deepak@Vikram, 2.Surender Pal, 3.Manpreet Kaur@Nancy** have absconded (or are concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **1.Deepak@Vikram, 2.Surender Pal, 3.Manpreet Kaur@Nancy** of **Police Station Vijay Vihar, Delhi** are required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **08.07.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Shagun
Ld. JMFC, North-West,
1st Floor, Room No. 109
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DPI/7185/RD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Arshad S/o Noorddin R/o I-150 Sunder Nagri, Nand Nagri, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in Case **FIR No. 34/2021 U/S 379/411 IPC PS: Nand Nagri, Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Arshad** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Arshad** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Arshad** accused of **FIR No. 34/2021 U/S 379/411 IPC PS: Nand Nagri, Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **31.07.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Deepakshi Rana
JMFC-03, Room No. 19
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/7378/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 (2) (ii) Cr. P.C.

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused persons namely **Rahul Jain Prop. of M/s Navkar Computers R/o 1/2284, Ram Nagar, Shahdara, Delhi**, have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **FIR No. 1487/2019, U/s 138 NI Act.**, has been registered at **P.S. North Rohini, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Rahul Jain** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Rahul Jain** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Rahul Jain FIR No. 1487/2019, U/s 138 NI Act.**, registered at **P.S. North Rohini, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **24.07.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Ebbani Aggarwal
JMFC-03, Room No. 107
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/7094/RD/2026
(Court Notice)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Chander Shekhar Verma @ Raju, S/o Lt. Ramjas, R/o 1/71, Gali No. 01, Rattan Vihar, Kirari, Suleman Nagar, Sultanpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 516/2024, U/s 305/338/336(3)/340(2)/318(4)/61(2)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita-2023, P.S. Shahdara, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Chander Shekhar Verma @ Raju** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Chander Shekhar Verma @ Raju** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Chander Shekhar Verma @ Raju** accused of **FIR No. 516/2024, U/s 305/338/336(3)/340(2)/318(4)/61(2)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita-2023, P.S. Shahdara, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **06.07.2026**.

By Order - Sh. Rahul Saini
Judicial Magistrate First Class-08
Room No. G-06, New Court Building
Karkarduma Courts, Delhi

DP/7402/SHD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING ATTENDANCE OF DEFENDANT

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./ 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Sandeep Shrivash, S/o: Suresh Shrivash, R/o: D-187, Prashant Vihar, Sector-14, Rohini, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 951/2017, U/s: 356/379/411/34 IPC, Police Station Vijay Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sandeep Shrivash** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sandeep Shrivash** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sandeep Shrivash** of **Police Station Vijay Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **31.07.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Shagun
Ld. JMFC, North-West,
1st Floor, Room No. 109
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DPI/7211/RD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Parveen Mishra @ Kanhiya S/o Awadesh Mishra, R/o H.No. B-91, Raghubir Enclave, Nangloi Stand, Najafgarh, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 409/19, U/S 411/34 IPC, PS Dwarka North, Dwarka Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Parveen Mishra @ Kanhiya** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Parveen Mishra @ Kanhiya** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **Parveen Mishra @ Kanhiya** the said accused of **FIR No. 409/19, U/S 411/34 IPC, PS Dwarka North, Dwarka Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **11.08.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Rahul Katara
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06,
South-West Distt., Room No.-514,
Dwarka Courts, New Delhi

DP/7384/DW/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

SEE SECTION 84 BHARTIYA NAGARIK SURKSHA SANHITA

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused Person Namley **Ajay @ Vinay S/o Shyam Singh, R/o 1162, Gali No. 16, Mandoli Extn. Harsh Vihar, Delhi**, have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **FIR No. 20772/2021, U/s 379/411/34 IPC.**, has been registered at **P.S. Welcome, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the Said, **Ajay @ Vinay** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Ajay @ Vinay** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Ajay @ Vinay** of **FIR No. 20772/2021, U/s 379/411/34 IPC.**, has been registered at **P.S. Welcome, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.07.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Deepakshi Rana
Ld. MM-03, Room No.19
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/7289/NE/2026
(Court Notice)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./ 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Sidharth Sharma, S/o: Narendra Sharma, R/o: WZ-133, Vishnu Garden, Delhi, Also at: 223, Chhakhua Wala Aashik, Krishna Place Kotwari, Omkar Ropad, Dehradun Kotwali Dehradun, Uttarakhand** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 31/2023, U/s: 498A IPC, Police Station Dwarka North, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sidharth Sharma** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sidharth Sharma** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sidharth Sharma** of **Police Station Dwarka North, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **25.07.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Ebbani Aggarwal
Ld. JMFC (Mahila Court)-03,
South-West, Room No. 312,
District Court Dwarka New Delhi

DP/7198/DW/2026

UNION TERRITORY OF JAMMU & KASHMIR

OFFICE THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER

PWD (R&B) DIVISION GANDHI NAGAR JAMMU

e-NIT No. DGN/23 of 2026-27

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

For and on behalf of the Lieutenant Governor, Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir e-tenders are invited on percentage basis from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Union Territory of J&K, CPWD, Railways, MES and other State/Central Governments for each of the following works :-

S. No	Name of Work	Name of Division	Advertised cost (Rs. In lakh.)	Cost of Tender document (In Rs.)	Earnest Money (In Rs.)	Time Allowed for completion	Time and date of opening of tender	Class of Contractor
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1.	Repair & Renovation / Up-gradation of Building of Electric Central Stores Complex Narwal Jammu (Under Capex Budget 2026-27)	PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar	86.37	1500	172740 (2% of the Advertised Cost)	06 Months	(1200 Hrs) on or after 17-06-2026	"A" Class

Position of AAAA-
Position of TS :-
Project Authority :-
Major Head of Account :-

Accorded by Superintending Engineer Procurement Circle JPDCJ Jammu vide order No. SE/PRJ/AA/32 of 2026 dated 28-04-2026 amounting to Rs. 88.99 Lacs.
Sanctioned by Superintending Engineer PWD (R&B) Circle South Jammu vide order No. 25 of May 2026 dated 21-05-2026 amounting to Rs.86.37 Lacs
Superintending Engineer Procurement Circle JPDCJ Jammu
Under Capex Budget 2026-27.

The Bidding documents Consisting of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, Drawings, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen/downloaded from the departmental website <http://jkenders.gov.in> per below schedule :-

1	Date of Issue of Tender Notice	02-06-2026
2	Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 02-06-2026 to 16-06-2026, 1800 Hrs
3	Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting	08-06-2026 at 1300 Hrs. in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar Jammu
4	Bid submission Start Date	02-06-2026
5	Bid Submission End Date	16-06-2026 upto 1800 Hrs
6	Date & time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	17-06-2026 on or after 1200 Hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar Jammu
7	Date & time of opening of Financial Bids (Online)	To be notified after technical bid evaluation is completed

- Bids must be accompanied with cost of Tender document in shape of e-challan through Treasury indicating Treasury Voucher No. & date, e-NIT No. and name of work duly crediting to 0059 (Revenue) favoring Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar Jammu and upload the same to treasury challan/receipt. Earnest money-Bid security in shape of CDR/DRBG pledged to Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar Jammu. The CDR/DRBG shall be valid for 45 Days beyond the bid validity period. The original intimations in respect of cost of documents, EMD and relevant documents of LI to be submitted to the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar Jammu at the time of allotment.
- The electronic bidding system would not allow any late submission of bids after due date and time as per server time. Bidders may modify their bids by uploading their request for modification before the deadline for submission of bids. For this, the bidder need not to make any additional payment towards the cost of tender document. For bid modification and consequential re-submission, the bidder is not required to withdraw his bid submitted earlier. The last modified bid submitted by the bidder within the bid submission time shall be considered as the bid. For this purpose, modification/withdrawal by other means will not be accepted. In online system of bid submission, the modification and consequential- submission of bids is allowed any number of times. The bidders may withdraw his bid by uploading their request before the deadline for submission of bids; however, if the bid is withdrawn, the re-submission of the bid is not allowed. No bid shall be modified or withdrawn after the deadline of submission of bids.
- The date and time of opening of Financial-Bids shall be notified on Web Site www.jkenders.gov.in and conveyed to the bidders automatically through an e-mail message on their e-mail address. The Financial-bids of responsive bidders shall be opened online in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar Jammu. The date for same shall be intimated separately.
- The bids for the work shall remain valid for a period of 120 days from the date of opening of Technical bids.
- The earnest money shall be forfeited, if-
 - Any bidder/tenderer withdraws his bid/tender during the period of bid validity or makes any modification in the terms and conditions of the bid.
 - Failure of Successful bidder to furnish the required performance security within specified time period after issue of letter of acceptance.
 - Failure of successful bidder to execute the agreement on same day of allotment of work contract as per Chief Engineer PW (R&B) Department Jammu's Circular No. CEJ/G/12660-87 dated 07-10-2021.
- Instruction to bidders regarding e-tendering process.
 - Bidders are advised to download bid information manual from the "Downloads" option as well as from "Bidders Manual Kit" on website www.jkenders.gov.in to acquaint bid submission process.
 - To participate in bidding process, bidders have to get "Digital Signature Certificate (DSC)" as per Information Technology Act-2000. Bidders can get digital certificate from any approved vendors.
 - The bidders have to submit their bids online in electronic format with digital Signature. No financial bid will be accepted in physical form.
 - Bids will be opened online as per time schedule mentioned above.
 - Bidders must ensure to upload scanned copy of all necessary documents mentioned in NIT and SBD with technical bid online.

DrP No. DIP3-3144/26 Date 04.06.2026

Sd/-
(Er. Karanjeet Singh)
Executive Engineer, PWD (R&B) Division Gandhi Nagar



JUNE 11-JULY 19

48 TEAMS, 16 CITIES, 3 COUNTRIES

The 2026 FIFA World Cup, spread across the United States, Mexico, and Canada, is the biggest the sport has ever staged. There are the personalities — the players and powerbrokers who have shaped the four years since Qatar. There is the geography — Mexico and the United States have hosted this tournament before — and the nostalgia — of what happened on those pitches. And in this edition, there are some things happening for the first time.

MESSI II

Liberated from burden of history after realising a lifelong dream in Qatar, Argentina's talismanic forward may light up global stage again



Messi's post-2022 journey has unfolded differently. Rather than declining, he has drifted into something mythological - half-footballer, half-symbol.

bodyguard and emotional amplifier. Enzo Fernandez brought swagger. Emiliano Martinez brought madness.

For the first time, Argentina looked like a modern football team instead of a shrine to its own history.

Messi changed, too. The explosive dribbler who once tore through entire mid-fields stopped trying to dominate every second and instead manipulated matches in moments.

A pause. A disguised pass. A glance before a through ball.



Benfica's Gianluca Prestianni (L) was given a six-month ban after covering his mouth to direct homophobic language towards Real Madrid's Vinicius during a Champions League match. REUTERS

Vinicius-Prestianni incident sparks a new red-card rule

Bhuvan Gupta

DON'T HAVE something to hide? Don't cover your mouth when you say it. "That's it, as simple as that," FIFA president Gianni Infantino stated about the new red card rule to be adopted at the 2026 World Cup.

The rule empowers referees to eject players who hide their mouths during run-ins with opponents.

It was a direct consequence of Gianluca Prestianni's dubious conduct towards Vinicius Junior in their February UEFA Champions League face-off.

Moments after netting a stunner, Vinicius alleged racial abuse and was vehemently backed by Real Madrid teammate Kylian Mbappe, who said Prestianni "doesn't deserve to play this competition".

The 20-year-old Benfica forward retorted by claiming the Brazilian "misinterpreted what he thinks he heard", and was eventually handed a six-match ban for homophobic remarks instead. FIFA later extended the ban globally, which meant Prestianni would have missed Argentina's first two World Cup games had he been picked in the squad.

Racism and homophobia lie in the same offence category under Article 14 of UEFA's disciplinary regulations, and the striker's mouth-shielding with his jersey would certainly not have aided the ethics and disciplinary investigator appointed to probe the incident. This was not the first time something of the sort had transpired.

In March 2021, Slavia Prague defender Ondrej Kudela hid his mouth while racially abusing Rangers' Glen Kamara in a Europa League clash, and eventually served a 10-match ban.

According to the BBC, Prestianni's unbecoming words marked the 20th time Vinicius called out racist abuse against him since arriving at the Bernabeu in 2018.

The International Football Association Board's (IFAB) Law

EXPERT SPEAK



"Covering the mouth means you are doing something potentially very wrong."

PIERLUIGI COLLINA, HEAD OF FIFA'S REFEREES COMMITTEE

12 stipulates a straight red card for players "using offensive, insulting or abusive language and/or action(s)".

Referees rely on what they hear, their assistants and the video assistant referee's (VAR) inputs, as well as players' reactions and the context of the incident.

Challenge for referees

With the new rule, the referee will have more discretion in trying to ascertain the nature of conversation between opposing players. Banter is not a problem, but if the official sees a player covering their mouth with a hand, arm or shirt in a confrontation, a send-off is prescribed.

It remains to be seen how this would play out, as footballers routinely cover their mouths during matches. Further, given language barriers across nationalities, mishearing is a possibility. The onus would thus be on referees to adapt their decision-making from clear proof to interpretation.

It is worth noting that the aforementioned Law 12 also has a yellow card provision for players covering their faces with masks and the like, though that pertains to celebration of a goal. The mouth-covering directive, in a way, clubs the two aspects as a racism safeguard, for that is a malady best nipped in the bud.

NOSTALGIA

Bebeto's cradle celebration: Beautiful, simple and a tradition for new fathers

Sandip G

TWO AFTERNOONS before the quarterfinals against the Netherlands, Brazil coach Carlos Alberto Pereira told his men to unwind. Some of them hit the swimming pool, somewhat to explore Dallas. But striker Beбето did not leave his room, and pranced restlessly in the corridor, waiting for the hotel phone to ring.

Hours passed, and he went down to the teleoperator and sat with him. His wife Denise was heavily pregnant when he left for the tournament. Soon after he left, she was robbed of her car and Rolex at gunpoint. In the morning his father told him that she was going to the labour. "We were expecting our third child, and I was there with her for the other two," he later told FIFA.

Around sunset, the phone finally buzzed. It was his mother, who broke the news that a son, Matheus, was born. Hours

later, broadcast giants Globo arranged a video call with Beбето, his wife and newborn, through an expensive video-phone device. "I broke down in tears and kept crying for minutes. I couldn't talk, I was so emotional because I was not there with them," he would say.

Baby-faced assassin

The media called the father baby-faced assassin, for his fresh-faced looks. He played in a front-two with the hubristic Romario, the lead ace who scored with a sniper's precision but fitfully volatile. Beбето's role was to facilitate Romario's fearsome strikes, to create space by dragging the defenders with his clever runs and finessed passes.

The management was initially worried because of they were not the best friends, an animosity that flared in the leagues of Brazil and Spain, and they were of contrasting personalities (Bebeto is a family type, stay at home. I'm a street

cat, Romario once said), but on the turf, they telegraphed each other's designs with a clairvoyant's intuition.

Romario was all the rage in the 1994 World Cup, but the afternoon in Dallas was Beбето's. First, he sprinted nearly 30 yards to pick a cross from his half, conjured a perfectly weighted pass onto Romario marauding into the box, which he smacked on one bounce to the nets. Minutes later came a glorious goal and an iconic moment in the World Cup. Beбето's cradle celebration, the ode to his son.

A stray header from Branco bubbled towards Romario halfway in the Dutch box. They vociferously claimed an offside, Romario certainly was. But he didn't touch the ball, and the Dutch left it unattended. Beбето sprang onto it, controlled the ball with his right thigh, slid away from a Dutch defender's stretched leg from behind, ran three measured



Bebeto (C) is joined by Romario (R) and Mazino for the cradle celebration after he scored a goal against the Dutch. SCREENGRAB

strides, rounded off the goal-keeper Ed De Goey and slammed the ball into the empty nets.

He recollected the sequence: "Romario was offside. I looked at their last man and thought, 'I'm not offside.' I was off with everything I had. At that moment, I pleaded with God to allow me to score a goal against Holland in homage to

my son," he said.

Beaming, he galloped to the touchline, contorting his arms like a cradle and rocking it, as though he were cradling an imaginary baby. He turned to his left, he saw Romario doing the same; he gazed to the right, midfielder Mazinho was doing the same. Mazinho had two sons — Thiago and Rafinha. Thiago (Alcantara), a silken

"It doesn't matter where I go in the world, everyone wants to talk to me about that celebration. I still get emotional talking about it. It means so much to me, my family."

BEBETO ON THE CELEBRATION

midfielder, chose the nationality of his mother and won trophies for Spain; he was Pep Guardiola's midfield conduit in Bayern Munich. Rafinha, barely one then, played for Barcelona and Brazil. Romario had a nine-month-old son too — Romarinho, who also became a footballer, turning out for Fluminense among others. Romario, burying all the dif-

ferences with Beбето, hugged him and whispered, or so the myth goes, "I love you." "It was so beautiful. It was a simple gesture. But I didn't know it would become this famous," Beбето told FIFA.

So famous that it is often the first entry into any list of goal celebrations, recreated faithfully by every footballer who became a dad thereafter. The move was unrehearsed, he would say. He put it poetically: "When I made that celebration maybe it was like Matheus was baptised by God." He has reprised a hundred times to excited strangers in different corners of the world. "It doesn't matter where I go in the world, everyone wants to talk to me about that celebration. I still get emotional talking about it. It means so much to me, my family."

But he gets emotional each time someone whips up the moment. He calls it the Matheus goal. And his favourite goal. "I scored a lot of goals in

my career — wonder goals, goals that won titles — but everyone only remembers the Matheus goal. And that's one I remember the most too," he said.

It became more than a goal and celebration — it became a tradition for new fathers. And what of Matheus. He became an attacking midfielder good enough to turn up for Portuguese club Sporting CP, now playing for the Tampa Bay Rowdies in Florida.

"Football was all he was ever interested in. I think his first ever word was probably 'football,'" Beбето told *Globo*. But the son never became the player his father was, or replicated his father's famous celebration himself, even though he is a father himself. "For some reason, I have never felt like doing it," he told *Fox Sports*. As an afterthought he added: "Maybe, before I retire, I would one day!"

Then, the most fabled celebration of all time would complete a full circle.

Indonesia Open: Sindhu loses to An Seyoung for the tenth time

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, June 4

THE LAST time PV Sindhu took a set off World No 1 and Olympic champion An Seyoung was in April of 2023. With her 10th loss to the era's greatest shuttler, a 21-17, 21-15 straight sets put-down at the Super 1000 Indonesia Open, there is danger of a fatalistic feeling taking root: that she might never beat the Korean. It would go against what made Sindhu India's highest achieving shuttler, and the legacy of her 5 big medals – Rio silver and the two bronzes and silvers at World's or the 2019 title, where she did not allow the greatness of her opponents from eventually beating them anyway.

Her absolute self-assurance started with the Chinese she decimated, and culminated in her greatest win, the 2019 quarterfinals against Tai Tzu-ying at the Basel World's. If she could solve the Tai Tzu-ying riddle, she ought to back herself to one day – soon – beat An Seyoung too. The 21-17, 21-15 however was nowhere close to how to get that done. Coach Irwansyah will need to play the part that Pulella Gopichand did in guiding her across the Tzu-ying hurdle with pinpoint inputs in shot selection.

Against Seyoung, Sindhu needs to believe herself, that she can get into a 19-19 situation, after which that decisive point is snared away, with strategy. Right this moment, Sindhu doesn't seem to believe she can.

Last week in Singapore and again to a lesser extent in Indonesia, Sindhu showed she has the weapons to trouble the Korean. Make no mistake, the straight set margins do not give a proper picture of how much, she can put Seyoung on the edge in the early part of the first set. But 17, 15 are pretty accurate scores at explaining how quickly Sindhu loses hope, fades away when Seyoung hits the next gear.

INDIA V AFGHANISTAN ONE-OFF TEST

Giant-killers with white ball aim to impress with red one

Afg are hindered by a sparse calendar, but a record of four wins from 12 proves India can't take them lightly

Lalith Kalidas
New Chandigarh, June 4

RAIS AHMADZAI remembers a "long, long drive" with his young Afghan teammates in Zimbabwe from well over a decade ago, as if it were yesterday. It was August 2009. Hoping on what he now recollects was a small van, Ahmadzai and the Afghanistan cricket team were travelling 250 kilometres from Harare, chasing history. Nerves jangling, they were approaching something they had never really prepared for before — all-white kits, a red cricket ball, and the status of First-Class cricketers awaiting at the Mutare Sports Club.

"I was so excited to wear a white kit, to have the white floppy on my head," Ahmadzai, now head coach of the Afghanistan A and U-19 teams, tells The Indian Express from Kabul.

"I remember us talking in the van... that at the end of the match, our cricket profiles on the internet would recognise us as First-Class cricketers," he recounts.

Novices in the longer format, Afghanistan walked away with a draw against a stronger Zimbabwe XI, though Ahmadzai now scoffs at their unlettered approach on debut. "We had no idea how to play the red ball. There was no temperament. Everyone was in a hurry."

Five months after that Zimbabwean initiation, Afghanistan won the ICC Intercontinental Cup – an erstwhile First-Class development tour-

namment – at the first time of asking, beating Scotland in the final. The first batch of Test caps arrived in under 10 years when Asghar Afghan's men took the field against India in Bengaluru in 2018.

On Saturday, Hashmatullah Shahidi's side will contest Afghanistan's second Test against India at the PCA Stadium in New Chandigarh. Ahmadzai traces a discernible contrast between sides from back in his time and now. "Match fees, contracts, good facilities, a clinical approach to batting and bowling in red-ball cricket."

If basic facilities were scarce 17 years ago, the lack of structured game time continues to hinder Afghanistan's cricket story across formats.

"We have more experience now. But we need to play more Tests. We play only one or two per year," skipper Shahidi said in the pre-match press conference on Thursday.

Having played only 12 in eight years hasn't helped. Afghanistan are considered giant-killers in the white-ball formats, reaching the 2024 T20 World Cup semifinals and coming close to the same stage at the ODI World Cup a few months earlier. But as far as Tests are concerned, even their early success – four wins in 12 matches – has been overlooked.

"We remain among one of the few teams to have won in just their second-ever Test appearance. For a team that hardly plays a Test or two a year, four wins are a significant



Rahmanullah Gurbaz (L) with his teammates after practice session in New Chandigarh. KAMLESHWAR SINGH

achievement. The real test will begin when we get to play six to eight matches a year," says Ahmadzai.

White-ball success and the emergence of global franchise league stars such as Rashid Khan, Mohammad Nabi and Rahmanullah Gurbaz have paved the way for Afghanistan's red-ball aspirations.

Cricket grounds in Jalalabad and Nangarhar, 150 kilometres from the capital Kabul, have gained prominence in hosting the Ahmad Shah Abadi tournament – the annual First-Class event in the country.

"We have a very strong First-Class structure. Good players from the age-groups are being picked to play in the tournament that is now contested by four teams," Ahmadzai informs.

The glare of T20 cricket that lifts players from obscurity is inescapable, but Ahmadzai stresses that the national board is steadily backing the develop-

ment of cricketers proficient in the longest format.

"Most of the players hail from very poor families. Because of what T20s have done for some of them, everyone now wants to participate in such leagues. As a Test-playing nation, we must also be able to provide the players with good contracts and inform the selection committees that a good Test cricketer will be able to contribute to other formats as well."

But Afghanistan has to fight for recognition during diminishing red-ball international windows outside the World Test Championship cycle, at a time when even India are navigating a slow-paced Test transition under Shubman Gill.

Hope and a wave of names float for Afghanistan from the month-long camp for Test players in Kabul and subsequent three-day matches in Jalalabad.

"I am excited by the way Sediqullah Atal and Rahmanullah Zadran played in the practice games in preparation for the India tour," says Ahmadzai, counting on the young batters to leave an impression.

A strong showing against the two-time WTC finalists could impress the ICC board this week, but pathways for a structured Test cricket calendar still demand more work.

"The quality of home pitches needs to improve. But if we want to work more, the Test in India will be a good challenge," says Ahmadzai. "We will be waiting for the next ICC meeting to see how many Tests they will give us in the new cycle."

A van ride to Mutare had set the red-ball rolling in Afghanistan 17 years ago. The frontier has shifted by a few yards, from a fight for admission to taking on the big boys for regular time on the Test cricket roster.

Gaikwad likely to replace Kohli in the ODI squad



Ruturaj Gaikwad is likely to be added to ODI squad. REUTERS

Devendra Pandey
Mumbai, June 4

RUTURAJ GAIKWAD is likely to get picked as Virat Kohli's replacement for three ODI series against Afghanistan whereas Rajat Patidar might be looked in for India A squad which will travel to Sri Lanka for tri-series involving Afghanistan.

The senior selection committee will have to make last minute changes after Kohli was ruled out for Afghanistan series starting from June 13 in Dharamsala due to a hamstring injury that he picked during the IPL final on Sunday. It is learnt that Kohli has been advised a minimum of two-week rest and though he may be fit in time for the last ODI on June 20, the selectors are unlikely to include him for the series.

Gaikwad was earlier added to India A squad after Riyan Parag had gotten injured during IPL. The formal announcement is expected soon.

Meanwhile, during Royal Challengers Bengaluru's successful chase in the final against Gujarat Titans in Ahmedabad, Kohli is understood to have faced slight discomfort on his hamstring and needed a bit of medical attention. Though he continued to bat without any struggle, further tests have revealed an injury to his hamstring. Since he has been advised two weeks rest, Kohli would be racing against to be immediately match fit. And more over, India

have a busy ODI calendar ahead with India set to travel to England in July for a white-ball series that includes three ODIs.

Apart from Kohli, when the selectors sit down on Saturday to select India's T20 squads for the tour of UK and Asian Games, they may have to take a call on Rohit Sharma's availability for the Afghanistan series. The opener, despite struggling with a hamstring injury and missing a fair portion of Mumbai Indians fixtures, has been included in India's ODI squad. But as mentioned by chairman of selectors Ajit Agarkar, his availability depends on him clearing the fitness test. As things stand, there hasn't been an update on Rohit's fitness test.

In case Rohit isn't able to clear the fitness test, then the selectors will hand a recall to Yashasvi Jaiswal, who was the third-choice opener in the last two series. Though he scored his maiden ODI century in the last match he played, for the series against Afghanistan, the selectors chose Ishan Kishan as the back-up opener. But Jaiswal, with a compact game is seen as an exciting prospect and a strong candidate to open alongside captain Shubman Gill.

Apart from Kohli and Rohit, there are also concerns around Hardik Pandya. Since the IPL, where he did sit out twice because of back issue. Like Rohit, he is also expected to give a fitness test and only if he is cleared to bowl, will be made part of the team.

● NORWAY CHESS

‘Would’ve loved to have some friends’: Pragg on life on road

Amit Kamath
Oslo, June 14

AT SOME point over the last few months, R Praggnanandhaa sat down to take stock of the year that had been. 2025 had been a long year. But also a good year, one with success on the board. Chasing a spot in the Candidates tournament via the FIDE Circuit route meant he had to play relentlessly. While taking stock, Pragg noticed that there was a phase when he travelled to seven countries in a span of three months.

That's something he's looking to avoid this year.

"I'm trying to keep it a bit more light this year," Praggnanandhaa tells Indian media in Oslo in an interaction on the second rest day of the Norway Chess tournament. Then, a smile appears on his face when he remembers the commitments he's already made for 2026. "I'm still probably gonna play almost all the tournaments, but I will probably skip like the Esports World Cup. At some point, you just have to prioritise."

This need for prioritising comes from the realisation that relentless chess left him mentally burnt out last year.

"I'll try to play less and have breaks in between. Last year was – even though the results went my way – it was a bit too much. So much of chess," says the 20-year-old in a moment of candor. "At some point, you're just burnt out. You don't have the energy. Even if you have physical energy, you just don't have the mental energy to do the same thing pretty much in every tournament. Having the same routine gets tiring at some point. It just becomes automatic that you just don't enjoy it anymore."

He says he has some hobbies away from the chess board which he pursues. But for now his life revolves around chess. "Sometimes I do feel like I focus too much on chess. Certainly, I think having a different hobby, could help chess as well. There are some things that I want to try in the future," he admits. What things? "Sometimes you just read something and you're



R Praggnanandhaa is competing in Norway Chess. NORWAY CHESS

excited. I want to try this thing," he says without specifying.

All the relentless travel that the top Indian chess prodigies do comes with a rider. Their life in some of these picturesque countries revolves around the playing hall and the hotel rooms. The only time they really see any of the sights of those countries is when they head for a daily walk that's baked into their routines now.

"You are not going to these countries to just have a look at the place. You are going there to fight in every tournament, which are usually super strong. So it is mentally tiring. But I know it is me that signed up for all these tournaments."

Mentally tiring

Ask Praggnanandhaa what he enjoys about the sport now that he's accomplished so much and he speaks of how he still enjoys playing the game.

"Whenever I sit at the board, I just enjoy it," he says before adding: "It just depends on tournament to tournament. Like at Norway Chess, the format is so exciting that I'm just happy to play. Also, this field is super strong. I mean, there are tournaments where the goal is simple, just to try and win the tournament. But in some tournaments, you are just there to enjoy."

Last year, Pragg and Gukesh had spoken about how going

back home to Chennai had started to feel like a vacation for them because they would spend most of their life jetsetting around the world. There is a sense that India's young prodigies sacrificed a part of normal childhoods to do this.

Ask him whether he spends any time in Chennai with Gukesh and he quips with a cheeky smile: "I think we look at each other too much in tournaments. We don't want to look at each other's face at all. Usually like if I'm going out, it's usually my sister who is there, my family is there, they're the ones."

But doesn't he look at too much of his sister at home and in tournaments as well? "As a brother and sister, you have to, there's no escape," he chuckles. Pragg admits that he does have a circle of friends from chess back home.

But when the topic comes about having regrets about not living a normal childhood, he says: "If I was doing that, I probably would not be here today. You have to give up certain things for certain things. I don't really regret it, but of course, I would have loved to have some school friends or college friends back home. But when I am going for something much more bigger, I am happy with how things are right now."

(The writer is in Oslo at the invitation of Norway Chess)

Teen Andreeva dismisses Kostyuk to reach French Open final

Reuters
Paris, June 4

RUSSIAN TEENAGER Mirra Andreeva powered into her maiden Grand Slam final with a ruthless 6-1 6-3 victory over Ukraine's Marta Kostyuk in a politically charged French Open semi-final on Thursday. The eighth seed seized control from the outset and never loosened her grip on the contest, overwhelming Kostyuk with her depth and aggression on Court Philippe Chatriot to set up a title clash against compatriot Diana Shnaider or Polish qualifier Maja Chwalinska. As has become customary for Ukrainian players since Russia's invasion of their country in 2022, Kostyuk did not pose for the traditional pre-match photograph with her opponent and there was no handshake at the net before or after the match.

Andreeva, 19, raced into a 4-0 lead in the opening set and barely looked back in the third meeting between the two players, the Ukrainian having won the first two. Kostyuk briefly threatened to make a contest of it in the second set, but the Russian swiftly snuffed out any hopes of a comeback before serving out the match to complete a dominant display.

"I'm still very nervous, very nervous coming to this match as she's had an amazing season, she hadn't lost on clay, so that put pressure," said Andreeva. "She's an amazing player, a tough opponent, so I'm super happy with the way I played. I'm happy I got revenge for the Madrid final, and to reach my first Grand Slam final."

"All of these feelings combined, I've never felt anything like this, I'm very excited about the last match here in Paris."

Kostyuk seemed to struggle with early nerves and windy conditions, handing her opponent the first break with a double fault and an unforced backhand error while Andreeva picked up steam. The Ukrainian was out of sorts but briefly put up a fight in the second set when she broke back for 4-3, only to drop serve in the next game.

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